

Ontario Billboard Business Guide

Planning guide for one digital billboard in Ontario. Checked as of September 21 2026; assumption sources checked September 23 2026.

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Part 0. Read This First

Checked as of September 21 2026.

Labels: VERIFIED (confirmed in an official source), ESTIMATE (our own math from real prices), UNKNOWN (no answer yet; each comes with how to find out).

The one-page answer

GO, with conditions. The math works, but big facts are still open. Gate 1 (Jan 31 2027) and Gate 2 (about Apr 2027) must both pass before the ~\$175,000 build spend. A failed gate means you adjust the plan or stop, at low cost.

What we build. One digital billboard face, 10 ft by 20 ft class (about 3 metres by 6 metres; the real board may be a little smaller to fit a town's rules). It stands on a steel pole and shows six slots in a loop, all day.

Where. First choice: Yonge Street in Richmond Hill, roughly between Highway 7 and Elgin Mills Road. Next choices: East Gwillimbury and Bradford West Gwillimbury. Newmarket is parked, not ruled out.

RULE: Never plan a board in Toronto or next to a highway. Toronto refuses almost all new billboard signs like ours. Highway land belongs to the province, so there is no landlord to rent from. Part 3 has both rules, town by town.

Careful: The biggest open question is UNKNOWN: does the City of Richmond Hill count our kind of land as **Commercial land** (land its rules allow stores and signs on)? If yes, many good spots on Yonge Street can work. If no, none can, on that street. Part 3 explains this; the Toolkit has the six written questions to send the City.

What it costs (ESTIMATE). Building one billboard face costs \$130,000 for a **Smart build** (the cheapest version, fewer extras), \$175,000 likely, and \$225,000 if costs run high. These come from real prices, but no builder has quoted yet. They cover the screen, the pole, the ground work, the permits, and every fee.

You need about \$228,750 in cash and credit before the first ad plays (ESTIMATE). That includes the build cost above, a safety buffer, and a **tax float** (a short wait for a coming tax refund).

Leasing part of the screen instead of buying it drops your own cash needed to about \$128,750, which is \$100,000 less up front. Part 2 shows every line.

What it earns (ESTIMATE). With the board full of ads and running well, the money left before loan payments and tax is:

- Bad year: \$4,396 a year, about \$366 a month.
- Likely year: \$33,116 a year, about \$2,760 a month.
- Good year: \$58,505 a year, about \$4,875 a month.

Part 2 shows the full arithmetic and what a loan does to these numbers.

RULE: Never order the steel or the screen early. Wait until four of six slots are signed and the town permit is issued. This proves people will pay before you spend the big money.

Timeline. About 10 months from today to the first ad, if every gate passes. Target: August 2027.

Careful: Gate 1 requires a formal power request filed with **Alectra**, Richmond Hill's hydro (electricity) utility, by Jan 31 2027. Missing it could push the first ad from August 2027 to later in 2027.

Phase	Dates	What happens	Roughly costs
Phase 0, learn and prove	Oct 2026 to Jan 2027	Decision made, facts confirmed, first sales calls, site walk	\$3,000 to \$9,000
Gate 1	Jan 31 2027	Check: Alectra power request filed, a town has responded in writing, sales interest is real	A checkpoint, no cost
Phase 1, sign and file	Feb to Apr 2027	Lease signed, permit filed, financing lined up, four slots signed	\$10,000 to \$20,000
Gate 2	About Apr 2027	Check: permit issued, financing approved, four of six slots signed	A checkpoint, no cost
Phase 2, build	May to Jul 2027	Foundation, pole, screen, power, inspections	\$130,000 to \$225,000
Go live	Target Aug 1 2027	First ads play. This date could move later if the hydro company needs more time	
6-month check	Jan 31 2028	Is the board earning as much as we planned?	A checkpoint, no cost
12-month stop rule	Jul 2028	If under 45% of slots are sold, fix the price, hand the board to another company to sell for you, or sell the board	

45% of 6 slots = 2.7, so the stop rule applies if fewer than 3 slots are sold.

Team. The plan assumes you and your co-founder keep your day jobs and work evenings and weekends. Confirm each person's real availability, and whether either of you needs an employer's written permission for a side business (Part 15 has the full list).

Careful: Three inputs are still open and change the plan: cash you can risk; age (some loan and grant programs have age limits); and your co-founder's citizenship or permanent resident status, which decides what work they can do in the company. Part 15 lists every open question and what each answer changes.

Sources and citations: Every number above comes from research2/MODEL.md (the financial model) and research2/DECISIONS.md (23 decisions made from all our research on September 21 2026). Re-run the model with `python3 research2/model.py`.

What you do

1. **You and your co-founder, this week, September 22 to 28 2026:** Read Parts 0 through 5 once, start to finish. About 2 to 3 hours combined. Cost: free.
2. **You, your co-founder, and your spouse, early October 2026:** Hold one meeting. Decide why you are doing this, how much money you could lose, how many hours each of you will give, and who leads. Write it down. Sign it. About 2 hours. Cost: free.
3. **You, by mid-October 2026:** Confirm the real numbers behind this plan: how much cash you have (already in a Canadian bank, with a clear record of where it came from) and your own age (some loan

programs have an age limit).

4. **Your co-founder, by mid-October 2026:** If your co-founder is not a Canadian citizen or permanent resident, get their immigration status confirmed in writing, by a licensed immigration consultant (RCIC) or a lawyer, before they do any paid or unpaid work in the company. This fact is UNKNOWN right now. The **Law Society Referral Service** is free: one 30-minute call with a lawyer, not a consultant. Call 416-947-3300 or 1-800-668-7380, or visit findlegalhelp.ca. A full written opinion may cost a fee; ask for a price first.
5. **You, by mid-October 2026:** Ask your manager for written permission to run a side business. Part 11 has a sample letter. Cost: free.

Guide map

- **The Guide:** Part 0 through Part 17 (18 sections).
- **Dictionary:** terms, A to Z.
- **Toolkit:** letters and scripts to copy and paste: a letter for the town, a script for calling an advertiser, a checklist for a bank meeting.
- **Expert Reference:** for your lawyer, accountant, and town staff. Exact by-law numbers (a **by-law** is a town rule passed by council) and sources.

Part	What it covers
0	Read this first: the answer, the dates, the first steps
1	What a billboard business is
2	How the money works
3	The rules of the game, town by town
4	Our plan in plain words
5	The journey, step by step, with dates
6	Finding the spot and the landlord
7	Getting the permits
8	Building it
9	Getting customers
10	Running the board, day to day
11	Setting up the business itself
12	Where the money comes from
13	Cheaper and easier ways in
14	What can go wrong
15	Questions we need answered
16	Who to call
17	What is proven and what is not

Tip: Read Parts 0 through 5 first for the whole picture, then read each part right before you act on it.

Legend and conventions

Colours. Green means go: the rule is clear and lets us build. Yellow means caution: allowed, but with a hidden problem. Red means stop: not allowed here.

Boxes. RULE: a hard rule you must follow, with the reason in one sentence. **Careful:** a risk, and what to do about it. **Tip:** a shortcut that saves time or money. **Sources and citations:** exact clause numbers, legal wording, and file references; skippable on a first read.

Terms. "Town" means the local government, even for a city like Richmond Hill. The sign itself is the **billboard face** ("the board" for short). A **slot** is one advertiser's turn on it; a **loop** is all the slots playing in sequence before it repeats. A **permit** is the town's written yes to build. Part 1 covers these in full.

Part 1. What a Billboard Business Is

This plan: one digital face, six slots, Richmond Hill first.

Checked as of September 21, 2026.

Who is who

Role	What they do	A real example
Advertiser	Buys a slot	A Persian-community realtor or currency exchange on Yonge Street
Viewer	The audience	Drivers on Yonge Street, Richmond Hill
Landlord	Land owner	A plaza owner on Yonge Street
Operator	Owens the face and sells the slots. The role you and your co-founder would play	Eye Candy Ads, Action Media, and, if you build, your own company
Town	Makes the rules and issues the sign permit	Richmond Hill's Sign Permit desk
Builder	Builds and installs the face	Media Resources, in Oakville
Hydro company	Supplies the power. In Ontario the electric utility is called "hydro"	Alectra, which serves Richmond Hill

Tip: You also need an engineer to certify that the pole and foundation can carry the structure. Part 8 covers this step.

What you own and what you rent

You lease the land from the landlord. You own the structure: the screen, the pole, the foundation, and the wiring.

RULE: Always write a **permit-loss exit** into the lease, a clause that lets you leave early if the town ever cancels your permit.

Three ways to earn

1. Own a board. Build your own face and sell the six slots yourself. This is the main plan in this guide. In a likely year, one board nets about \$33,116 before loan payments (ESTIMATE). That is about \$2,760 a month before the loan payment ($\$33,116 / 12$). Part 2 has the full math, including a bad year and a good year.

2. Sell someone else's board. Become a rep: sell slots on a board someone else owns and keep a cut. Plan on 10% to 15% (ESTIMATE): no Ontario operator publishes a rep rate, but 80% of out-of-home companies pay reps 10% or less, and agency commissions run 15% to 17.5% (Billboard Insider, US trade sources; Part 13).

One board in Vaughan (BillboardHub listing #5107, 7800 Keele St) lists a slot at \$1,750 for a 4-week period (28 days), the same price for 4, 12, 24 or 52 weeks (checked September 23, 2026). At 15%, that is \$262.50 a

period. $\$262.50 \times 13 \text{ periods} = \$3,412.50$ a year, for one slot sold all year. Three slots like that earn about \$10,238 a year, with almost no cash of your own.

3. Do services for other boards. Work for a sign shop or LED installer. Trade experience from elsewhere (sign-making, electrical work, construction, or similar) transfers directly. Job Bank's Ontario wages for a Sign Installer (NOC 73200, 2023-2024 data) are \$18, \$25 and \$40 an hour for low, median and high: \$37,440, \$52,000 and \$83,200 a year at 2,080 hours. Sign makers (NOC 94219) are \$17.60, \$22 and \$32.02 an hour. The Ontario government's Starter Company Plus grant pays up to \$5,000 and needs a 25% matching contribution (Part 12), so this job likely pays more. You can save toward owning a board at the same time.

Tip: Many people start with way 2 or 3 to prove the business and build cash, then move to owning a board. Part 13 has a longer, ranked list of cheaper ways in.

Printed face versus digital face

Across Canada, printed boards are shrinking and digital boards are growing. ESTIMATE, based on the boards we researched.

Slot, loop, and the four-week period

A **slot** is one advertiser's time on the screen. This plan uses six slots per face. A **loop** is all six slots played in sequence, then repeating.

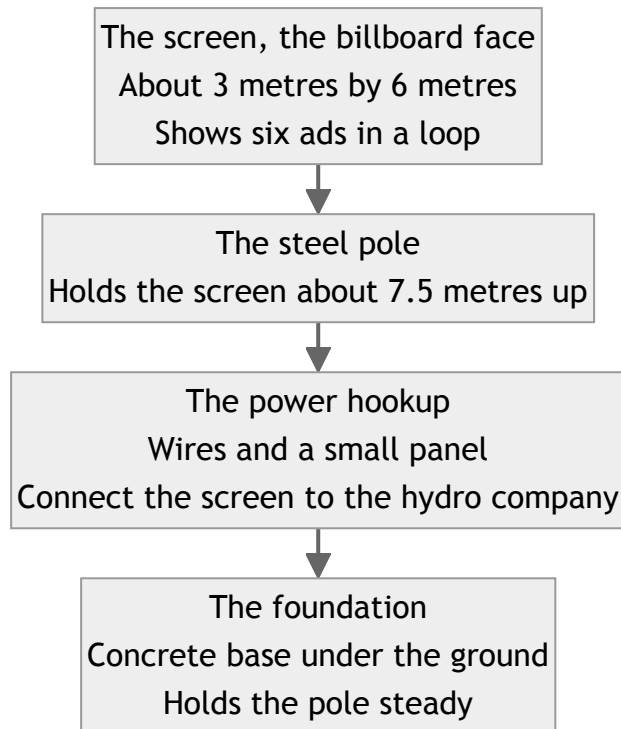
In Richmond Hill, each slot runs about 8 seconds: $6 \times 8 = 48$ seconds, so the loop repeats roughly every 48 seconds all day. Under East Gwillimbury's rules, the slot is 10 seconds: $6 \times 10 = 60$ seconds, so the loop repeats roughly every 60 seconds.

A **4-week period** is the block advertisers buy, not a calendar month. 13 periods (52 weeks) cover one year.

Occupancy is the average share of slots sold across the year. At 60%, that is 3.6 of the 6 slots sold on a typical day.

Dwell time (the shortest time a slot must show) varies by town: Richmond Hill 3 seconds, Bradford 5 seconds, Newmarket 6 seconds, East Gwillimbury 10 seconds. VERIFIED against each town's own rule book. This plan uses 8- to 10-second slots, each at or above its town's minimum (8 seconds in Richmond Hill, 10 in East Gwillimbury).

A picture of one board, part by part



Part	What it is	Size
The screen	The LED billboard face	10 ft by 20 ft class, about 3 metres by 6 metres
The steel pole	Holds the screen high enough to see from a distance	About 7.5 metres tall
The power hookup	Wire and a small panel bringing power up the pole from the hydro company	Runs inside or alongside the pole
The foundation	Concrete base set into the ground	Goes several metres down

Tip: The four parts are costed and bought separately, not as one item. Part 2 has the whole-board cost. Part 8 has each part's cost and the Ontario companies that build it, and uses two trade terms: **monopole** for the pole, and **pylon** for the pole and screen together.

What you do

1. **You and your co-founder, this week:** Visit a real digital billboard face in person. Any city will do. Count the slots. Time each slot and the full loop, and compare them with the dwell-time minimums above. About one hour. Cost: nothing beyond driving there.
2. **You, this week:** Talk to someone who runs a board and does not compete with your plan. Ask what one day of their work looks like. One short conversation. Cost: free.
3. **Your co-founder, this week:** If you have trade experience (sign-making, electrical work, construction, or similar) from elsewhere, write down what is the same here and what is different. Notes in any language are fine. This feeds Part 8. About one hour. Cost: free.

Part 2. How the Money Works

In one sentence: In the Likely case one board leaves \$33,116 a year before loans and tax and pays back a \$175,000 build in about 5.3 years; in the Bad case it never truly pays back.

All dollars are Canadian. Checked as of September 21, 2026, from our own master money file. "Money left" is this guide's word for NOI: revenue minus land rent, sales cost and fixed running costs, before loan payments, tax and salary. Part 12 covers what happens to it after a loan.

The three cases: bad, likely and good

Ontario boards post list prices of \$1,750 to \$1,995 a period. The cases assume you collect less, because new boards discount to win their first customers. Prices are per 4-week period, 13 periods a year.

	Bad	Likely	Good
Price per slot, per 4-week period	\$1,200	\$1,600	\$1,900
How full (occupancy)	40%	60%	75%
Average slots sold, of 6	2.4	3.6	4.5

	Bad	Likely	Good
Revenue, price times 6 times 13 times how full	\$37,440	\$74,880	\$111,150
Collected per 4-week period, on average	\$2,880	\$5,760	\$8,550
Land rent	\$10,000	\$14,976	\$22,230
Sales cost, 10%	\$3,744	\$7,488	\$11,115
Fixed running costs	\$19,300	\$19,300	\$19,300
Money left before loans and tax	\$4,396	\$33,116	\$58,505

Likely case, worked:

- **Full-year ceiling.** 6 slots x \$1,600 x 13 periods = \$124,800, with every slot sold every period.
- **Real revenue.** \$124,800 x 60% full = **\$74,880**.
- **Land rent:** 20% of revenue or \$10,000 a year, whichever is more. 20% of \$74,880 is \$14,976, above the \$10,000 minimum, so rent is \$14,976.
- **Sales cost:** commonly 10% of revenue, paid to whoever sells the ads. 10% of \$74,880 is \$7,488.
- **Fixed running costs:** \$19,300 a year regardless of price or occupancy (table below).
- **Money left.** \$74,880 minus \$14,976 minus \$7,488 minus \$19,300 = **\$33,116 a year**.

Sources and citations: No Ontario landlord or operator publishes rent or sales-cost terms, so both are ESTIMATE. Rent: BOLD Boards offers landowners 15% of gross (boldboards.ca/lease, checked September 23, 2026), Lamar's US site leases cost about 17% of billboard revenue (Lamar 10-K, fiscal 2025), and US ground-lease guides put revenue share at 15% to 20%, so 20% is a cautious top-of-range figure. The \$10,000 minimum is our own assumption; confirm it with the landlord. Sales cost: Billboard Insider puts in-house sales, base plus commission, at "closer to 10%" of revenue (2016) and found that 80% of out-of-home companies pay commission of 10% or less (February 4, 2025). An agency or rep firm costs 15% to 17.5%.

Fixed running cost, per year	Amount
Electricity, about 40,000 kWh, after Ontario's 23.5% rebate	\$6,100
Insurance	\$4,500
Repairs and spare-parts reserve	\$3,000
Software, cellular data, monitoring	\$1,200
Town permit renewals and fees	\$500
Property-tax pass-through to the landlord	\$1,000
Bookkeeping, accounting and legal upkeep	\$3,000
Total	\$19,300

Bad case, worked:

- 6 slots x \$1,200 x 13 periods = \$93,600 at most.
- \$93,600 x 40% full = \$37,440 in real revenue.
- Land rent: 20% of \$37,440 is \$7,488, below the \$10,000 minimum, so rent is \$10,000 a year.
- Sales cost: 10% of \$37,440 is \$3,744.
- Fixed costs: \$19,300.
- Money left = \$37,440 minus \$10,000 minus \$3,744 minus \$19,300 = **\$4,396 a year.**

Good case, worked:

- 6 slots x \$1,900 x 13 periods = \$148,200 at most.
- \$148,200 x 75% full = \$111,150 in real revenue.
- Land rent: 20% of \$111,150 is \$22,230.
- Sales cost: 10% of \$111,150 is \$11,115.
- Fixed costs: \$19,300.
- Money left = \$111,150 minus \$22,230 minus \$11,115 minus \$19,300 = **\$58,505 a year.**

Payback

ESTIMATE: no Ontario vendor has given a written price yet for a finished 10-by-20-foot board. The build costs below are planning numbers, not quotes. **\$130,000** is a cost-cut build. **\$175,000** is a realistic build. **\$225,000** is a stress case, if steel and screen prices rise. Each carries an 8% contingency, so the real total runs higher.

Build cost	Bad case	Likely case	Good case
\$130,000, Smart build	29.6 years	3.9 years	2.2 years
\$175,000, Likely build	39.8 years	5.3 years	3.0 years
\$225,000, Stress build	51.2 years	6.8 years	3.8 years

RULE: Do not order steel or a screen until both are true: four slots are signed for a full year at \$1,400 or more a period, and the town permit is in hand.

Four signed slots come close to the Likely case's \$74,880 revenue:

Slots signed at \$1,400	Revenue a year	Money left before loans
3	\$54,600	\$18,920
4	\$72,800	\$31,660
5	\$91,000	\$44,400
6	\$109,200	\$57,140

What moves the result

How full the board stays moves the result most, then price. Build cost changes payback speed, not the yearly money left.

Break-even at \$1,600 a slot is about 26% full: 1.6 of 6 slots, roughly \$2,500 a period. Revenue is about \$32,600 a year. Rent stays at the \$10,000 minimum, since revenue is under \$50,000. Sales cost is about \$3,260. \$32,600 minus \$10,000 minus \$3,260 minus \$19,300 is about zero.

The loan effect

The plan pays for steel, foundation and power with a long bank loan, and leases only the screen (a **screen lease**). Cost per \$100,000, per year:

Way to pay	Cost per \$100,000, per year
Bank loan, 5 years, 7.45%	\$24,017
Bank loan, 10 years, 7.45%	\$14,213
Bank loan, 15 years, 7.45%	\$11,090
Screen lease, 48 months, about 10%	\$30,435
Screen lease, 60 months, about 10%	\$25,496
Screen lease, 84 months, about 10%	\$19,921

7.45% is today's ceiling rate on the government-backed loan program in Part 12. **ESTIMATE:** the lease rates are a planning guess. No equipment lessor publishes a rate before you ask.

A \$150,000, 10-year loan costs \$21,319 a year.

- **Likely:** \$33,116 minus \$21,319 leaves **\$11,797 a year**, free and clear.
- **Bad:** the payment is bigger than the money left. Every year it stays Bad, it eats into your cash reserve.

Lenders generally want a coverage ratio of 1.25 or higher. At Likely, \$33,116 divided by \$21,319 is 1.55, which clears the bar. At Bad it is 0.21, well short. Part 12 covers loan programs, the cash you need before the first ad, and how to structure a loan a lender will approve.

What scale changes: 1, 3, 7, 12, 20 boards

Each added board repeats the Likely case and carries its own \$150,000, 10-year loan. More than one board also brings shared costs: a part-time bookkeeper, a commission seller, or memberships. The plan assumes \$0

for 1 to 2 boards, since you and your co-founder do the work. It assumes \$25,000 a year for 3 to 5 boards, and \$60,000 a year for 6 to 12 boards.

Boards	Money left before loans, after shared costs	Money left after each board's loan payment
1	\$33,116	\$11,797
3	\$74,348	\$10,391
7	\$171,812	\$22,579
12	\$337,392	\$81,564
20	About \$602,320, ESTIMATE	About \$175,940, ESTIMATE

The after-loan column does not rise smoothly. At 3 boards it is below the 1-board figure, because the \$25,000 shared cost starts there: $3 \times \$11,797 = \$35,391$, minus $\$25,000 = \$10,391$.

ESTIMATE: the 20-board row. Nobody has worked out shared costs for more than 12 boards, and 20 boards almost certainly needs more than \$60,000 a year of shared help. Treat \$175,940 as an optimistic ceiling, not a promise.

One pole can also carry two faces, one on each side. Total cost is about \$285,000: about \$175,000 for the first face and about \$110,000 more for the second screen and steel. The pole and permit are already paid for by the first face. At Likely, two faces on one pole leave \$66,232 a year and pay back in 4.3 years. This assumes the back side sells as well as the front. **UNKNOWN:** nobody has proven that. Ask advertisers about it during the pre-sale, the letter-of-intent round before the board is built (four letters at \$1,400 or more per 4 weeks by January 31 2027; Part 9).

When can you leave your day job

UNKNOWN: the board count and the date. Twelve boards, each still carrying its own \$150,000 loan, leave about \$81,564 a year after loans. Reaching about \$120,000 a year after loans (the earlier plan's day-job replacement target) needs about 15 to 16 boards on the same math. Nobody has priced that many boards, planned permits for them, or confirmed that many good spots exist across York and Simcoe Region.

Use a rule instead of a number. Leave your day job only when the money left after every loan payment stays at your target for two consecutive calendar quarters, at whatever board count that takes. Two faster routes: pay loans off quickly instead of adding new ones, or sell the whole company once it has a track record. Small billboard companies have sold for roughly 4 to 7 times a year's money left. **UNKNOWN:** no Canadian sale price has been made public to check that range.

What you do

1. **This week:** read this part with your co-founder. Agree that the Bad case is real and plan for it, not only for Likely or Good.
2. **In Phase 1, February to April 2027:** get 4 signed slots first, each at \$1,400 or more a period for a full year. Get it in writing, before any steel or screen is ordered.
3. **Once real vendor quotes exist, in Phase 0 or 1:** re-run this math with the real build price instead of the \$130,000 to \$225,000 range. Ask whoever helps with the numbers to redo the payback table.

4. **Ongoing, once the board is live:** track money left after every loan payment, every quarter. Consider leaving your day job only when your target is met and holds for two quarters in a row.
5. **Before adding a second or third board:** you and your co-founder re-check the shared-cost line against what the bookkeeper and seller really cost then, not the \$25,000 or \$60,000 planning numbers from this part.

Part 3. The Rules of the Game

In one sentence: Of 13 towns checked (as of September 21 2026), none is green, seven are yellow and six are red. Richmond Hill, the target, is yellow and hangs on one unconfirmed zoning question. Highway sites and Toronto are closed to you. Sign nothing until a town confirms in writing.

By-laws, permits, and zoning

Every town near Toronto has its own sign by-law, and no two are the same. A sign by-law usually allows a billboard only on land zoned Commercial or Industrial.

UNKNOWN: The plan's target street, Richmond Hill's Yonge Street, has many mixed-use lots. The town has never confirmed in writing whether mixed use counts as Commercial land, or as Residential land, which would block a sign nearby. This is the single biggest unknown in the plan. What you do, step 1, says what to ask and who to ask.

By-laws call a billboard a **third-party sign**; some towns say **off-premises advertising**.

A variance is a slow backup, not the plan.

Who says yes: more than one desk

Every site needs the landlord, the town, the electric utility and the Electrical Safety Authority (ESA). The other desks apply by location. The upper-tier governments in play are York Region and Simcoe County.

Who	What they check	When they matter
The town	Zoning, the sign by-law, the sign permit, the building permit	Every site, every town
York Region or Simcoe County	Big roads the Region or County owns	Only if the sign sits near a Regional or County road
The province (MTO)	Land near a highway	Only within 400 m of a fast highway
A conservation authority	Rivers and flood land	Only if the lot sits in a flagged flood area
The electric utility	The power connection	Every site, once the sign is approved
The Electrical Safety Authority (ESA)	Safe wiring	Every site, before the sign turns on

Sources and citations: MTO is the Ministry of Transportation of Ontario. Richmond Hill's electric utility is Alectra. Its conservation authority is TRCA, the Toronto and Region Conservation Authority (not LSRCA, which an earlier project note named by mistake). All VERIFIED September 21 2026, against each town's own website and by-law.

The town-by-town traffic light

Every yellow town has real limits and needs its own written confirmation before real money moves.

Town	Colour	Why	The number that matters most
Richmond Hill	Yellow	Legal in principle since April 8 2026, but the town has not confirmed in writing whether Yonge Street's mixed-use lots count as commercial land	19 sq. m cap counting the frame, 100 m from homes, 300 m from another sign
East Gwillimbury	Yellow	Legal today by staff decision, but the permit lasts only one year and can be refused at renewal	250 m from any home, 300 m from another sign
Bradford West Gwillimbury	Yellow	A ten-year licence already exists, but a digital screen needs prior written approval from the Chief Building Official first	Only 40 m needed from another sign, the loosest spacing rule we found anywhere
Newmarket	Red, parked for now	The town's own map shows only one open spot, and council refused the last request in September 2025	No council meeting can decide anything before December 14 2026
Innisfil	Yellow	Signs must stay plain, with no digital light or moving colour allowed at all	A town-wide cap of forty five signs total
Barrie	Yellow	New signs go only on empty commercial or farm land, and two companies already operate there	500 m from another sign, 100 m from homes
Georgina	Yellow	A new sign on ordinary commercial land is capped too small to be worth building	10 sq. m cap on a commercial lot
Vaughan	Yellow	Signs are allowed only inside employment zones , land set aside for offices and factories, which are likely already taken	600 m from another sign
Aurora	Red	An older, unchecked record says every new sign needs a council vote	No everyday approval path found
Markham	Red	Only ten billboards are allowed in the whole town, ever, all by council vote	A hard cap of ten
King Township	Red	Third-party signs are banned outright	Zero allowed
Whitchurch-Stouffville	Red	Third-party signs are banned outright	Zero allowed
Toronto	Red	Bans new signs near every major highway and much of Yonge Street, and refuses most of what is left	An annual sign tax of \$15,084.23, on top of the ban

Sources and citations: Richmond Hill Sign By-law 52-09, amended by By-law 25-26, section 7.6.7. East Gwillimbury Sign By-law 2025-052, amended by By-law 2026-077. Bradford West Gwillimbury Sign By-law 2011-023. Newmarket Sign By-law 2017-73. Innisfil Sign By-law 050-06. Barrie Sign By-law 2018-029, amended by By-law 2026-011. Georgina By-law 2006-0062. Vaughan Sign By-law 140-2018. Markham By-law 2002-94, section 5.7.1. King Township By-law 2018-03, section 42. Whitchurch-Stouffville By-law 2016-012-RE. Toronto Municipal Code, Chapter 694. All VERIFIED against each town's own document, September 21 2026. Aurora's council-vote rule, and the \$363 fee once quoted for it, could not be checked again on records.aurora.ca. Treat Aurora's exact mechanism as unconfirmed. RED is still the right colour for it.

The highway rule, and who actually gets highway signs

RULE: we will not plan a sign near a highway. It is not a real path for us.

RULE: across the whole province, MTO allows no billboard within 400 m of a **400-series highway**, a fast highway with no stoplights: 400, 401, 404, 407 or 427. No city exception exists anywhere. A sign closer than 400 m needs a **Minister's Order**, signed personally by the minister in charge of highways: \$770.00, valid 5 years, renewal required. The province can cancel it early and owes nothing back.

Every large freeway sign we could trace sits on government land, or land held by a government agency. **Pattison** runs signs like this at highway rest stops. **Allvision** has one near a **GO** train station (GO is the train system around Toronto); one example is not a pattern. Each operates under a Minister's Order, a path open to big companies that already know people in government, not to a new small business. One sign near Highway 400 and Steeles Avenue matched no public record, so exceptions cannot be ruled out; every sign we could check follows the rule.

Why Toronto is closed

Toronto bans a new billboard within 400 m of six highways: 400, 401, 404, 409, the Don Valley Parkway and the QEW (Queen Elizabeth Way). The Gardiner Expressway and Highway 427 are banned too, under their own separate rules. Another ban covers 450 m of much of Yonge Street. What is left is narrow strips of industrial and utility land, already crowded with existing signs.

A new sign there almost always needs a variance from Toronto's five-member Sign Variance Committee. Between 2024 and September 18 2026, the committee decided 28 requests for a new digital third-party sign and refused 18, about 2 out of every 3. The few approvals mostly went to companies with a lot of money already, whose land nearly met every rule on its own.

Toronto also charges an annual sign tax: \$15,084.23 a year for a sign our size, about 20 cents of every dollar a board like ours earns. That is about two and a half months of sales, and it is owed before any ad is sold.

What can change, and the dates to watch

ESTIMATE: our best judgment, not a fact. Tightening of new-sign rules by 2028 is 30 to 45 percent likely. A forced removal of an already-built, lawful sign in the same time is far less likely, only 5 to 15 percent. Build fast once every gate is passed (Part 5), to stay ahead of any new rule.

Elections. Ontario's municipal election is October 26 2026. New councils in most towns begin serving from mid-November 2026, right after you would start applying. A new council can ask staff to rewrite a sign by-law at any time.

Grandfathering (Ontario term: **legal non-conforming** status): in Richmond Hill it covers only signs standing on November 9 2009, the exact wording of the by-law. A sign built in 2027 has no automatic protection; whether it stays protected depends on what a future by-law says. Every lease needs a way out if the town takes the permit away.

Planned reviews. Richmond Hill staff say a full sign by-law rewrite is planned, called **the town's Phase 3 review**. That is the town's name, not the plan's Phase 3 in Part 4. No date has been set. Bradford staff called their current rules outdated and asked for a rewrite in December 2025; nothing has been drafted so far.

Date	What happens
October 26 2026	Municipal election day across Ontario

Date	What happens
November 15 2026	Richmond Hill's new council begins its term
November 17 2026	East Gwillimbury's new council officially starts
December 14 2026	Newmarket's first council meeting after the election, the earliest any Newmarket decision can move
December 15 2026	East Gwillimbury's first council meeting after the election

Sources and citations: Richmond Hill Sign By-law 52-09 section 2.3 is the legal non-conforming clause. November 9 2009 is the day the by-law first came into force. Ontario's Municipal Act stopped giving new sign by-laws an automatic grandfather clause after 2017, so protection for a 2027 sign rests on the future by-law's own words, not a standing right. **UNKNOWN:** whether Richmond Hill's two zoning by-laws actually passed. Council voted on them on September 16 2026, numbered 81-26 and 82-26. The minutes were not yet public as of September 21 2026.

What you do

1. **You** email Richmond Hill's sign desk, signpermits@richmondhill.ca, 905-771-8800, in October 2026. Ask in writing whether Yonge Street's mixed-use zones count as Commercial land for a sign. Cost: free. Time: no promised reply time exists for this exact question; allow 2 to 4 weeks, then follow up by phone.
2. **You** also file the Request for Zoning By-law Information form at forms.richmondhill.ca. Cost: free. Time: up to 5 weekdays.
3. **You and your co-founder** read the town table above before picking a second and a third town to keep in reserve. Cost: free. Time: one evening, this month.
4. **You** check the council meeting list for each town you are still considering, once a month starting November 2026. Look for the words "sign by-law." Cost: free. Time: about 15 minutes a month, ongoing.
5. **You** do not sign a lease, order a screen, or apply for a permit anywhere. Wait until that town's written yes is in hand. This rule has no exception.

Part 4. Our Plan in Plain Words

In one sentence: Build one six-slot LED face on Yonge Street in Richmond Hill, from Highway 7 to Elgin Mills, and order no steel until four advertisers have signed for a full year.

Checked as of September 21, 2026.

The big idea

In a likely year, one board earns about \$33,116 before loan payments. A typical loan on one board costs \$21,319 a year. That leaves \$11,797 in the early years while the loan is paid off. One board alone will not replace your day-job income. We only decide to grow after the first board proves itself.

The place: Yonge Street, Richmond Hill, from Highway 7 to Elgin Mills

1. **It became legal.** On April 8 2026, Richmond Hill passed a sign rule. A ground sign may now carry off-premises advertising, meaning ads for businesses that are not on that property. Some by-laws call this a third-party sign. This has never been allowed here before.
2. **Nobody has built one yet.** On September 21 2026 we checked the town's own list of building permits. It shows no other company building this kind of sign on Yonge Street, and no applications. The list does not show every kind of permit, so this is our best evidence, not a certainty. Part 3 showed that one sign blocks a 300 m radius, so no other sign like ours can go up inside that circle.
3. **Traffic and community.** This stretch of Yonge Street carries tens of thousands of cars every day. It also runs through the heart of the Greater Toronto Area's Persian-Canadian community. That gives a natural first set of advertisers, many of whom speak the same language as you and your co-founder.
4. **Real landlord targets.** Part 6 lists twelve properties along this stretch. Each was checked, lot by lot, for a knock-down-and-rebuild plan, a special downtown rule, or another problem.

RULE: no site is confirmed yet. Every one of the twelve lots has an open question. Three have their own building application already filed. The other nine each have a different problem. Most are next to a neighbour's tower application. A few have a zoning number under appeal. One sits inside a condo building. One is owned by the City itself, inside a zone with no digital signs allowed.

This stretch stays clear of Highway 407's own 400 m no-go zone, which runs from about Highway 7 north to about 8790 Yonge Street. Usable frontage begins a little north of Highway 7 itself. ESTIMATE, from research file g-zoning-reading.

Why not Newmarket

Newmarket is parked, not dropped. Even its best case is slower than Richmond Hill, with a smaller and less certain payoff.

Newmarket has allowed billboards for many years, but its own map allows them in only three small areas of the whole town.

- One is a set of thin strips of land already inside the 300 m circle of another sign, so nothing new can go there.
- One sits mostly inside the highway rule zone from Part 3.

- One is a fan-shaped piece of land near Yonge Street and Davis Drive. It is the only one that looks open, and no willing landlord has been confirmed even there.

In September 2025, Newmarket's council refused the only recent request for a new digital sign, at 749 Davis Drive. Nearby neighbours objected to the bright light and the distraction. No Newmarket council meeting can decide anything before December 14 2026.

The product: what we are building

One LED face, about 3.0 m by 6.0 m (roughly 10 by 20 feet). Each slot runs 8 to 10 seconds. Over a year the board sells slots across 13 four-week periods. An advertiser can book one period or a whole year.

RULE: order a screen sized about 3.0 m by 6.0 m outside its frame (9 feet 10 inches by 19 feet 8 inches). This size fits under Richmond Hill's 19 square metre cap for a sign on Yonge Street. The cap counts the metal frame around the screen, so a true 10 by 20 foot screen with a normal frame is slightly over it.

Table C of Richmond Hill's Sign By-law allows 0.30 square metres of sign per metre of frontage, up to that cap. 19 divided by 0.30 equals 63.3, so the full face needs 63.3 m of frontage.

Backup size: a screen 8 feet by 16 feet (about 2.4 m by 4.9 m) needs only about 40 m of frontage instead of 63 m. Use it if the best lot we find has a narrower frontage. ESTIMATE: the smaller face saves \$44,000 to \$64,000 on the screen. Source: research file c2.

What we will not do

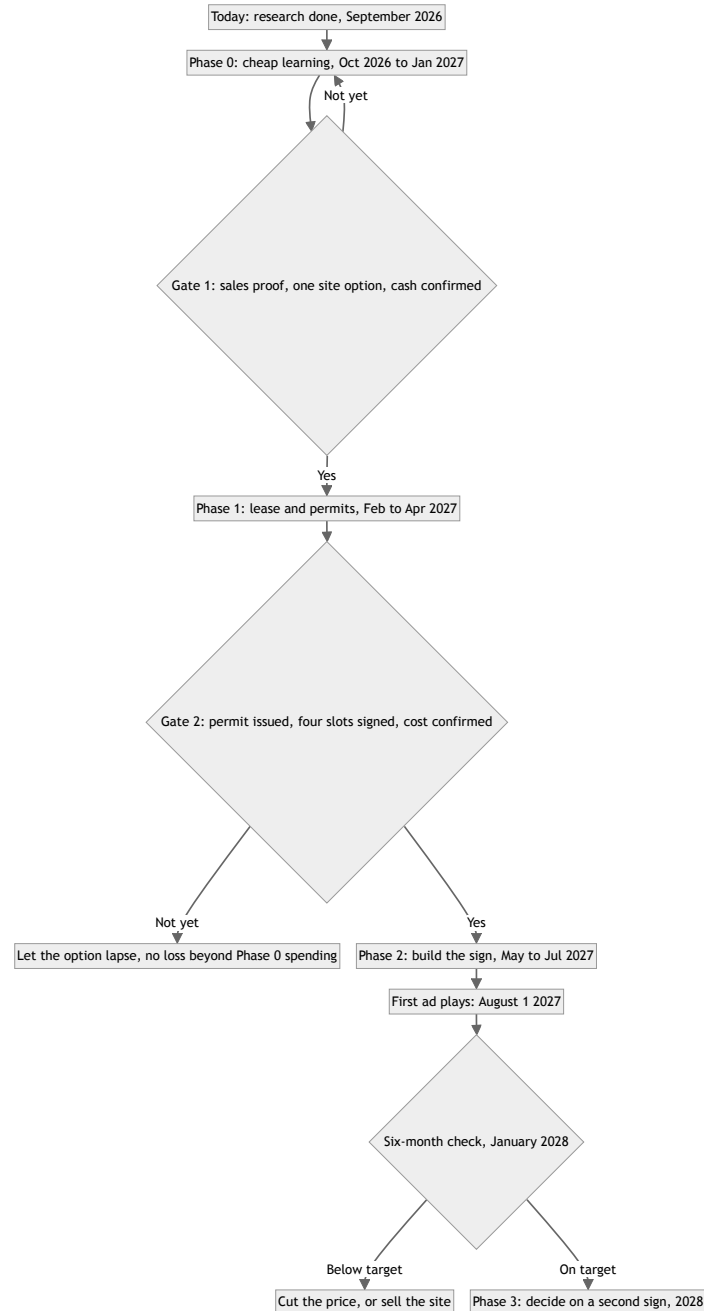
- **RULE:** we will not build near a highway or inside Toronto. Part 3 explains why both are closed to a new business like this one.
- **RULE:** we will not order steel or a screen until four advertisers sign, each for a full year. Four signed slots at \$1,400 per period earns close to the likely case (Part 2).
- **RULE:** no lender, including banks, can push us past what we can afford to lose. We keep a starting reserve of at least \$30,000 untouched. We raise it to \$45,000 to \$60,000 if our lease does not cap what we owe for leaving early.
- **RULE:** we will not pay you or your co-founder a salary in year one. The only exception is paying back money you or your co-founder lent the company, with paperwork. The company cannot yet afford real wages on top of its other costs.
- **RULE:** we will not give a landlord a free advertising slot instead of rent. A free slot is worth \$1,600 times 13 periods. That equals \$20,800 a year at full price, more than the rent itself. We offer a bigger share of the money instead.
- **RULE:** if any money for this business comes from a country under sanctions or heavy financial scrutiny, we get advice first. A lawyer and an accountant both sign off before we move it, in one clear, documented step. Banks and **FINTRAC**, Canada's financial watchdog, treat money from those countries as high risk, no matter how ordinary the money's real source is.
- **RULE:** we will not sign a lease of 21 years or more. We stop one day short of 21 years instead. Ontario's Planning Act treats a 21-year lease almost like selling part of the land, and a lease that long needs a special extra yes from the town.
- **RULE:** we will not advertise cannabis, tobacco, or vaping. We also will not advertise a currency exchange business unless it is registered with FINTRAC. We check every exchange's registration on the day it signs, and again before we renew its contract.

Back-up sites, if Richmond Hill does not work out

Switch if the zoning question from Part 3 comes back unfavourable, or no landlord says yes. Four back-up plans:

1. **East Gwillimbury, along Woodbine Avenue.** This town already allows this kind of sign today. Town staff decide it, rather than an unclear rule. The permit still only lasts one year at a time. One large candidate property runs about 1,240 m of frontage on Woodbine Avenue. That number is an estimate from public mapping, not a landlord agreement.
2. **Bradford West Gwillimbury, along Holland Street.** This town has allowed this kind of sign for over ten years. The town calls its permit a **licence**. It has the loosest spacing rule of any town we checked, only 40 m. A digital screen still needs a written yes first, from the head of the town's building office. One candidate property sits near 490 Holland Street West.
3. **Buying or converting an existing sign in Georgina.** Georgina's rules for a brand new sign are too small to be worth building one from scratch. Instead, we could buy an existing sign from a local sign builder and upgrade it to digital. Two examples to ask about are Eye Candy Ads' sign in Keswick, at 22869 Woodbine Avenue, and Action Media's sign at 2848 Ravenshoe Road.
4. **The partner route.** One of you sells ad space, on commission, for an existing sign company instead of owning a sign. It needs almost no money, pays about 10 to 15 percent of what each ad sells for, and builds advertiser relationships.

The path from here to the first ad, in one picture



The dates and gate conditions come from Part 5, "The journey step by step," and from our own money math in research2/MODEL.md. VERIFIED September 21 2026, against research2/DECISIONS.md.

What you do

1. **You** treat Richmond Hill, Yonge Street, Highway 7 to Elgin Mills, as first choice. Start the written zoning question from Part 3 in October 2026. Cost: free.
2. **You and your co-founder** agree, this month, to park Newmarket. Revisit it only if Richmond Hill and both back-up towns all fail.
3. **You** pick the face size before asking any company for a price. Choose between the full 10 by 20 foot face and the smaller 8 by 16 foot face, based on which candidate lot's frontage looks most likely to work.

4. **Research the backups.** Look into the East Gwillimbury Woodbine Avenue site and the Bradford Holland Street site, alongside the Richmond Hill zoning question. One of you can handle the paperwork, the other the site research. Start in October 2026, at no cost beyond time spent.
5. **You both** read the eight "we will not" rules together and agree to hold each other to them.

Part 5. The Journey, Step by Step

The six phases

Gates use three colours. Green: every test passed, move on. Yellow: one thing is off, fix it that month. Red: a test failed, stop. Try the next town on the list (East Gwillimbury, then Bradford) or stay a reseller with no board of your own.

Phase	Dates	Goal	Cash spent	Gate at the end
0. Learn and decide	Oct 1 2026 to Jan 31 2027	Agree together, learn cheaply, set up the company	about \$3,000 to \$9,000	GATE 1, Jan 31 2027
1. Option and paperwork	Feb 1 to about Apr 30 2027	Sign a short land option, get the town permit, line up money	plus \$10,000 to \$20,000	GATE 2, about April 2027
2. Build and go live	May 2027 to Jan 31 2028	Build the sign, turn it on, prove it for six months	plus \$21,900 to \$128,750, depending on the funding plan in Part 12	Six-month review, Jan 31 2028
3. Prove and plan board two	Feb 2028 to about Aug 2028	Hold the board full for a year, then decide on a second one	little new cash if board one pays its own way	Twelve-month hold test, around July 2028
4. Grow	2028 to 2030	Add a board every six months to a year, funded by boards already running	funded mostly by loans against boards already earning	You leave your day job once the boards can pay a salary. Needs about twelve loaned boards, fewer once paid off, or a sale.
5. Harvest	2030 to 2032	Twelve to twenty boards, then sell some, sell all, or keep the income	none, this phase makes money	your choice, no forced date

Tip: Three build cost levels, all estimates, not signed quotes. Smaller build: about \$130,000. Likely: about \$175,000. Worst case: about \$225,000. Each level carries +8% for surprises, so the worst case is \$225,000 + 8% (\$18,000) = about \$243,000. If every supplier's quote lands above that, shrink the design or walk away.

Phase 0, learn and decide, October 1 2026 to January 31 2027

What happens:

- 1. Founders meeting.** You, your co-founder, and any spouse or family member with a financial stake meet once. Agree on the goal, the hours each of you can give, and the most you can afford to lose together. Write down the decision to go or not.
- 2. Confirm the key facts.** Is the cash really available, already in a Canadian bank, with a clear paper trail? If your co-founder is not a Canadian citizen or permanent resident, get their immigration status confirmed in writing, by a licensed immigration consultant (RCIC, Regulated Canadian Immigration Consultant) or a lawyer, before they do any paid or unpaid work in the company. See Part 15.

3. **Get your employer's written consent** if you keep your day job, before spending real money. Check your employment contract for a non-compete clause. Do billboard work only on your own time. Keep the signed letter.
4. **Pick advisors.** Hire a small-business lawyer, an accountant, and an insurance broker before spending money.
5. **Run the cheap tests** from Part 13 first, for example reselling slots on someone else's board, before betting on building your own.
6. **Set up the company.** Incorporate in Ontario, \$300. Register for HST, 13% in Ontario. Open a business bank account. Sign a shareholder agreement.
7. **Start the Richmond Hill paperwork.** Send the free written zoning question. It decides whether your chosen street counts as Commercial. Part 7 has the full process.

GATE 1, January 31 2027, an owner-signed checklist:

- **Zoning confirmed.** The City has answered the zoning question in writing, or East Gwillimbury is confirmed instead.
- **Landlord found.** A willing landlord exists for at least one shortlisted lot.
- **Sales proof.** Three rep sales made on someone else's board, or one test ad bought and reported on.
- **Four non-binding letters of intent** at \$1,400 or more per slot.
- **One budgetary quote** from a supplier, for one of the three build levels above.
- **Cash confirmed** for one of the four funding plans in Part 12. These range from \$21,900 up to \$128,750.
- **Consent letter signed.** Your employer's written consent letter is signed and received.
- **Power request filed.** The formal connection request has been filed with Alectra, Richmond Hill's power utility. See the Careful note below.

Careful: Alectra can be the slowest step in the whole project. Reusing power already at the site: one to three months. New metered service: three to five months. A line expansion: six to nine months or more, and that top end is UNKNOWN, nobody has capped it. File Alectra's formal connection request no later than January 31 2027, even though the sign permit itself is not filed until Phase 1.

Phase 1, option and paperwork, February 1 to about April 30 2027

What happens:

1. **Sign the option to lease**, not a full lease yet. It must include a clause letting you walk away if the permit is refused.
2. **Order the paperwork.** Survey, soil report, and the engineer's stamped drawings. These run in parallel, six to twelve weeks total.
3. **File the sign permit** once the drawings are ready. It costs \$279 in Richmond Hill. VERIFIED, read from the by-law's own fee schedule.
4. **Lock in insurance and financing.** Bind your insurance quotes. Finish the lender package.
5. **Convert letters of intent to orders**, permit-conditioned: the order only becomes real once the permit is issued. Each advertiser pays a ten percent deposit, held in trust by your lawyer.

GATE 2, about April 2027. All of these must be true:

- The permit is issued.
- Quotes are fixed, in writing, at one of the three build levels above.
- Financing is approved.
- Four of six slots are signed.

- A firm written power offer from Alectra is in hand.

RULE: No steel or screen gets ordered until four slots are signed and the town permit is in hand.

Phase 2, build and go live, May 2027 to January 31 2028

What happens:

1. **Safety paperwork first.** Before digging: call Ontario One Call to mark buried lines, confirm builder's insurance, and check every contractor's WSIB (Workplace Safety and Insurance Board) clearance certificate.
2. **Build the sign.** Foundation, steel pole, crane day, screen mount, electrical hook-up. Usually five to nine months from the option being signed.
3. **Final sign-offs.** Alectra energizes the sign. The Electrical Safety Authority (ESA) signs off on the electrical work. The engineer confirms the structure is sound.
4. **Go live.** Target date is August 1 2027, an estimate. It slips to October to December 2027 only if Alectra must expand the power line. It will not slip if the sign reuses power already at the site.
5. **Run the first ninety days.** Check the screen weekly. Keep a complaint log. Invoice every four weeks. Start renewal conversations early.

Six-month review, January 31 2028. Green: the board is billing sixty percent of its slots (about \$5,000 collected per four-week period) and half the advertisers have said they will renew. Red: collections stay under \$3,400 for three periods in a row.

Phase 3, prove and plan board two, February to about August 2028

RULE: No second board gets built or funded until board one holds sixty percent full for twelve straight months. The board goes live around August 2027, so this test cannot be checked until around July 2028, an estimate counted from the go-live date.

Month-twelve stop rule, around July 2028. If the board is under forty-five percent full at the twelve-month mark: fix the price or the sales approach, hand sales to a reseller such as Sanford Outdoor or DigiPoint, or list the board for sale within ninety days. Part 14 has the full playbook.

Phases 4 and 5, grow and harvest, 2028 to 2032

A salary-sized income of about \$120,000 a year needs roughly twelve boards still carrying their loans, fewer once paid off, or a sale instead.

A single board leaves about \$33,000 a year before loans, an estimate from the money model in Part 2, or about \$12,000 a year while its own loan is still being paid. Ten boards leave about \$58,000 a year after loans, still less than a full salary.

Selling a working network to a bigger company typically brings four to eleven times the yearly cash left. For one board earning \$33,000 a year, that is about \$132,000 to \$363,000. The real number depends on how many boards sell together, and bigger networks tend to sell for more per dollar of income.

Month-by-month calendar, October 2026 to the first ad

Month	Main actions	Who leads	Approx. cost this month
Oct 2026	Decision made, immigration opinion, employer consent. Lawyer and accountant hired, incorporation, HST registration. Zoning question sent, cheap tests begin	You, your co-founder	\$2,500 to \$5,500
Nov 2026	Open the business bank account. Set the brand and rate card. Check shortlisted lots against the sign rules. Start first landlord conversations. Watch the Oct 26 election. New councils begin Nov 15 in Richmond Hill and Nov 17 in East Gwillimbury	You	\$500 to \$1,500
Dec 2026	Pre-consult the City, Alectra, and an insurance broker. First landlord meetings. Push toward four letters of intent. Send three supplier quote requests	You, your co-founder	\$500 to \$1,000
Jan 2027	File Alectra's formal power request by Jan 31. Finish letters of intent. Get a funding pre-screen. Build a lender-ready twenty-four-month cash-flow sheet. GATE 1 falls on Jan 31	You	\$0 to \$500
Feb 2027	Sign the short option to lease. Site visit with an electrician and an engineer	You, lawyer	\$2,000 to \$5,000 in legal fees
Mar 2027	Survey, soil report, and stamped engineer drawings. File the Richmond Hill sign permit once the drawings are done	Engineer, surveyor, you	\$9,000 to \$27,000 in soft costs
Apr 2027	Bind insurance. Convert letters of intent into signed orders with ten percent deposits. GATE 2 falls about now	You, lawyer, broker	Varies, see Part 12
May 2027	Sign the full lease and register the notice of lease. Order the screen. Pay the utility offer. Hire the builder. Complete One Call locates and safety paperwork before digging	You, contractor	Screen and steel deposits, see Part 8
Jun to Jul 2027	Foundation, steel, crane day, screen mounted, electrical hook-up, ESA inspection, Alectra energizes the sign	Contractor, engineer, electrician	Bulk of the \$130,000 to \$225,000 build, plus 8%
Aug 1 2027	Target go-live, an estimate. May slip to the last quarter of 2027 if Alectra needs an expansion	You, your co-founder	Ongoing running costs begin
Aug to Oct 2027	First ninety days. Weekly checks. Invoicing. First renewal calls	One of you on site, the other on paper	About \$19,300 a year in running costs, see Part 2
Jan 31 2028	Six-month review against the gate numbers	You	\$0

By-law detail: Richmond Hill Sign By-law 52-09, section 12.3: a sign permit lapses six months after issue if the sign has not been built yet. VERIFIED, read in the by-law itself. Section 12.4 allows one six-month extension, only if the sign still meets the rules in force at renewal. That is why the calendar files the permit only once the design is fixed. A permit filed too early can expire unused.

What you do

1. **This week, by September 28 2026**, book the founders meeting: one evening, held in the first two weeks of October. Also visit a working billboard together and take photos. Read this whole guide once, together if possible. Cost is zero.
2. **Early October**, the immigration opinion from Phase 0, step 2: one consultation, usually under an hour, plus a written opinion. Cost is UNKNOWN. Ask for a written quote when you book.
3. **Early October**, write and send the employer consent letter. Cost is zero.
4. **Mid October**, hire a lawyer and an accountant. Start with the free thirty-minute Law Society referral, then move to paid help. Cost runs from zero up to about \$5,000. Incorporation and basic templates usually run \$2,000 to \$5,000.
5. **Late October**, your lawyer incorporates the company and registers for HST. Incorporation is same-day online. Choose monthly HST filing at registration. Cost is \$300 plus lawyer fees.
6. **Late October**, once the six zoning questions are drafted in the Toolkit, send the Request for Zoning By-law Information to zoninginfo@richmondhill.ca. Follow up at signpermits@richmondhill.ca or 905-771-8800. Cost is zero. Reply time is up to five business days for the free letter.
7. **October through December**, run the cheap tests from Part 13. Call three billboard resellers about a commission-only rep deal, and price one four-week test ad. Do both evenings and weekends. A test ad costs about \$1,978 with tax. VERIFIED, from a real test ad on the Vaughan 7800 Keele board. In parallel, work the personal and community contact list from Part 9.
8. **January 31 2027**, you and your co-founder review the Gate 1 checklist together. Decide in writing whether to continue, switch to another town, or pause.

Where these facts come from

research2/MODEL.md, research2/DECISIONS.md, research2/FACT_BASE.md, research2/FACTS_money.md, research2/p1-richmond-hill-build-steps.md, research2/g-alectra-power-connection.md, and research2/c4-test-cheap-first.md, all checked September 21 2026.

Part 6. Finding the Spot and the Landlord

Bottom line: Call the landlord at 9555 Yonge St, Richmond Hill, first, but only after the town confirms zoning in writing (Part 7). East Gwillimbury and Bradford are next. Newmarket is parked.

All facts below were checked between September 21 and 22, 2026, unless marked otherwise.

What a good spot actually is

A full 10 ft x 20 ft face is 18.6 m2. Richmond Hill's cap counts the frame, so the legal maximum is 19 m2. That needs about 63 m (207 ft) of frontage.

Note: A sign on the wrong side of the road faces away from half of two-way traffic. A south-facing face meets northbound drivers in direct sun for 8 to 11 hours a day, which can wash out the picture in daytime. Decide which direction of travel you are selling, then pick the matching side.

The checklist

Part 7 has each town's exact numbers.

Test	What it protects	Typical distance
Zoning	Only commercial or industrial land qualifies	Ask the town in writing
Distance from homes	Keeps a bright sign away from bedrooms	100 to 300 metres
Distance from another sign	Stops one landlord from fencing off a whole street	40 to 600 metres
Distance from a highway	Keeps drivers from losing focus at speed	400 metres, every town
Distance from a traffic signal	Keeps drivers' eyes on the road at intersections	15 to 100 metres
Frontage	Sets the biggest legal billboard face size	40 to 73 metres
Downtown or heritage area	Some old town cores ban digital signs outright	Ask for the map

Careful: East Gwillimbury's rule for a digital sign is 100 metres from a traffic signal, far more than other towns use. Bradford's rule near a county road is 91 metres. Most other towns use 15 to 23 metres. Check the exact number for your town before you rule out a lot.

RULE: Spend nothing on a survey, a soil report, or an engineer until the town answers your zoning question in writing.

Richmond Hill, Yonge Street: the shortlist

Yonge Street between Highway 7 and Elgin Mills Road has 83 lots, all facing the street and clearing the highway test. Some sit inside the banned Downtown strip, where no digital sign is allowed. That leaves 67 lots that could still work.

Whether any of the 67 pass depends on one open question: the town has not said whether its new mixed-use zones count as Commercial or Residential land.

ESTIMATE: We judge the odds of a favourable reading at 85 to 90 percent. This is our own guess, not a town ruling.

If the reading is favourable, 40 of the 67 lots pass. Of those, 18 are worth calling, and 10 of the 18 are the strongest bets. If not, zero lots pass. Part 7 explains how to ask the town in writing.

Note: The town's zoning maps label these mixed-use zones RMU-COR1, KDA-YC and RHC. Give those codes to the town when you ask your written question in Part 7.

We checked 12 of these lots in depth. None is clean GREEN (zero problems). Six are YELLOW (workable, but the lease needs care) and six are RED (a real problem: an active highrise application, town ownership, or a no-digital zone). The best YELLOW lots to call first:

Address	What is there now	Why it is promising	Watch for
9555 Yonge St, at Weldrick Rd W	A restaurant and retail plaza with CoCo Fresh Tea, Sansotei Ramen and a National Bank branch	Best mix of frontage and distance from homes on the list	Only 8 metres of margin on the 100-metre homes test. A Suncor gas station expansion nearby is under review
10520 and 10488 Yonge St, near Levendale Rd	CIBC branch, All Star Wings	The landlord is a named company already dealing with the town on paperwork	Sits near the edge of the Uptown no-digital area. Part of the lot touches a flood-control zone
9580 Yonge St	UPS Store, Nando's, Midori strip	A small lot, likely a fast yes from a small landlord	Competes with the 300-metre spacing rule against nearby lots, so only one of that group can go ahead
9050 Yonge St	Sun Life office	An office building suggests one clear decision maker	Only 2 metres of margin on the 100-metre homes test
9144 Yonge St	Kia Motors Plaza	If it is a Kia store, a personal contact in that dealer network could open the door faster	A future rebuild here would legally have to be a highrise. The lease needs a strong way out

We don't know who owns most of these lots yet; landlord names cost about \$37 to \$50 each to find (see below). Two are known from a public town filing: 10520 and 10488 Yonge belong to Sitzler Group Holdings No. 1 Limited.

East Gwillimbury and Bradford: the shortlist

East Gwillimbury has no open zoning question. Its rules are set and town staff can approve a sign directly. The best stretch found so far is Woodbine Avenue, about 670 metres south of Green Lane East, with roughly 1,240 metres of frontage, room for several lots. It clears every distance test on paper.

ESTIMATE: A second candidate sits near the Highway 404 interchange, on Green Lane East near Leslie Street. It has the best visibility of any site checked, but sits beside a Toyota dealership site under review, and its safety margins are thin: some tests pass by only 40 to 60 metres. A real survey could still rule it out.

Careful, ESTIMATE: These East Gwillimbury points came from testing the roadside every 20 metres on public maps. Nobody has checked the real property lines, and there is no open map of rural landownership in York Region, so no landlord names exist yet for either site. Drive by; do not make an offer.

In Bradford West Gwillimbury, the best lead is 490 Holland Street West: a vacant commercial lot with 81.7 metres of frontage, owned by Bradford Self-Storage. It sits 3.3 kilometres from Highway 400 and 1.4 kilometres from the nearest existing sign. Holland Street is also **County Road 88**; any lot within 400 metres of a county road needs a second permit, from Simcoe County, on top of the town's own rules. Part 7 has the details.

Newmarket is parked. Its map shows only one open pocket of land, near the Upper Canada Mall. The only recent attempt at a new site was a variance at 749 Davis Drive. It took about 10 months and was refused. No Council meeting can decide a new Newmarket sign case before December 14, 2026.

Finding the landlord

1. Check the town's free public map of development applications first. A project already filed often lists the landlord's name for free.
2. Search the address on OnLand (onland.ca), Ontario's land registry. It gives you the parcel's **PIN**, a 9-digit lot number.
3. Buy the Parcel Register for \$36.50, rising to \$37.10 after November 2, 2026, so order before that date if you can. It shows the landlord's name (the form calls this the "registered owner"), any **chargee** (a lender with a claim on the property), and any registered lease.
4. If the landlord is a company, order an \$8 report from the Ontario Business Registry. It shows the company's directors.

Checking the top 5 Richmond Hill lots this way costs about \$183 to \$245. All 12 lots cost about \$440 to \$590, less than the \$1,600 list price of one slot for one 4-week period.

Who you are dealing with, and how long they take

- **Family-owned lot.** One or two decision makers. First reply in 1 to 3 weeks. Signed deal in 2 to 4 months.
- **Car dealership.** The on-site landlord can say yes in 1 to 4 weeks, but the car brand's sign rules or the dealership's lender can still veto it. Total time is usually 2 to 5 months, or a fast no. A personal contact in that dealer network may open this door faster.
- **Big landlord.** A pension fund or real estate company; Hillcrest Mall's landlord is one. Expect 3 to 12 months, or a polite no.
- **Condominium board.** Needs a vote of every unit owner in the building. Expect 3 to 9 months.

What to say when you first call

Opener: "I am starting a small local digital sign company in Richmond Hill. We would rebuild the sign pole at our own cost and pay you rent every year. Can we meet?"

Tip: The full landlord offer letter is in the Toolkit tab. Send it as a follow-up after a good first call, not as the opener.

What to offer

Offer 20 percent of **gross revenue**, or \$10,000 a year, whichever is higher. Other billboard companies usually pay landlords 15 to 20 percent. Using the three cases from Part 2, the landlord earns:

Case	Revenue collected in a year	Landlord earns
Bad	\$37,440	\$10,000, the floor
Likely	\$74,880	\$14,976
Good	\$111,150	\$22,230

In the Bad case, 20 percent would be \$7,488, so the \$10,000 floor applies.

Careful: If a landlord asks for a free ad slot instead of cash, that costs you \$20,800 a year at list price (\$1,600 a slot, 13 times a year). Offer a higher cash percentage instead. It is usually cheaper.

Note: Under Ontario's Planning Act, a lease of part of a lot needs town approval, called a Committee of Adjustment consent, if it runs 21 years or more, counting every renewal added together. Without it, the lease can be legally void. Write every lease as 21 years less a day, unless a lawyer gets that consent.

What landlords worry about, and the honest answer

Worry	Answer
You will raise my property taxes.	The government values only the sign itself, at replacement cost minus half for wear. Your land and building keep their own value. We pay the sign's extra tax.
My tenants will lose their storefront panels.	Every existing tenant panel stays. We add only a new panel. We get written consent first, if any tenant's lease requires it.
What if I want to sell or rebuild later?	The lease includes an exit. We move the sign, or take it down, on notice. Any buyer of your property is told up front.
What if your company fails?	We carry liability insurance naming you. We also post a removal deposit. That means the sign always comes down properly, at no cost to you.
My bank has a loan on this property.	We prepare the paperwork your lender needs and pay any legal fee for their consent.
Why should I trust a new company?	We are local. We already have advertisers ready to sign. The option to hold the land costs you nothing if the town says no.

What you do

1. **This week and next.** Check the checklist above against each Richmond Hill lot on the shortlist. Use the town's free zoning map. Cost \$0. About 2 to 3 hours total.
2. **Within 2 weeks.** Send the written zoning question to the town. The script for it is in Part 7. Do this before spending money on any lot. Cost \$0. Reply expected in 5 to 10 business days.
3. **You and your co-founder, together, once the zoning answer looks favourable.** Pick the top 2 or 3 lots. Order the parcel registers for them. About \$37 to \$50 per lot. Same day, online.
4. **Within 1 month of a favourable zoning answer.** Call or visit each landlord in order. Start with 9555 Yonge. Use the answers above for their worries. Budget 2 to 4 months for a family landlord to say yes.

Budget longer for a big landlord.

5. **With a real estate lawyer, once a landlord says yes in principle.** Sign an option to lease that holds the land while the town decides on the permit; walk-away cost is nil if the permit is refused. Legal cost about \$2,000 to \$5,000. 4 to 8 weeks.
6. **Site visits, any time, in parallel.** Visit each shortlisted lot in person. Photograph the existing sign pole and the tenant panels. Note the driveways and traffic signals nearby. No cost. A few hours per site. Split landlord calls and English-language paperwork from site visits between you and your co-founder.

Part 7. Getting the Permits

In one sentence: Richmond Hill (Yonge Street) is the main permit target, about 8 to 9 months on a clean site from a signed landlord option to lights on.

All facts below were checked between September 21 and 22, 2026, unless marked otherwise. "The town" includes the City of Richmond Hill.

Richmond Hill: the main path, step by step

1. **Pre-screen the lot** against Part 6's checklist yourself. No cost, 1 to 2 weeks.
2. **Get the town's zoning answer in writing.** Richmond Hill offers two: a free Request for Zoning By-law Information form (about 5 business days; confirms the zone label, not the Sign By-law's own wording) and a paid Permitted Use Letter (\$237 plus tax, about \$268 total, within 10 business days, more official). Neither settles the open mixed-use question from Part 6, whether the mixed-use zones count as Commercial, Residential, or both. For that, email signpermits@richmondhill.ca, copy bylaw@richmondhill.ca, put your exact question in writing, and ask for a written reply. **UNKNOWN:** no fixed reply time is published for this kind of question.
3. **Get the landlord's written consent, and sign an option to lease that depends on the permit being granted.** Legal cost about \$2,000 to \$5,000. 4 to 8 weeks.
4. **Hold the free pre-consultation calls.** Contact the Building Division, the conservation authority, and York Region before spending on drawings. All free, 1 to 3 weeks.
5. **Build the design package.** You need a licensed surveyor's plan, a soil report, and a structural engineer's stamped drawings. The engineer must be a **P.Eng** (licensed professional engineer); only a P.Eng can sign off on the sign's safety. Together, about \$7,000 to \$19,000. 3 to 6 weeks.
6. **File the sign permit application.** The fee is \$279. **UNKNOWN:** the town does not publish a review time. Budget 4 to 8 weeks for one round of comments and a reply.
7. **The building permit rides along with the sign permit.** Richmond Hill charges no separate building fee for a sign. Once your file is complete, Ontario's Building Code gives the town 10 business days to issue the permit or refuse it.
8. **Site plan control, only if the town says it applies.** Ask at pre-consultation. If it applies, a minor amendment costs \$1,088 to \$1,256. 2 to 6 weeks.
9. **York Region approval, only if the sign touches the road allowance.** The road allowance is the town- or region-owned strip beside the street, including the sidewalk and boulevard. This step usually costs \$0 because the sign sits fully on private land. If any part of the sign reaches the boulevard, a Corridor Control Permit costs \$580.
10. **Check with the conservation authority.** TRCA (Toronto and Region Conservation Authority) protects rivers and flood land around Richmond Hill. A free search shows whether your lot is regulated. If not, you are done. If it is, a permit costs about \$2,555. 5 to 7 weeks.
11. **Order power from Alectra,** the electric utility serving Richmond Hill. File the request the same week as the sign permit. **UNKNOWN:** the cost is whatever Alectra quotes once it designs the connection. Timeline: 1 to 3 months if you reuse the landlord's existing supply, 3 to 5 months for new metered service, 6 to 9 months or more if the local grid needs expanding. **RULE:** Do not take the town permit or order the steel until Alectra gives a firm written offer. Power can take longer to arrange than the permit itself.
12. **Call Ontario One Call before any digging.** This free service marks buried pipes and wires. The call takes 5 business days to process; the result stays valid for 60 days.

13. **The electrician files a Notification of Work with the Electrical Safety Authority (ESA)** before construction starts. Fee \$143. ESA inspects the wiring before power goes on.
14. **Build.** Foundation, steel, screen and wiring go up, with town and engineer inspections along the way. About 2 to 4 weeks on site, once material has arrived.
15. **Final sign-off and lights on.** The engineer sends a final field review letter. ESA issues a Certificate of Acceptance. The town does its own final inspection. Then Alectra turns the power on.

Add 2 to 5 months if you need extra approvals: the conservation authority, a site plan amendment, or a variance.

Soft costs (survey, engineering, legal, government fees): about \$9,400 on a low, clean site, up to about \$27,600 on a harder one. Build cost is separate, see Part 8.

The 6-month clock

RULE: The sign permit expires 6 months after the town issues it, unless the sign has actually been built by then. One 6-month extension is allowed if you ask in writing before it expires. Apply for the sign permit only once the steel, the screen, and the Alectra connection are ready.

If Richmond Hill says no

Ask for the reasons and the exact by-law sections in writing. Often, moving the sign spot a few metres or fixing a drawing is enough to refile, usually at no extra cost. If that fails, the only formal route left is a **variance**. It costs \$2,312, plus a public notice (\$415 for the first, \$148 for each extra). **ESTIMATE, not confirmed by a lawyer:** the Sign By-law has no built-in appeal process, so a refused variance may leave only **judicial review** (a lawsuit, needs a lawyer) as the last resort. Ask a real estate lawyer to confirm this by-law reading first.

East Gwillimbury, Bradford and Newmarket, in brief

Town	Sign fee, year one	Typical review time	Contact
Richmond Hill	\$279, no separate building fee	Not published, budget 4 to 8 weeks	Community Standards, 905-771-8800, signpermits@richmondhill.ca
East Gwillimbury	About \$1,988, then about \$576 a year	5 to 15 business days for by-law staff review	By-law Enforcement, 905-478-4282 ext 1478, bylaws@eastgwillimbury.ca
Bradford West Gwillimbury	\$371.60 licence, plus \$266.97 building, plus \$150 County (about \$790 with all three), plus a refundable deposit	Building permit legal clock 10 business days, no total published	Building Division, 905-778-2055 ext 1520. No email known yet. Call to ask
Newmarket	\$1,993.31, but PARKED, no open site today	3 to 4 months best case if a site opens up	Licensing, 905-953-5300 ext 2221, licensing@newmarket.ca

East Gwillimbury does not face Richmond Hill's open zoning question. Its rules are already fixed in writing, and town staff can approve a sign directly. The Chief Building Official (CBO) is the town's building-permit approver.

1. Screen the site against the checklist in Part 6, and get the landlord's letter.
2. Get written zoning confirmation from the town's Zoning Examiner. Also get a written reading from the CBO on the by-law's fine print.
3. Check with the conservation authority.
4. Request power from the utility that serves the site.

5. Prepare the same kind of design package used for Richmond Hill.
6. File a Sign Permit Application with By-law Enforcement.
7. File a Building Permit at the same time, using the **CityView portal**, the town's online system for building permits.

If a rule is not met, a variance from the CBO costs \$523.50. The same 6-month build clock applies here as in Richmond Hill; any extension is entirely at the town's discretion.

If the CBO refuses your variance, you can appeal in writing. Send the appeal to Legislative Services within 14 days. The town then holds a public hearing, with 7 days' notice first. An Appeals Committee decides, and that decision is final. **UNKNOWN:** the appeal fee for a sign case. A general town appeal form costs \$299.50, but this may not be the same fee. Ask Legislative Services to confirm before you file.

Careful: East Gwillimbury requires every ad to show for at least 10 seconds. The nearby Eye Candy sign runs 6-second ads, shorter than the rule allows. Check current practice with the town before you assume that faster pace is allowed.

Bradford West Gwillimbury issues a **licence** in place of a permit. It lasts 10 years once issued.

1. Screen the site. Check whether it sits within 400 metres of a **County Road**, a road owned by Simcoe County, not the town. If it does, you also need a second, stricter Simcoe County sign permit, which costs \$150.
2. Get conservation authority approval first. It has the longest wait of any step.
3. Apply for the County permit.
4. File with the town's Building Division. You need a construction application and a sign licence application. You also need engineered drawings if the sign stands over 7.5 metres tall.

A digital billboard face needs the CBO's written approval before it can show ads that move or change.

If a rule is not met, a small variance costs \$400 from the CBO; a bigger variance needs Council approval and costs \$800. If the CBO refuses a digital billboard face, you have 10 days to ask Council to review it, at a cost of \$800. Council's decision is final within 30 days.

A refundable security deposit is also required, 10 percent of the construction cost, between \$500 and \$10,000. The sign must go up within 6 months of the licence and be finished within 12 months.

Newmarket: the sign permit costs \$1,993.31, if a site is ever found, and renews every 5 years for \$665.19. The only recent test case, a variance at 749 Davis Drive, took about 10 months and was refused; Council said approving it would set a precedent it did not want. No Council meeting happens between the town's September 21, 2026 session and December 14, 2026, because of the municipal election on October 26.

The document checklist

Keep one file per town, digital and paper, with all of these.

- The town's written zoning answer.
- In Richmond Hill, also the sign desk's written interpretation of the Commercial-versus-Residential question.
- The signed option to lease, with a permit-loss exit, and the landlord's written authorization letter.
- A licensed surveyor's plan showing the exact sign spot and every required distance.
- A scaled site plan and sign elevation drawing.
- The structural engineer's stamped drawings and the soil report.

- The screen maker's spec sheet, showing a recognized safety mark, weight, and power load.
- The electrician's single-line diagram and licence number.
- The conservation authority's result, and a permit if the site is regulated.
- A certificate of insurance naming the landlord.
- The Ontario One Call locate confirmation.
- The Electrical Safety Authority's Notification of Work receipt and final Certificate of Acceptance.
- The engineer's final field review letter and the town's final inspection sign-off.

What you do

1. **You**, once the landlord's option is signed. Send the free zoning question and the written interpretation email, both in the same week. Cost \$0. Reply in about 5 to 10 business days for the free form.
UNKNOWN: no fixed time for the written interpretation.
2. **You**, in parallel with the zoning question. Hire a surveyor, a soil engineer, and a structural engineer. About \$7,000 to \$19,000 total. 3 to 6 weeks.
3. **You**, once the design package is ready. File the sign permit with the town. File the Alectra power request the same week. Cost \$279, plus Alectra's quoted cost. Budget 4 to 8 weeks for the town's review.
4. **You**, the same week as the permit filing. Wait for Alectra's written offer. Do not take the permit or order steel before it arrives. Cost: Alectra's quote. 1 to 9 months or more, depending on whether new power is needed.
5. **You and the fabricator**, once the permit is issued. Order the steel and screen right away. The 6-month clock has already started. Cost as set out in Part 8. 8 to 12 weeks to fabricate.
6. **Your co-founder**, during construction. Be on-site for deliveries, footing pours, and the crane lift. No cost beyond time. 2 to 4 weeks on site.
7. **You**, at the very end. Collect the engineer's letter, the ESA certificate, and the town's final inspection sign-off before calling the board finished. Cost \$0. A few days, once construction wraps up.

Part 8. Building It

In one sentence: Plan about \$189,000 cash for one board, hire one prime contractor, and do not take out the City permit or order steel until Alectra, Richmond Hill's power company, sends its written Offer to Connect.

Checked September 21, 2026. No Canadian company publishes a fixed price for a board like yours, so every dollar figure below is an estimate until you hold written quotes.

The size rule that comes before anything else

Richmond Hill's Sign By-law caps one billboard face, frame included, at 19.00 square metres (m2). A true 10 ft by 20 ft face is 18.58 m2, so it fits only with a frame no wider than about 23 mm. Most vendor frames are wider. VERIFIED in the by-law.

RULE: order the face as 3.0 m by 6.0 m. State "outside dimensions including all trim, no more than 19.00 m2." Trim is the metal edging around the screen, the same as the frame.

An 8 ft by 16 ft face (11.9 m2) needs about 40 m of frontage, not 63 m. That roughly doubles the number of Yonge Street lots that can hold it. It also saves an estimated \$44,000 on the screen alone.

Careful: Most plazas are only allowed one ground sign on the street side of the lot. So your board is usually a rebuild of the landlord's existing pylon, carrying the tenant name panels and your screen on one pole, not a second pole beside it. Get the town to confirm this reading in writing first. See Part 7, Getting the Permits.

The four parts of a board

Part	What it is	Size and weight	Who builds it
The screen	LED display	About 1,800 to 4,000 lb, or 800 to 1,800 kg	A display supplier
The steel structure	Monopole plus the screen frame	The steel alone is an estimated 3,000 to 8,000 lb	A steel fabricator, often the same company as the screen
The foundation	A caisson: a drilled shaft of rebar and concrete	About 5 ft wide, 15 ft deep, roughly one truck of concrete	A drilling contractor
The power hookup	Wire, a small panel, and a safety switch to the power company	Draws up to 15.5 kW at full brightness, about 4 kW on average	A licensed electrician plus the power company

The Ontario Building Code requires an engineering package stamped by a **P.Eng** (an engineer licensed in Ontario) for signs over 115 kg. A US engineer's stamp is not enough for a permit.

Who builds it: real companies

Company	City	Phone or email	What they do
Media Resources	Oakville	1-800-667-4554, info@mediaresources.com	Engineers, manufactures, installs and services digital boards, best fit for a first board
Daktronics Canada	Burlington	1-888-325-7446	Screens, control software, financing
Nummax	Quebec City	1-877-255-3471	Canadian-made outdoor screens
Formetco	Georgia, USA	1-800-367-6382	Screens and structures, installs in Canada
Steel Art Signs	Richmond Hill	1-800-771-6971, sales@steelart.com	Local sign fabricator, building since 1949
Pride Visual Solutions	Cambridge	1-877-551-5529, info@pridevisualsolutions.com	Sign fabricator, has built for car dealerships before
Rouge Hill Consulting	Toronto	437-833-7817, permits@rougehillconsulting.com	Runs the whole tender for you, checks the work
Signature Engineering	Ontario-wide	519-572-2409, chris.sharpe@signatureengineering.ca	The engineer who stamps the drawings

Careful: Daktronics Canada's published standard sizes start at 11 ft by 22 ft, about 22.5 m², over the 19.00 m² cap. No 10 by 20 or 8 by 16 is listed. Confirm in writing that they will build your smaller size before sending an RFQ.

Tip: Pride Visual Solutions has built signs for car dealerships before. If your own workplace has a pylon sign, ask who built it. That call can open a door for pricing and references. Get your employer's written consent for your side business first. See Part 11.

Asking three companies for quotes, and comparing them

Send the same one-page RFQ to at least three suppliers. State the size, the site (a Yonge Street plaza pylon) and exactly what you need priced.

Ask each company before you sign:

Question to ask each company	Why it matters
Total price in Canadian dollars, HST shown separately	US web prices hide duty, freight and Canadian certification
Does the exact screen carry a cULus or CSA mark (an independent lab's fire and shock safety label), with a certificate	Ontario's electrical safety office can refuse to connect an unmarked screen
How many years of warranty on parts and on labour	A 5-year warranty is a real trade-off against a 10-year one
Who is the Ontario P.Eng, and what is their licence number	No Ontario stamp means no permit

Question to ask each company	Why it matters
How many weeks from order to a working board	Fabrication alone runs 4 to 8 weeks, the screen another 6 to 8
Two Ontario references you can phone	A company with no Ontario references is a bigger risk
What is excluded from the price	A quote with no exclusions listed usually hides extras

RULE: refuse any quote missing an Ontario P.Eng's name, a safety mark, an insurance certificate, or a WSIB (Workplace Safety and Insurance Board, Ontario's workers' compensation body) clearance number. See the constructor rules below.

Question	Company A	Company B	Company C
Total price, HST separate			
Safety mark and certificate, yes or no			
Warranty, parts and labour			
P.Eng name and licence number			
Weeks to a working board			
Two Ontario references			
What is excluded			

Hydro and inspection

Hydro is the Canadian word for electricity.

Alectra connects the wire. The **Electrical Safety Authority (ESA)**, Ontario's electrical safety regulator, inspects the work before Alectra turns the power on.

Situation	Realistic time to power-on
Reusing the landlord's existing electrical supply	1 to 3 months
A brand new metered connection, no upgrade needed	3 to 5 months
Alectra has to build new equipment to serve the site	6 to 9 months or more

Alectra replies to a request within 15 days and makes a firm written offer, the **Offer to Connect**, within 60 days. The ESA charges a billboard connection fee of \$143.

RULE: do not take out the City permit or order the steel before the written offer arrives. File the formal request no later than January 31, 2027, to protect the August 1, 2027 go-live target.

A 6-month notice rule applies only if Alectra must expand its own equipment. A plain connection that reuses the landlord's supply skips that rule.

Being your own general contractor, safely

RULE: for a first board, hire ONE prime contractor. That is a turnkey supplier (one company that does most of the work) such as Media Resources, or one consultant named in writing to act as constructor, such as Rouge Hill Consulting.

Ontario safety law names one person in charge of site safety, the **constructor**, with real legal duties. **Careful:** if you hire more than one contractor, someone must sign as constructor. If nobody does, the law will likely name your company by default.

Becoming the constructor means three things:

1. You must file a **Notice of Project** with the Ministry of Labour before work starts. This applies above \$50,000 of labour and materials, which a board far exceeds.
2. You must collect a valid **WSIB clearance certificate** from each contractor before work starts. Without one, you can be held responsible for a contractor's unpaid WSIB premiums.
3. Neither owner should do the physical construction labour.

If no contractor will take the role, you end up as constructor. Expect paperwork and time, not extra money.

Cost lines: what the money actually buys

Three cases, each before an 8 percent contingency:

- **Smart build:** \$130,000. A smaller screen, reusing the landlord's existing pole.
- **Likely:** \$175,000. The case used everywhere else in this guide.
- **Stress:** \$225,000. The worst realistic prices.

The Likely breakdown below is an **ESTIMATE**, built from the lowest prices vendors have published, not a written quote.

Line	Likely cost	What it means
Screen, controller, software, spare parts	\$100,000	The biggest line, roughly 57 percent of the total
Steel structure and foundation	\$35,000	Foundation drilling alone is \$5,000 to \$20,000, step 10
Crane, installation labour, commissioning	\$12,000	The lift alone is \$3,000 to \$7,000, step 11
Electrical work and data connection	\$9,000	Wiring on site, not counting Alectra's own connection cost
Soft costs: engineer, soil report, survey, permits, legal	\$15,000	Survey, soil and engineer ranges are in step 4
Freight, customs brokerage, duty	\$3,000	Tariff risk covered below
Subtotal, rounded	\$175,000	The six lines add to \$174,000, rounded to the Likely number
Contingency, 8 percent	\$14,000	Reserve on the \$175,000 subtotal
Total with contingency	about \$189,000	\$175,000 + \$14,000. The cash number to plan for

Two trade measures now add cost. A 25 percent steel surtax has applied since December 26, 2025. A 50 percent counter-tariff on US-made steel and monitors has applied since September 8, 2026. A US screen billed as a monitor, not a light panel, could carry it: about \$55,000 extra on a \$110,000 display. **Tip:** an Ontario-fabricated pole avoids both extra charges. Ask each quote where the steel is actually made, and get the tariff classification in writing too.

Timeline: from a signed permit to a working board

Step	Who	How long
Survey, soil report, engineer's drawings, run together	Surveyor, geotechnical firm, P.Eng	2 to 3 weeks
Comparing quotes and checking references	You	About 1 week
Steel fabrication	Fabricator	4 to 8 weeks
Screen manufacturing and shipping	Supplier	6 to 8 weeks
Drilling and pouring the foundation	Drilling contractor	1 to 2 days, plus concrete cure time set by the engineer
Crane day, pole and screen set in place	Installer, crane operator	1 to 2 days
Electrical hookup, ESA inspection, Alectra energizes	Electrician, ESA, Alectra	1 to 2 weeks
Testing, training, engineer's final sign-off	Supplier, P.Eng, town inspector	1 to 3 days

Plan 3 to 6 months from permit to lights on, with steel and screen built in parallel. That matches the August 1, 2027 target, as long as the hydro connection does not need an expansion.

What you do:

1. **You**, write one line describing the board: size, site, single or double face. Free. One day.
2. **You and your co-founder**, decide whether to hire one prime contractor or a consultant. Budget 3 to 5 percent of build cost for a consultant, roughly \$5,000 to \$9,000 on a \$175,000 build. One week.
3. **You**, send the RFQ to at least three suppliers from the company table. Free to ask. Allow 2 to 4 weeks for written answers.
4. **You**, in parallel, book a surveyor, a geotechnical firm, and an Ontario P.Eng. Roughly \$1,500 to \$5,000 for the survey. \$3,500 to \$8,000 for soil. \$2,000 to \$6,000 for the engineer. 2 to 3 weeks.
5. **You**, with your co-founder reading the technical answers, compare the quotes using the tables above. Phone two references per finalist. One week, no cost.
6. **You**, file the formal Alectra connection request no later than January 31, 2027. No fixed cost yet. Actual cost follows once Alectra makes its offer, up to 60 days.
7. **You**, sign the winning contract only after the permit is issued. Four of six slots must be signed too, the pre-sale gate from Part 5. Have a construction lawyer read it first, about \$300 to \$600.
8. **The prime contractor, or you if acting as constructor**, file the Notice of Project. Collect a WSIB clearance certificate from every contractor before work begins. Free, but do not skip it.
9. **The fabricator and supplier**, build once the contract and permit are in hand. 4 to 8 weeks for steel. 6 to 8 weeks for the screen, often overlapping.
10. **The drilling contractor, watched by the P.Eng**, pours the foundation. \$5,000 to \$20,000, an ESTIMATE. 1 to 2 days plus cure time.

11. **The installer and crane operator** set the pole and screen on one crane day. Roughly \$3,000 to \$7,000 for the lift. 1 to 2 days.
12. **The electrician, then the ESA, then Alectra**, complete the hookup and turn the power on. \$5,000 to \$25,000, an ESTIMATE. Alectra's own actual cost stays UNKNOWN until they quote it. 1 to 2 weeks.
13. **The supplier and P.Eng**, commission the board, train you both, then sign off. Usually included in the contract price. 1 to 3 days.
14. **You**, load the first paid ads and go live. Ongoing from here, moving into Part 10, Running the Board.

Part 9. Getting Customers

In one sentence: Pre-sell four of the six slots to local Yonge Street businesses by January 31, 2027, at \$1,400 or more per 4 weeks for a full year, before you order any screen or steel.

Facts below are VERIFIED, checked September 21, 2026, unless marked otherwise.

Who to call first

Numbers come from business directories and each company's website. Confirm every phone number before you write anyone into a contract.

Category	Example, name and phone	Why they are a good first call
Independent mortgage brokers	Kamran Etessam, 647-931-3639, and Mike Tabesh, 7191 Yonge, 416-875-3300	They decide their own ads. Bank staff on Yonge, like TD's (Toronto-Dominion Bank) Parmida Hosseini or RBC's (Royal Bank of Canada) Farideh Frouzesh, usually cannot. Head office controls bank advertising.
Persian-speaking realtors	Hans Team, Reza Ghamsari, 13025 Yonge, 647-822-4243, and Farzad Seifi, 1550 16th Ave, 416-666-9975	Spring listing season matters to them, as does being known in a neighbourhood.
Immigration and law offices	Iranian Legal Services, 7368 Yonge, 416-849-7081, and Ghasemi Law, 9030 Leslie, 416-887-9200	They sell on trust and want to be seen on the street their clients live on.
Currency exchanges	Taheri Exchange, 5775 Yonge, Toronto, 416-488-8822	Must be registered with FINTRAC to advertise legally; see the FINTRAC rule below. Cap this category at 2 of the 6 slots.
Grocers and food shops	Madani, 12977 Yonge, 905-773-2323, and Super Parsian, 8129 Yonge, 905-709-1400	Their peak seasons are Nowruz (Persian New Year, spring) and Shab-e Yalda (longest night, December). Exact dates are under Seasonal Peaks.
Dentists and clinics	Rose Hill Dental, 9580 Yonge, 905-237-7014, and Dr. Mohammad Kashefi, 10610 Bayview, 905-780-8444	New-patient offers work well on a daily-drive board.
Event promoters	Eventorian, 315 Steelcase Rd E, Markham, and EMH Productions	They buy short 2 to 3 week bursts before a concert or festival.
Independent auto dealers	Independent, owner-run dealers only. Not owned by the same brand as your employer, and not a competitor of your employer. Example: Volkswagen Richmond Hill, 10440 Yonge, 905-889-7701, family owned since 1958	See the dealership rule in Part 11 before you approach any dealer.
Driving and tutoring schools	Young Drivers of Canada, Richmond Hill	Back-to-school and spring are their busy seasons.

Category	Example, name and phone	Why they are a good first call
Plaza tenants near the pole	Ask the landlord to introduce you	They already know the traffic on that street.

The FINTRAC rule for currency exchanges

RULE: before you sign any currency exchange, ask for its FINTRAC registration number and check it yourself on FINTRAC's public list at fintrac-canafe.canada.ca/msb-esm/reg-eng.csv. Search it for the exchange's name. Write into the contract: you may remove the ad at once, with no refund, if status ever shows anything but "Registered." Check again on the day you sign; the list changes every month.

FINTRAC is Canada's financial watchdog. A currency exchange is a **money services business (MSB)** and must be registered with it before offering any service, so before advertising on a billboard. FINTRAC cancelled 18 Yonge Street exchange registrations in 2026 alone; others have expired or stopped.

The Persian-community edge

No Persian-owned business was found advertising on any Greater Toronto Area (GTA) billboard in available records (not proof it never happened), and no competing board speaks to this community in its own neighbourhood.

In Richmond Hill, about 11.6% of residents, roughly 1 in 9, call Persian their mother tongue (2021 census). About 20,345 residents trace their background to Iran, per the same census.

ESTIMATE: this population number was copied from another website's summary of the census, not read directly from Statistics Canada's own report. Treat it as roughly right, not exact.

Bazaarche.ca, a business directory, lists 594 verified Iranian-owned businesses in the area.

Two Persian-language media outlets can make introductions but do not sell billboard space: Iran Star newspaper, 647-674-4048, and Radio Sedaye Iran, 905-886-2540 (on air). UNKNOWN: Iran Star may have stopped printing; its newest issue online is dated April 2025. Call to confirm before you rely on it.

RULE: at least 50% of the words on the sign must be in English or French. Persian text can appear beside it, but cannot be the whole message. Part 11 covers this and other content rules in full.

Pricing and rate card

Term	Price per 4 weeks	Off list	What it means
4 weeks	\$1,900	0%	The list price
12 weeks	\$1,750	8%	\$5,250 for 12 weeks
26 weeks	\$1,650	13%	\$10,725 for 26 weeks
52 weeks	\$1,500	21%	\$19,500 for the whole year
Founding advertiser, 52 weeks	\$1,400	26%	First four advertisers only, price locked for one year

HST, 13% in Ontario, is added on top of every price here. Most early sales will be direct: a direct local advertiser pays list price and you keep the full amount. Agencies get 15% off gross price. A founding advertiser pays about \$50 a day (\$1,400 divided by 28 days).

These prices are the plan's own proposal, based on comparable nearby boards, not market fact.

A \$1,600 slot is fair at a \$2.50 to \$3.50 CPM, which needs about 16,500 vehicles a day in one direction. Yonge Street's two-way count is roughly 25,000 to 35,000 vehicles a day, so one direction is about 12,500 to 17,500. Buy the AADT (average annual daily traffic) count for this stretch from York Region, \$160, before locking a final price, and judge it by the one-direction number. Don't copy other billboard companies' "daily impressions" claims onto your own materials. Some competitors' numbers don't match their own prices when you check the math, so treat them as marketing, not fact.

Pre-selling, before you build anything

RULE: never order the screen or the steel before two things happen: four of the six slots signed, and the town's permit in hand.

1. **Letter of intent (LOI):** a one-page paper. The business says it would like a slot once the board is built, and it states a price. No money changes hands, and it does not bind the advertiser. It shows real interest, to you and to a lender.
2. **Signed order with a deposit:** once the permit and the land lease are both signed, turn each LOI into a real order. The advertiser pays a deposit of 10% of the year's price. It is held in trust, in a separate account the company cannot spend, and refunded in full if the board never goes live. On a \$1,400 x 13 year, that is \$1,820 per slot.

Worked example: four signed slots at \$1,400 each, for a full year, equals \$72,800 of revenue ($\$1,400 \times 13$ periods $\times 4$ slots). That is close to the plan's Likely case (the middle revenue estimate): 6 slots at \$1,600, 60% full, \$74,880 a year.

The pitch

Pre-sale pitch: say you are not selling anything today. State the board is not built yet, and ask for ten minutes to show a mock-up of their ad. Do not say "guaranteed" or "sold out soon." Only say the permit is approved if it truly is. Do not drop your price right away when someone says "too expensive." Each slot plays about 1,800 times a day.

Give every advertiser real proof once the board is live:

1. A unique phone number or promo word, made only for their board ad.
2. A "how did you hear about us" question for their staff to ask new customers.

Neither is a promise of sales. Never claim the ad caused a sale.

Contracts and payment

Use an insertion order with these terms:

1. Billed every 4 weeks, in advance.
2. HST added on top.

3. A deposit of 10% of the year's price, held in trust, in a separate account the company cannot spend.
4. No cancelling in the first 12 weeks.
5. After that, 30 days' written notice to cancel.
6. The ad plays at least 92.5% of the paid time. You owe a credit for any **shortfall**, the part that did not play.
7. If the town removes the permit, unused periods are refunded in full. Nothing more is owed.

RULE: Canada's Interest Act, section 4, caps late-payment interest quoted per month at 5% a year, unless the contract also states the yearly rate. A contract cannot write only "1.5% a month"; it must also say the yearly rate, such as "18% a year," or the monthly figure does not apply.

Seasonal peaks

When	What happens	Who to call before it
Around October 8, 2026	Mehregan, an autumn Persian festival	Grocers, event promoters
December 21, 2026	Shab-e Yalda	Grocers, bakeries, restaurants
January	The slowest month for home sales in the GTA	Not the month to pitch realtors
March 21, 2027	Nowruz	Grocers, restaurants, exchanges, travel agents, event promoters
April to May	Peak home-buying season	Realtors, mortgage brokers
October 28 and December 9, 2026	Bank of Canada rate announcements	Mortgage brokers, whose ad copy can change the same day rates do

What you do

1. Starting October 2026, call the first ten names above. Use Farsi when the owner prefers. Log the date and the answer for each call.
2. Visit Persian-owned shops on Yonge Street with your co-founder. If one of you already knows people in the community, let them lead the introductions. This community buys mostly by referral and in person.
3. Buy the York Region traffic count, \$160, before setting a final price. Allow 3 business days for it to arrive.
4. Check every currency exchange against the FINTRAC list before signing. Check again on the day you sign.
5. Collect four signed letters of intent. Price: \$1,400 or more per 4 weeks, for a full year. Deadline: January 31, 2027. This is the pre-sale gate, the plan's own sales target. It is not "Gate 1," a different deadline for power-connection paperwork. Part 11 explains Gate 1.
6. Once the permit and the land lease are both signed, turn each letter of intent into a signed order. Collect its deposit (10% of the year's price) and hold it in trust, in a separate account the company cannot spend.
7. Once the board is live, expected around August 2027, send every advertiser a proof-of-play report every 4 weeks. Show how often the ad played, with photos.

Part 10. Running the Board

Checked September 21, 2026. Figures marked as estimates are the research team's own, not published industry numbers.

Hours needed, by phase

Phase	Combined hours a week	Why
First 90 days live	20 to 30 hours	Learning the routine, first renewals, early faults
Steady state, 4 to 6 of 6 slots sold	9 to 14 hours	Checks, invoicing, occasional sales calls
Under 60 percent sold (3 or fewer slots)	12 to 18 hours	Selling takes over more of the week

What software runs the board

Pick a screen whose maker includes the CMS free.

Software	Maker	Cost
Ignite OA	Watchfire	Free for the life of the display, Watchfire's own claim
Venus Control Suite	Daktronics	Not published, ask in the quote
Nummax Manager	Nummax	Not published, ask in the quote
Blip	A marketplace, not a display maker	No upfront fee, only use it to sell leftover time

Careful: Blip's own pages list US locations only, in 46 states. Nobody has confirmed it will list a Canadian board. Ask Blip in writing before counting on it.

A good CMS monitors the board and emails you on a fault. **Tip:** send the alert to two emails, yours and your co-founder's, so a fault is never missed because one person is away.

A normal week, once slots are selling

Roughly 2 to 3 hours a week for your co-founder and 3 to 5 hours for you on running the board itself. The day-by-day slotting comes from vendor guidance and industry practice, not one published source, so treat it as a starting point.

Day	Who	Task	Time
Every day	Either of you	Glance at the CMS dashboard, confirm it is online	5 minutes
Monday	Your co-founder	Walk to the site, photograph the lit face, check for litter, ice, or damage	30 minutes
Tuesday	You	Load any new or changed ads due this week, check each against the rules below	60 minutes

Day	Who	Task	Time
Wednesday	You	Sales calls or visits to advertiser prospects	60 to 90 minutes
Thursday	Your co-founder	Visit one or two nearby advertisers, speaking their language where that helps	30 to 60 minutes
Friday	You	Send invoices due soon, check the bank	30 minutes

A normal month, one 4-week billing period

Advertisers are billed every 4 weeks, not monthly: 13 periods a year. Each takes roughly 6.5 to 7.5 hours of paperwork, on top of the weekly routine.

Week of the period	Task	Time
Week 1, billing day	Send invoices, swap in new ads, send each advertiser a Proof of Play report	2 hours
Week 2	Bookkeeping: match the bank statement, pay the landlord's share, check the power bill	2 to 3 hours
Week 3	Compliance check: screenshot the dimming schedule , test alerts reach both phones, count spare parts	1 hour
Week 4	Renewals: contact any advertiser whose slot ends within 8 weeks	1.5 hours

Making the ads

The screen is 3.0 m by 6.0 m, roughly 300 by 600 pixels at the planned pixel pitch. Confirm the exact count with your supplier before building any template.

Rules the file must follow:

- A plain picture file, either JPG or PNG, never a video. Richmond Hill's by-law bans movement inside the message.
- At least half the words must be English or French. This is Richmond Hill's rule. Farsi can be a helper line underneath, not the main line.
- Big, bold text. Aim for 6 to 8 words and one logo, readable from a moving car.

Design work cost: no Ontario price list exists, so these are estimates. Free if the advertiser sends a finished file. \$100 to \$200 from your own template. \$300 to \$600 for a fully custom design. A \$150 fee on a \$1,750 booking adds under 9 percent.

What breaks, and how to fix it

Ask your supplier to include spare modules with the board: 3 to 5 percent of the screen cost, roughly \$3,000 to \$5,000 on the \$100,000 screen line.

Makers such as Watchfire and Daktronics offer a 10-year brightness guarantee. It usually skips the crane needed to reach a module on the pole, so ask about that cost separately.

Plan two preventive maintenance visits a year, spring and fall, at an estimated \$500 to \$1,500 each. Add a yearly maintenance reserve of \$2,000 to \$4,000 for unplanned repairs.

Weather

Ask your supplier, in writing, to confirm the operating temperature range, about minus 30 to plus 50 Celsius. After an ice storm, check for ice on top of the screen that could fall, and rope off the area below until it is gone. Rinse salt spray off the face each spring.

For lightning, ask your electrician for a surge protector at the power panel and a proper ground wire on the pole. Confirm your insurer knows both are in place.

Insurance claims

Plan roughly \$4,500 a year for insurance, covering liability, property damage, equipment breakdown, and cyber risk. Federated Insurance, the Ontario Sign Association's recommended insurer, is at 1-844-628-6800. Also get quotes from a few independent brokers.

If the screen or pole is damaged (vehicle, vandalism, fire, storm):

1. Make the site safe first, for example roping off a fallen piece.
2. Photograph everything before touching anything.
3. Call the police if it involves a vehicle or vandalism.
4. Tell your insurer within 24 hours.
5. Do not start repairs until the adjuster has looked at it.
6. Send affected advertisers a short notice that their ad is temporarily off.

RULE: never repair the board before the adjuster clears it. The insurer can refuse to pay otherwise.

Neighbours' complaints

A neighbour's complaint, often about brightness, is a permit risk, because a repeat complaint can bring the town back to review your permit.

What you do when a complaint comes in:

1. Answer within 24 hours.
2. Write down who called, what they said, and the brightness setting at that hour.
3. Check the automatic dimming is working as programmed.
4. Offer a small brightness adjustment if it is reasonable.
5. Reply in writing, in English, from you personally.

Keep a **compliance file** with the permit, the engineer's report, quarterly brightness photos, and every complaint.

Monthly paperwork

HST (Ontario's sales tax) is 13 percent on every invoice. A \$1,600 booking becomes \$1,808, an extra \$208. You owe the HST on the date you send the invoice, even if unpaid.

A late-fee clause is enforceable only if the contract states the yearly rate, for example "2 percent per month, 24 percent per year." Without that yearly rate written down, the law caps you at 5 percent a year.

Wave is free software for invoices and payment tracking. Register for HST from day one of the company so you can claim back the HST paid during the build. The plan's figure is about \$9,750 back, an ESTIMATE on non-screen spending. It could reach \$22,750 if HST applies to more than the leased screen.

First 90 days live: a checklist

The day numbers are the plan's own targets, from its gates (Part 5).

1. **60 days before go-live.** You confirm the insurance policy is bound for go-live day.
2. **30 days before go-live.** You and your co-founder load ads into the loop, including the landlord's slot. Test that alerts reach both phones.
3. **Go-live day.** You photograph the board's first play. Send the first round of invoices in advance for the next period.
4. **Day 7.** Your co-founder does the first weekly site walk and photo log.
5. **Day 28, end of period 1.** You send the first Proof of Play report to every advertiser. Invoice period 2. Match the bank statement.
6. **Day 60.** Both of you do the first compliance check of the brightness log and complaint log.
7. **Day 90.** Both of you review against the plan's numbers. Check how many slots are billing. Check uptime against the industry example of 95 to 98 percent, so up to about 14 to 36 hours dark a month is still normal.
8. **Ongoing.** The plan's stop rule is under 45 percent full at month 12 (fewer than 3 of 6 slots). That triggers a hard look at fixing, selling, or winding down the board.

What you do:

1. **You**, pick a screen whose CMS is free before you buy. Set fault alerts to both your emails. Free. Decide this before the build is finished.
2. **Your co-founder**, do the weekly site walk and photo log every Monday. Free. 30 minutes a week.
3. **You**, load and check new ad files each week they are due. Free. About 1 hour a week.
4. **Both of you**, run the 4-week billing cycle. Follow the monthly table above. No extra cost. About 6.5 to 7.5 hours per period.
5. **You**, register for HST on day one. File monthly at first so the build-year credit comes back sooner. Free to register. Ongoing.
6. **You**, get insurance quotes from Federated Insurance and at least two independent brokers before go-live. Roughly \$4,500 a year. Start 60 days before go-live.
7. **Both of you**, answer any complaint within 24 hours. Log it in the compliance file. Free. Ongoing.
8. **You**, if there is ever damage, follow the six insurance-claim steps above. Wait for the adjuster before repairing. Cost depends on the damage, covered by insurance up to the policy limit. As needed.
9. **You**, work through the first-90-days checklist above in order, starting 60 days before go-live. No new cost. Runs to day 90.
10. **Both of you**, watch the month-12 occupancy number against the 45 percent stop rule. If the board is under that line, meet and decide together. Free. Check monthly from month 6 onward.

Part 11. Setting Up the Business

Facts below are VERIFIED, checked September 21, 2026, unless marked otherwise. Nothing here is legal or tax advice.

The company

Incorporate under the **Ontario Business Corporations Act (OBCA)**. Cost: \$300, filed online, ready the same day.

RULE: incorporate in Ontario, not federally, and not as a partnership.

Why not the alternatives:

- **Federal corporation (CBCA):** at least 25% of directors must be "resident Canadians." Ontario has no such rule.
- **Partnership:** each partner can bind the other personally, and both carry unlimited personal liability.

Detail: CBCA section 105(3) sets the residency requirement. Section 2(1) defines "resident Canadian": a citizen who lives in Canada, or a permanent resident who lives here, but only up to one year past the date they became eligible for citizenship.

The bank account

Open a business account in the corporation's name right after incorporation. Bring a **source of funds pack:** a written explanation of where the starting money comes from, backed by documents.

If any startup money has passed through Iran, or sits in an account connected to Iran, plan for extra questions and time. Canadian banks must treat every transaction to or from Iran as high risk, at any dollar amount. They must ask where the money came from, verify identity, and report it.

DO: start with money already in a Canadian bank account with a clear history. Keep every paper: sale documents, old bank statements, salary records. Have them translated and certified if written in Farsi. Tell your bank in person, before a large amount arrives, not after.

DO NOT: split a deposit into smaller amounts to stay under the \$10,000 reporting line. This is called **structuring**, and it is treated as suspicious on its own, whatever the real reason. Do not use an unregistered exchange house to move money, or an informal money network such as hawala. Running one without registering is a federal offence, and a customer can end up holding someone else's illegal money without knowing it.

Part 12, "Money: where it comes from," covers every funding source.

HST

RULE: register for HST on day one, and choose **monthly filing** at registration, not the yearly default. A small new company does not have to register yet, but early registration lets you claim back the 13% on the steel, the screen, the lawyer, and every other building cost. About \$19,500 could be recovered on a \$150,000 build.

HST (harmonized sales tax) is 13% in Ontario and applies to most goods and services, including advertising. HST you pay on your own purchases comes back as an **input tax credit (ITC)** once you are registered.

Worked example: a \$45,000 construction bill carries \$5,850 of HST. With monthly filing, that \$5,850 is normally refunded about 4 weeks after you file the return, instead of up to a year later. The tax office (CRA) can pull a large first refund for review before it pays. This guide's planning adds 8 to 10 more weeks for that review. CRA does not publish how long a review takes, so plan your cash for the slower case too.

Insurance

Budget about \$4,500 a year for one board. The range is \$2,500 to \$11,000.

No Canadian insurer publishes a ready-made billboard program. The closest connection is Federated Insurance, the Ontario Sign Association's recommended insurer, 1-844-628-6800. Also get written quotes from 3 to 4 licensed brokers.

Insurance line	Low	Likely	High
Liability (commercial general liability, CGL), landlord named	\$800	\$1,500	\$2,500
Property and equipment breakdown	\$900	\$1,800	\$3,500
Cyber and advertising liability	\$250	\$750	\$1,500
Excess liability to \$5M, only if the lease or lender requires it	\$0	\$1,000	\$3,000
Sum of the lines above	\$1,950	\$5,050	\$10,500
Total, our plan for	\$2,500 to \$3,500	about \$4,500	\$8,000 to \$11,000

The "Total" row is a rounded recommendation, not the plain sum. It builds in a cushion because a landlord, lender, or lease may require the excess-liability line even in a low year. Do not sign a lease or loan without a written quote in hand. The landlord, the lender, and any road-crane permit will each want proof of coverage.

RULE: never let a crane lift the screen without insurance in force. You need your own CGL and the crane operator's own coverage too.

WSIB

WSIB (Workplace Safety and Insurance Board) is Ontario's mandatory workers' compensation system. It also protects a business from being sued directly for a workplace injury.

Class L (general advertising, what your company mostly is): \$0.18 per \$100 of payroll. Class G5 (construction): \$2.15 per \$100 of payroll, more than ten times as much.

Using outside contractors to install and maintain the structure, instead of your own crew, supports Class L. WSIB alone decides the final class, and no one, including this guide, can promise Class L in advance. Get every contractor's current WSIB clearance certificate before they start work. Without it, you can be held responsible for their unpaid premiums.

RULE: register with WSIB within 10 calendar days of hiring your first employee who is not an owner.

Lawyer

Have a lawyer draft the shareholder agreement, a site lease template, and an advertiser order-form template. Expect roughly \$2,000 to \$9,000 in total, depending on how much is custom drafted.

Typical cost, from 2026 Ontario price guides:

1. Incorporation plus the shareholder agreement: about \$2,000 to \$5,000.
2. Site lease and advertiser order-form templates: about \$1,500 to \$4,000.

Free first step: the Law Society Referral Service gives a free 30-minute consultation with a lawyer at findlegalhelp.ca.

Accountant

T2 (annual corporate return): about \$1,200 to \$3,500 a year for clean books. Bookkeeping: about \$200 to \$800 a month if you do not keep the books yourselves. Have the accountant confirm the TOSI position before any dividend is paid (see the shareholder agreement section). These are general Ontario small-business ranges, not a quote for this company.

The employer consent note

You are a full-time employee elsewhere.

RULE: write your manager a short letter now. Say plainly that you are starting a separate billboard advertising business, on your own time, with your own money. Ask for written acknowledgement and keep the reply.

Ontario's Employment Standards Act, section 67.2, makes most non-compete clauses void (in effect since 2021), so an employer generally cannot stop an employee from starting a side business. A separate, older rule still applies while you are employed there: the **duty of loyalty**. You cannot use work time, your employer's customer lists, or its resources for the billboard business. Do not sell ad space to your employer's direct competitor.

The shareholder agreement

The agreement should cover:

1. Who does which job, and how many hours a week.
2. How salary and dividends get decided.
3. What happens if one person wants to leave, or cannot keep working.
4. Who buys the other out, and at what price.

5. How disagreements get settled, before they reach a courtroom.

If you are married, Ontario's Family Law Act treats company shares as property that can be divided in a separation. Otherwise a court decides later, so settle it in advance in a marriage contract or a clause in the shareholder agreement.

If you or your co-founder lends the company money, write it down clearly as either a loan or a gift. A documented loan is the cleanest way to get that money back out, and it avoids extra tax later. Charge at least CRA's prescribed rate: 3% for the last quarter of 2026. A gift is simpler but gone for good: it cannot later be taken back out of the company tax-free.

Detail: if you and your co-founder are related, whether by blood, marriage, or common law, **TOSI** (tax on split income) applies to both of you. TOSI can tax a dividend at the highest personal tax rate unless an exception applies. One exception: working 20 hours a week or more in the business, with timesheets to prove it. Whoever does not clear that hours test should take no dividends until the accountant confirms another exception, such as owning 10% or more of the shares. TOSI never touches salary, only dividends.

Your co-founder's immigration status, and what each one allows

Status	Own shares	Be paid	Work day to day	Run the company
Canadian citizen	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Permanent resident	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Protected person or refugee, with a valid open work permit	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes, if permit valid
Open work permit, other category	Yes	Yes, if valid	Yes	Ask an immigration lawyer
Employer-specific work permit	Yes, passively only	Only by the named employer	No	No
Study permit	Yes, passively only	Only inside a 24-hour weekly work cap	Limited hours only	No
Visitor	Passive ownership only	No	No	No

Even the "Yes" rows do not settle **self-employment**. That needs its own written answer from a professional.

To place your co-founder in a row, check the exact document, their age, how long they have held it, and whether it allows self-employment. IRCC, Canada's immigration department, has not clearly published whether an open work permit allows running a company.

RULE: if your co-founder is not a Canadian citizen or a permanent resident, get their immigration status confirmed in writing before they do any paid or unpaid work in the company. Get it from a **Regulated Canadian Immigration Consultant (RCIC)** or an immigration lawyer, and it must state exactly what their status allows. Call IRCC at 1-888-242-2100 for a starting point. Do not rely on a phone call alone for a final answer.

Rules a billboard owner must obey about ad content

The law holds you partly responsible, as the publisher, for what appears on the board, not only the advertiser who paid for it.

RED, never run these, whatever the advertiser offers: cannabis, tobacco, or vaping ads. Federal law bans all three from public billboards outright. No exception for outdoor signs was found anywhere in the rules.

YELLOW, check before you run these: liquor ads should stay at least 200 metres from a school, by a provincial guideline. Currency exchange ads need a current FINTRAC registration, checked the day you sign, as explained in Part 9. **FINTRAC** is Canada's financial watchdog for money-related businesses. Mortgage broker ads must show the brokerage's licensed name and licence number. Real estate ads must show the brokerage's full registered name. During the Ontario municipal election period around October 2026, an election ad has extra rules: collect the advertiser's name and contact details in writing, and keep them for four years, open to public inspection, along with a copy of the ad and its price.

GREEN, generally fine, with ordinary honesty rules: everyday ads for shops, brokers, realtors, restaurants, and services, as long as nothing in them is false or misleading. Canada's Competition Act bans any ad that knowingly or recklessly misleads the public, and holds a publisher responsible if it knowingly lets a misleading ad run.

RULE: at least 50% of the words on the sign must be in English or French. This is Richmond Hill's sign by-law.

Sources and citations:

- Cannabis Act, section 17.
- Tobacco and Vaping Products Act, section 22.
- Competition Act, section 52.
- Municipal Elections Act, section 88.5.

What you do

1. Incorporate an Ontario corporation once you and your co-founder agree to proceed. Cost \$300, done online, same day.
2. Open a business bank account right after incorporation. Have a written source-of-funds explanation ready if any startup money has touched Iran.
3. Register for HST the same week as incorporation. Choose monthly filing at the moment of registration.
4. Send your manager a written disclosure letter before any paid billboard work. Keep the written reply on file.
5. You and your co-founder: meet a lawyer together. Start with the free Law Society Referral Service, to draft the shareholder agreement. Allow 2 to 4 weeks once started.
6. If your co-founder is not a Canadian citizen or a permanent resident, get their immigration status confirmed in writing, by an RCIC or immigration lawyer, before they do any paid or unpaid work in the company. Finish this before Gate 1, January 31, 2027, the deadline to file power-connection paperwork with Alectra, the local electric utility.
7. Request written insurance quotes from Federated Insurance and at least three **RIBO**-licensed brokers (Registered Insurance Brokers of Ontario). Allow 2 to 4 weeks, and get them before signing any lease.
8. Register with WSIB within 10 calendar days of hiring your first employee, meaning the first person who is not an owner. Keep a current WSIB clearance certificate on file for every outside contractor.

Part 12. Where the Money Comes From

In one sentence: Stack sources cheapest first; the cash you put in runs from \$21,900 (Stack D) to \$128,750 (Stack A), depending on the build.

A board costs \$130,000 to \$225,000. With only about \$40,000 of your own, see the end of "Four funding stacks". Money that started in Iran has its own section below. All dollars are Canadian. Checked September 21, 2026.

Every real source of money

Money that costs nothing but your own

Your own Canadian-banked cash. Free and fastest, if you can document where it came from.

A documented family loan. A written note between family members. It must charge at least the **CRA prescribed rate**, the Canada Revenue Agency's minimum interest rate for family loans. That rate is 3% for October to December 2026 and resets every quarter. A \$30,000 loan at 3% costs \$900 a year.

A documented gift. No cost, no repayment, no interest. It needs a signed gift letter naming the giver and the amount and stating no repayment is expected, plus proof of where the money came from. Canada does not tax the person receiving a gift.

Programs that need an applicant aged 18 to 39

If you are not 18 to 39, your co-founder may qualify instead, or another program may fit better.

Futurpreneur is a national program that lends to young founders. It has three streams:

Program	Amount	Rate today	Status
Futurpreneur Core Startup	Up to \$75,000, made of up to \$25,000 from Futurpreneur plus up to \$50,000 from BDC, the federal small-business bank	Futurpreneur part 7.45%, BDC part its own floating rate plus 1.65%	Open, the website replies in 5 to 10 business days
Futurpreneur Side Hustle	Up to \$25,000	7.45%, capped at 9%	Open
Futurpreneur Newcomer	Up to \$25,000, made of two equal halves	Rate not fixed, ask when applying	Open

Every stream needs an applicant aged 18 to 39 who is a citizen or permanent resident and owns more than 50% of the voting shares. Side Hustle fits an applicant who already has a full-time income outside the business. Core Startup will not lend to a contractor or agent for another business, such as a paid rep for another billboard operator. An ordinary outside job does not count. Every stream adds a 1% fee when the loan is paid out. Core Startup also adds up to two years of a mandatory mentor.

Programs that fit your co-founder

These need a citizen or permanent resident, and usually one not working a full-time job elsewhere. If your co-founder is not a citizen or permanent resident, get their status confirmed in writing, by a licensed immigration

consultant (RCIC) or lawyer, before they do any paid or unpaid work in the company. Treat every row below as conditional on that confirmation.

Program	Amount	Rate or cost today	Status
Starter Company Plus, an Ontario grant	Up to \$5,000, taxable, needs a 25% matching contribution	Grant, not repaid	York's application window closed June 26, 2026. The next date is not published
Alterna Community Microfinance plus a BDC match	Realistically about \$15,000 from Alterna, plus a BDC match, so up to \$40,000 combined	Rate not published, ask directly	Open
ACCESS Community Capital Fund	Up to \$20,000	Rate not published	Open, needs the ACCESS Business Lab finished first
South Lake Futures or Nottawasaga Futures, two local development lenders	Up to \$300,000	Rate not published	Open, but only if the board is actually located in their service area

Alterna also has a higher tier, up to \$25,000, with a BDC match that could reach \$50,000 total. The source does not say whether the higher tier applies here. Plan on \$40,000.

UNKNOWN: what the **ACCESS Business Lab** involves. Call ACCESS at 416-462-0496.

Starter Company Plus is delivered by a free local **Small Business Enterprise Centre**. For this area that is **YSBEC** (York Small Business Enterprise Centre), covering Aurora, East Gwillimbury, Georgina, King, Newmarket and Whitchurch-Stouffville. Through YSBEC, your co-founder must work 35 hours a week with no other full-time job. The next window is expected in spring 2027, not confirmed. **Richmond Hill has its own separate Small Business Enterprise Centre** running its own Starter Company Plus. It needs the business to sit inside Richmond Hill, your co-founder to be the majority owner, and at least 3 months of mentoring (YSBEC requires 6 months). Richmond Hill is the main planned location, and Starter Company Plus is not closed to a Richmond Hill board. **UNKNOWN:** the Richmond Hill centre's application window. Ask it directly.

South Lake Futures covers East Gwillimbury, Georgina and Brock. Nottawasaga Futures covers Bradford West Gwillimbury and Innisfil. Neither covers Richmond Hill, so both help only a second or third board outside it.

Money the company itself can borrow, through a bank

CSBFP, the Canada Small Business Financing Program, is federal and shares risk with the lender. You apply through a bank, credit union or caisse, not the government.

What it covers	Limit
Term loan, for equipment, leasehold improvements and permits	Up to \$1,000,000, of which at most \$500,000 for equipment and leasehold improvements together
Working capital and permits inside that \$500,000	Up to \$150,000
Line of credit, separate from the term loan	Up to \$150,000

The term loan rate ceiling is prime plus 3%, 7.45% today. A line of credit is prime plus 5%, 9.45% today. A 2% registration fee can be added to the loan instead of paid up front. The term loan runs up to 15 years, the line of

credit up to 5.

The government guarantees 85% of the lender's loss if the business fails to pay. That is not 85% of your debt. You still owe the bank 100%, and it can require a personal guarantee, which exposes your house, car and savings if the loan defaults.

Owner labour, yours or your co-founder's unpaid work, is not an eligible cost. Installation must be **subcontracted out on paper**: hire and pay an outside installer, and document it, even if you or your co-founder help too.

A screen lease comes from a company such as Daktronics, I-View or Formetco. It often ends in a \$1 buyout, so you own the screen after the last payment. Lessors publish no rate before you ask directly. **ESTIMATE**: plan on roughly 6% to 16% a year, a guess, not a quote. This guide's planning number is 10% a year.

BDC direct loans need 12 to 24 months of revenue, so they are not usable at launch. Save this source for board two.

Money from advertisers and the landlord, not a loan but the same effect

Advertiser prepayment. Four slots signed at \$1,400 or more per 4-week period for a full year is \$72,800. This is contracted revenue with no interest paid to anyone.

ESTIMATE, from the research behind this guide: annualised cost of a prepay discount.

- A 3% discount is worth about 5.8% a year in interest.
- A 5% discount is worth about 10% a year in interest.
- A 10% discount is worth about 22% a year in interest.
- A 15% discount is worth about 36% a year in interest.

The yearly cost runs about double the discount or more, and grows faster as the discount grows, because the money arrives on average about six months early. A locked price, with no discount, rewards early advertisers far more cheaply.

The landlord reusing the existing pole and power. Some landlords already have a **lit pole** on the property, with power and lights hooked up. Reusing its steel, foundation and power can save \$15,000 to \$40,000 of build cost. In exchange, landlords usually want a bigger rent share, for example 25% instead of 20%. That is about \$3,744 a year more at the Likely case.

A silent partner, family or close friends only

Ontario's **private issuer exemption** lets a private company raise money from family, close personal friends and close business associates without a **public share sale**. It does not cover customers, co-workers or people known only online. There is no dollar limit. A lawyer must draft the paperwork, usually \$1,500 to \$4,000. You also need a signed **risk-acknowledgement form**, kept for 8 years, in which the investor states in writing they could lose the money.

Example: \$50,000 for one third of the company. As equity, that third of the Likely case's money left is about \$11,039 a year. As a loan at 8% over 5 years, the same \$50,000 costs about \$12,166 a year. Equity costs less per year, but a loan ends after 5 years and giving up a third of the company never ends. A partner can also cut your ownership to 50% or less, which disqualifies you from Futurpreneur and Starter Company Plus. Check your ownership math first.

Money that will not help, so do not waste time chasing it

- **Kiva.** Lends only inside the United States.
- **Bank newcomer packages** from RBC, TD, Scotiabank, BMO or CIBC. They waive some fees and help build Canadian credit history. None of this is a loan.
- **Equity crowdfunding** is legal in Ontario, up to \$250,000 a raise. Disclosure costs are a poor fit for one sign.
- **CDAP**, a digital technology grant, is closed. **ZEVIP** and **ChargeON** are electric vehicle charger grants, also closed or not a fit for a billboard.
- **No government grant pays for a billboard.** Plan for at most \$5,000, from Starter Company Plus, and nothing more.

Real interest rates today, all in one place

Rate	Today's number
Bank of Canada policy rate	2.25%
Prime rate, all six big banks	4.45%
CSBFP term loan ceiling	7.45%
CSBFP line of credit ceiling	9.45%
Futurpreneur	7.45%, capped at 9%
Screen lease, planning guess only	About 6% to 16%
CRA prescribed rate for family loans, Q4 2026	3%

The Bank of Canada's next rate decisions are October 28 and December 9, 2026. Every rate above except the CRA rate can move then.

The order to apply in

1. **You and your co-founder**, October 2026: settle who will be majority owner. Confirm age eligibility, immigration status and cash on hand. This decides which programs are open to each of you.
2. **You**, October 2026: incorporate the Ontario corporation for \$300. Open the company bank account in person, with documents ready.
3. **You**, October 2026 onward: line up free help before applying anywhere. Use the Futurpreneur website and its mentor, your local Small Business Enterprise Centre and the ACCES webinar series.
4. **You**, before **Gate 1**, January 31, 2027: build one lender package. It needs a business plan, a two-year monthly cash flow, vendor quotes, advertiser **letters of intent** and a landlord letter. Call three lenders informally first.
5. **You**, after Gate 1: apply to Futurpreneur, if you are majority owner. Separately, **your co-founder** can apply to Alterna plus BDC. Unlike Starter Company Plus, this does not compete with Futurpreneur's ownership rule.
6. **You**, roughly April 2027: apply for the CSBFP loan and the screen lease, once the permit, lease and four signed slots are ready.
7. **You**, at registration: choose monthly **HST** (sales tax) filing, not annual. Refunds come back faster.
8. **You**, after 12 months of real revenue: return to BDC and CSBFP for board two.

Four funding stacks, and what happens with only \$40,000

Each stack includes 8% set aside for surprises, sales tax paid up front and a \$30,000 minimum reserve. Lenders generally want coverage (money left divided by the yearly loan payment) of 1.25 or higher. An older brief used a \$100,000 board and a \$150,000 board. Those figures are wrong. Do not use them.

Stack	Build	Cash needed	Loan payment a year	Coverage
A. Cash-heavy: full \$175,000 build, screen leased, no bank loan	\$175,000	\$128,750	\$19,921	1.66, comfortable
B. Balanced: \$175,000 build, screen leased, bank loan sized to lender minimums	\$175,000	\$82,750	\$26,459	1.25, right at the lender's minimum
C. Smart build: \$130,000 build, smaller screen or reused pole, screen leased	\$130,000	\$66,900	\$20,201	1.64, comfortable
D. Low cash: \$130,000 smart build, maximum debt, needs 5 of 6 slots pre-sold	\$130,000	\$21,900	\$29,048	1.53 if 5 slots are pre-sold, only 1.14 at the plain Likely case

If you only have about \$40,000 to put in: that sits between Stack D's \$21,900 and Stack C's \$66,900. It clears Stack D's minimum with about \$18,000 of cushion. But Stack D needs 5 of the 6 slots pre-sold before steel is ordered, a higher bar than this plan's 4-slot gate. It falls about \$27,000 short of Stack C's smoother, less risky path. Three ways to close that gap: a bigger CSBFP loan if a lender agrees, a silent family or friend investor, or saving a few more months before Phase 1.

Source of funds for money from Iran

If any of your cash started in Iran, or passed through an Iranian bank account, treat it as a special case. This is not legal advice. See a Canadian sanctions and **anti-money-laundering** lawyer before any of that money moves, and a **CPA**.

What to do. Start with money already in a Canadian bank account with a clear history. It needs no special proof. Keep every paper record for money from elsewhere: sale agreement, property deed and bank statements, translated and certified. Tell your bank the story yourself, in person, with documents, before a large amount arrives. Use only money services businesses registered with **FINTRAC**, Canada's financial intelligence agency, and check its public registry yourself first. Report any cash of \$10,000 or more crossing the border, using the **CBSA** (Canada Border Services Agency) declaration form.

What not to do. Never split a deposit into pieces under \$10,000 to avoid a report. This is called **structuring**, and it is a warning sign on its own even when the money is clean. Never use an unregistered exchange house. Never use an informal **hawala-style network** either, even on a relative's word. It moves money person to person with no bank and no paper trail. Operating one without registration is a federal offence, and using one can leave you holding money that police later trace to someone else's crime.

Why banks ask so many questions. Banks must establish **source of funds** (how this money was earned or acquired: salary, gift, property sale) and **source of wealth** (how your whole net worth built up). Any transaction connected to Iran, of any size, is treated as automatically high risk. The bank checks identity, asks for source of funds, keeps a record and often reports the transaction.

PEP status can follow relatives too. A **PEP** (politically exposed person) is someone who held a senior government, military, judicial or state-company position. It covers close relatives, including a spouse, parent or in-law, and once it applies it never expires. If your co-founder, or anyone close to them, held such a position, tell your bank and lawyer up front.

Sanctions do not ban ordinary people or ordinary savings. Canada's Iran sanctions freeze dealings only with named individuals and organizations, including Iran's Revolutionary Guards. In practice, Canada's own travel advisory says money cannot be sent to Iran through normal banking today, so moving money out of Iran at all is a real practical problem.

T1135 is a tax form for money held outside Canada. It applies if you or your co-founder held more than \$100,000 of foreign property at any point in a year, including a foreign bank balance. If so, it was due with that year's tax return. **UNKNOWN:** whether it was filed for past years. If it was missed, fix it before any large transfer, using the CRA's Voluntary Disclosures Program, which can reduce penalties for coming forward first.

A practical rule for advertisers, too. Check any currency exchange advertiser on FINTRAC's public registry every time before signing, because registrations get revoked. Accept payment only by cheque or bank transfer from the advertiser's own business account. Never accept cash. Add a clause to remove the ad if registration is lost.

Traps to watch for

- **The more than 50% rule blocks doubling up.** Futurpreneur and Starter Company Plus each need their applicant to own more than half the company, so only one of you can use one of them.
- **You cannot use Starter Company Plus while working full-time at an outside job.** It fits whichever of you does not.
- **The CSBFP's 85% guarantee protects the bank, not you.** With a personal guarantee signed, you can still owe every dollar personally.
- **A big prepay discount is expensive money in disguise.** 10% or 15% off for a year up front costs like paying 22% to 36% a year in interest. Offer a locked price instead.
- **A personal guarantee follows the person, not the corporation.** The corporation shields you only from debts you did not personally guarantee. Never let your spouse or co-founder sign one without their own lawyer.
- **A dead board still costs real money.** If the business fails, three costs remain: lease payments left, removal cost and any minimum rent owed. Together they can add up to \$155,000 to \$205,000, before tax relief. **ESTIMATE:** this number is likely too low for the bigger board this guide now plans. It was built on an older, smaller board and a smaller screen lease. Keep a bigger reserve if the lease and removal costs are not capped by contract.

What you do

1. **You and your co-founder**, October 2026: decide who owns more than 50% of the company.
2. **Your co-founder**, before Phase 1: get their immigration status confirmed in writing, by a Regulated Canadian Immigration Consultant (RCIC) or an immigration lawyer. Ask what their status allows them to do in the company, paid or unpaid.
3. **You**, by January 31, 2027: finish the lender package described above. Also make three informal calls to lenders, with no application.
4. **Whoever holds any Iranian-origin money**, before any transfer: see a sanctions lawyer and a CPA first. Start with Canadian-banked money wherever possible.

5. **You**, once your real cash total is known: compare it against the stacks above and pick the build size that matches. Do not assume a bigger build will fund itself.

Part 13. Cheaper and Easier Ways In

In one sentence: Start with idea 2 (become a rep) and the 90-day plan below, and order no steel or screen until 4 slots are signed at \$1,400 a period.

1. Partner with someone who already has money or land

A family or friend investor. Ontario lets a company sell shares to close family and friends without registering the sale with a regulator. This is the **FFBA exemption** (Family, Friends and Business Associates).

Example: a relative puts in one third of a \$130,000 board, the cheapest of the three builds in Part 2. Their share is about \$43,300 ($\$130,000 \div 3$). They get about one third of the board's yearly money left before loans. In the Likely case (Part 2) that is $\$33,116 \div 3 =$ about \$11,000 a year, so their money comes back in about 3.9 years.

A landlord who co-funds the steel. If the landlord already has a pylon, ask to reuse its foundation and power line, and ask them to pay part of the conversion to digital. In return they get extra rent points, meaning a bigger percentage of revenue. This saves about \$15,000 to \$40,000 of your own cash. That is our own estimate, built from other Canadian sign-cost research. Paying it back with 5 extra rent points costs about \$3,744 a year in the Likely case ($5\% \times \$74,880$ revenue).

RULE: a lawyer writes any partner deal before money changes hands. That costs about \$2,000 to \$5,000 for the family-investor deal. No cash of \$10,000 or more without a clear Canadian bank record.

2. Resell other people's boards: become a rep

Cost is almost nothing, and it is the fastest way to learn real prices.

No Ontario company advertises a rep program in writing. You have to ask by phone or email. A 2025 trade survey of out-of-home companies found eight in ten pay reps 10% or less. Most pay only after the advertiser has paid its invoice; one industry commenter puts the wait at 90 to 120 days (Billboard Insider survey, February 4, 2025).

Worked example. A board in Vaughan, BillboardHub listing #5107, at 7800 Keele St, rents one slot for \$1,750 per 4-week period. At a 15% commission, that is \$262.50 a period ($\$1,750 \times 15\%$). Sold for a full year, 13 periods, one slot earns you \$3,412.50 ($\262.50×13). Three slots sold all year earn about \$10,238 ($\$3,412.50 \times 3$).

3. Become a Farsi-speaking outdoor ad agency

Sell slots on other people's boards, the same model as idea 2. Pitch and write the ads in Farsi and English, and sell to Persian-owned shops on Yonge Street. Build a one-page media kit and a list of shops. This needs almost no money.

As of September 21, 2026, no Persian-language billboard-selling business exists in York Region. Persian radio, print and event companies sell their own ad space, not billboard slots.

Careful: an agency usually earns 15% off list price only when the seller grants a formal agency account. Small local media may quote one flat price instead. Your real income may come from creative work: writing and designing the ads, plus translation.

4. Lease or lease-to-own the screen instead of buying it

RULE: lease the screen. Save the bank loan for the steel and power, once orders are signed.

Company	What they offer	Terms shown on their page
Daktronics Canada	A "One Dollar Buyout" lease	Approval usually within 48 hours. No minimum stated
I-View LED, through Meridian OneCap	"100% Term Financing"	24, 36, 48 or 60 months
Formetco	One payment covers teardown, install and electrical	New builds need a financial review first

None of these companies publish their interest rate. This guide plans for 10% a year over 84 months (7 years). That is \$19,921 a year for every \$100,000 leased.

A bank loan through the **CSBFP** (Canada Small Business Financing Program) costs only \$14,213 a year per \$100,000. A bank, though, rarely lends to a business with no sales yet.

5. Buy a used screen instead of new

ESTIMATE: a used 10-by-20-foot face might cost very roughly \$10,000 to \$26,000. Used outdoor LED screens elsewhere sell for roughly 30% to 80% less than new. This is built from foreign asking prices. It is UNKNOWN for Canada. No Canadian seller of a used screen this size was found by September 21, 2026. That does not mean none exist.

A used screen usually carries no warranty. It may have parts the maker no longer sells. It can be dimmer than a new one.

Call Media Resources, Daktronics Canada, Sanford Outdoor and Pattison and ask for a used or swapped-out screen. None of them post that stock online.

6. Build the pole for static first, add the digital screen later

Richmond Hill's sign permit lapses six months after it is issued, if nothing is built. Some builders put up the pole, the foundation and the wiring first. That holds your spot. It also holds your 300-metre "no other sign nearby" circle. The digital screen goes on once the money and the advertisers are ready. A static face rents whole to one advertiser per season, not by the six-slot loop.

Careful: no verified Canadian price exists for a pole built for static use alone. Ask your engineer to design the pole and foundation for the future screen's weight and power load from day one, even if a printed poster goes up first. Skip this and you pay twice for the engineering.

7. Let the landlord pay part of it

Same deal as idea 1. If the landlord has a lit pylon, they keep the pole, foundation and power line, and you add only the new screen. That saves \$15,000 to \$40,000, for a bigger rent share. Expect four worries:

Worry	Answer
Property tax will go up	The assessment agency values only the sign, not the land or building. You reimburse the sign's share of that extra tax in the lease
The sign hurts their view or their tenants	Messages last 3 seconds. The screen dims at night. It shuts off if it breaks. The by-law keeps it 100 metres from housing
What if the town says no	The lease option , the landlord's promise to lease the spot once you are ready, ends if the town refuses. They keep any option fee you paid, and owe nothing else
What if you go out of business	The lease is registered on the property title. You carry insurance, and the board can be sold to a bigger operator

8. Sell sponsorships instead of slots

Sell sponsor packages on commission for Persian community events across the **GTA** (Greater Toronto Area). Packages usually include signage and banners. Tirgan is a Toronto arts festival, 416-227-1711. Eventorian runs Mehregan, Yalda and Nowruz events in Markham.

Worked example, our own estimate, not a quote. At 15% commission on \$2,000 sponsor deals, 5 deals a year earns about \$1,500 ($\$2,000 \times 15\% \times 5$). 20 deals earns about \$6,000, and 50 deals earns about \$15,000.

This is side income, not a living. It builds the list of Persian advertisers you will need to fill your own board later.

9. Take free help before spending your own money

- **Richmond Hill Small Business Enterprise Centre**, known as the SBEC. Free one-on-one advice, free seminars. Call 905-747-6317. Ask for a mentor with sign, real estate or ad-sales experience.
- **CRA Liaison Officer service**. A free visit from the Canada Revenue Agency (CRA), by phone, video or in person, on taxes and bookkeeping. Request a visit on canada.ca.
- **Law Society Referral Service**. A free 30-minute talk with a lawyer. Call 416-947-3300, or toll-free 1-800-668-7380, or use findlegalhelp.ca. Ask about the rep agreement. Ask how ownership should be split between you and your co-founder.
- **ACCES Employment, Entrepreneurship Connections**. A newcomer business training program with mentoring. Its exact schedule was not confirmed as of September 21, 2026. Call 416-921-1800 and ask for today's dates and cost. Ask if your co-founder qualifies.
- **Ontario Sign Association**. Membership costs about \$439 a year, but call first, 905-482-4942. Ask which category fits an outdoor advertiser. Ask for an introduction to a sign engineer.

None of these groups knows the billboard by-laws. Get any rule answer in writing from the town itself, never from a chamber of commerce or an association.

One idea worth asking about, not yet proven: Richmond Hill lets an EV Charging Station Sign, a sign next to an electric-car charger, skip two of its four distance rules. Those two rules block most other Yonge Street lots. JOLT already runs a charger with ad screens at 9555 Yonge St, so it could be a partner for this route. This is not a proven cheaper path. See Part 17 for the open questions to ask the City first.

The 90-day learn-and-earn plan: Monday, September 28 to Sunday, December 27, 2026

Cash cap, while the permit questions in Part 7 play out: about \$4,400 for the full plan, with the test ad and the course. A leaner, mostly-free version, skipping the test ad, the course and the lawyer review, costs about \$500 (the three traffic counts).

Realistic earnings in 90 days: low \$0, likely \$300 to \$800 booked (signed, not yet paid), high about \$2,500 booked. The real product of these 90 days is proof, not income: a rate card, one test-ad result, and 4 signed letters of intent.

Weeks	What you do	Cost
1 to 2	Call every existing operator for a rep agreement, idea 2. Book the free SBEC and Law Society calls	\$0
2 to 4	Buy 3 York Region traffic counts, \$160 each, for your target streets. Get the rep agreement checked by a lawyer	About \$1,730
3 to 6	Run one paid test ad on the Vaughan board for a Persian shop. Pay \$1,750 plus 13% HST (Ontario's sales tax)	About \$1,978
4 to 10	Hold 30 real conversations with possible advertisers. Collect 4 signed letters of intent at \$1,400 or more per period	\$0
Ongoing, optional	Buy a background reading course on the trade	About \$626
Week 13, Dec 27	Check the gate, a go or no-go checkpoint you agree on now. Criteria below	

The \$1,730 row: 3 traffic counts x \$160 = \$480, plus about \$1,250 for the lawyer's review. **The test-ad row:** \$1,750 + \$227.50 HST (13%) = about \$1,978.

RULE: order no steel or screen until 4 slots are signed at \$1,400 a period. Four slots for all 13 periods in a year is \$1,400 x 4 x 13 = \$72,800, close to the Likely-case revenue of \$74,880 in Part 2.

The first ten calls

1. **Sanford Outdoor**, 905-339-1339. Ask for a commission-only rep agreement.
2. **DigiPoint Media**, 289-223-1001. Same ask.
3. **Eye Candy Ads**. Contact Mark Snaper, 647-470-1237. Same ask. Mention you can sell in Farsi.
4. **Action Media**, 705-687-2000. Same ask.
5. **RCC Media**, 416-650-6000. Same ask.
6. **BOLD Boards**. Use the contact form at boldboards.ca. Ask about their landowner referral reward. It is listed as \$250 on one part of their page and \$750 on another. Confirm the real number, and any rep option.
7. **Richmond Hill SBEC**, 905-747-6317. Free consult. Ask for a mentor and an introduction to the City's Economic Development office.
8. **One Persian shop owner** on Yonge Street, a bakery, grocer or restaurant. Ask if they will be your test-ad customer.

9. **Law Society Referral Service**, 416-947-3300. Free 30 minutes. Ask about the rep agreement wording. Ask how to split company ownership.
10. **CRA Liaison Officer**. Request form on canada.ca. Free visit. Ask what to set up, a business number and HST, before spending money.

What you do:

1. **You, this week:** call the six operators in calls 1 to 6. Ask each for a written, commission-only rep agreement.
2. **You, week 2:** book the free Richmond Hill SBEC consult and the free Law Society 30-minute call.
3. **You and your co-founder, weeks 2 to 4:** agree which one Persian shop will be your test-ad customer. Agree who talks to them, in Farsi or English.
4. **You, by week 6:** run the one paid test ad, about \$1,978, once you and your co-founder approve the cash.
5. **You, weeks 4 to 10:** hold 30 real conversations. Collect 4 signed letters of intent at \$1,400 or more.
6. **Your co-founder, ongoing:** ask 3 Ontario Sign Association or ACCES contacts if a sign-shop job fits them. Also ask if the Entrepreneurship Connections program fits them.
7. **You both, week 13, December 27, 2026:** check the gate. Four letters of intent, plus 3 rep sales or 1 test ad, passes the gate. Passing means move to Part 5, the journey step by step. Missing means keep selling, not building.

Part 14. What Can Go Wrong

Eight of the 14 risks are red. Red: can end the project or wipe out your cash reserve. Yellow: costs months or thousands of dollars if missed, but will not sink the business alone.

The risk map

#	Risk	Light
1	Richmond Hill will not confirm the site is zoned right	Red
2	The landlord's own tenants, lender, or redevelopment plans block the deal	Red
3	Power costs more and takes longer than planned	Red
4	Advertisers will not sign a year ahead of a board that does not exist	Red
5	The build costs more than the ceiling	Red
6	Your co-founder's immigration status does not allow the work planned	Red
7	A personal guarantee puts your home at risk	Red
8	The town tightens or changes the sign rules later	Yellow
9	Nobody will insure a small digital billboard for a fair price	Yellow
10	Cash runs out between spending and collecting	Red
11	A competitor takes the site first	Yellow
12	An ad breaks the law and a regulator complains	Yellow
13	The screen is damaged in an Ontario winter	Yellow
14	Disagreement between co-founders under pressure	Yellow

The seven biggest risks, one at a time

1. Richmond Hill will not confirm the zoning

What it is. Richmond Hill's sign by-law allows a billboard on Commercial-zoned land, at least 100 metres from Residential land. Most Yonge Street lots sit in a mixed-use zone, and the by-law does not say whether that counts as Commercial or Residential. If the City reads it as Residential, zero of the 83 candidate lots on Yonge Street pass.

The fix. Before spending a dollar on design, send six written questions to the City's sign permit desk and get written answers. Email signpermits@richmondhill.ca, phone 905-771-8800. Also use the free zoning information line at zoninginfo@richmondhill.ca.

Stop rule. If the written answer says mixed-use counts as Residential, do not appeal or argue. Move to East Gwillimbury or Bradford. Part 4 explains why they are the back-up towns.

2. The landlord's own tenants, lender, or plans get in the way

What it is. Plaza tenants often have a right to their own sign panel on the same pole, and the landlord's bank may need to approve a new lease. Leases like this usually run 10 to 20 years. About 28% of the large Yonge Street lots already have a live City development application, so the site could be torn down for a taller building before your lease ends.

Worked example. A lease runs 15 years. The landlord sells the plaza for redevelopment in year six. Roughly \$94,000 sunk into steel, power, and engineering could be lost, plus the roughly \$20,000 to \$42,000 still owing on the screen lease. This happens only if the lease has no protective clause.

The fix. Before signing anything, pay for a parcel-register search (a title search) on the chosen lot. It costs about \$36.50 to \$49 per lot. It shows the owner's name, any mortgage, any registered lease, and any site-plan agreement (the City's paper approving how the property was built). Write the lease with a right to relocate the sign if the property redevelops, and a payment if the sign cannot be moved.

Stop rule. Two red flags: the search shows a live tower application on the exact lot, or the landlord's lawyer will not agree to a relocation clause. Either one means walk away from that lot and pick another from the shortlist.

3. Power costs more and takes longer than planned

What it is. A 10 by 20 foot LED sign draws up to 15,500 watts at peak and averages about 4,000 watts through the day, roughly \$6,100 a year of electricity. Alectra, the utility serving Richmond Hill, can ask for up to six months' notice, but only if new equipment must be built to reach the site.

The fix. File the power request as early as possible, no later than January 31 2027. Ask in writing whether the existing plaza pylon's circuit (the pole sign's existing wiring) can carry the extra load. That question alone can shrink the wait to one to three months.

Stop rule. Do not take the sign permit or order steel until Alectra's written connection offer is in hand, with its price and timeline confirmed.

4. Advertisers will not sign a year ahead of a board that does not exist

What it is. The plan's safety rule is to sell four of six slots before ordering steel. But small local businesses usually buy four to twelve weeks of advertising, rarely a full year, and rarely commit to a board that is not built yet. This is untested.

The fix. Use non-binding letters of intent for the pre-sale instead of year-long contracts. Offer a locked-in founding-advertiser price of \$1,400 per four weeks to the first four advertisers who commit. Back it with proof from a real test ad, bought on someone else's board first, as Part 13 explains.

Stop rule. Count the letters of intent at Gate 1, January 31 2027 (Part 5). If fewer than four exist at \$1,400 or more, do not move to Phase 1. Sell harder for another month, lower the price, or stay a reseller.

5. The build costs more than the ceiling

What it is. No verified written Canadian quote exists yet for a real 10 by 20 foot digital sign. Every number is an estimate, from \$130,000 for a smaller, smart build up to \$225,000 for the worst case. Add 8% for surprises (\$18,000 on \$225,000) and the real worst case to plan for is about \$243,000. Steel and LED-screen prices are also exposed to the tariffs added through 2025 and 2026.

The fix. Get five written quotes in Canadian dollars before Gate 2. Ask every supplier to quote the same list of work, and to state how long the quote stays valid. Prices can expire in 30 to 60 days.

Stop rule. If every quote comes in above about \$243,000 (the \$225,000 stress case plus 8%), do not proceed with the full 10 by 20 design. Switch to the smaller 8 by 16 foot face. It needs about \$44,000 less screen and half the road frontage.

6. Your co-founder's immigration status does not allow the planned work

What it is. Canadian immigration law can count unpaid, day-to-day work as work. Some statuses, such as a visitor's stay or a work permit tied to one named employer, do not allow someone to run or work in a Canadian company at all.

The fix. If your co-founder is not a Canadian citizen or permanent resident, get their status confirmed in writing by a licensed immigration consultant (RCIC, Regulated Canadian Immigration Consultant) or lawyer before they do any paid or unpaid work in the company.

Stop rule. If the written opinion says your co-founder cannot legally work in or run the company, restructure so you are the sole operator on paper. Pay your co-founder only once their status allows it, on legal advice.

7. A personal guarantee puts your home at risk

What it is. Banks, the government-backed small-business loan program, and equipment-lease companies often ask for a personal guarantee. The corporation does not protect anyone who signs one.

The fix. Only you, as an officer of the company, should ever sign a guarantee, with a top dollar limit written into it. Your spouse and your co-founder should never sign one casually. Never put a mortgage or lien on your home for the business. Keep the business bank account, insurance, and every signed document in the company's name only.

RULE: Your spouse and your co-founder should each get their own independent lawyer before signing anything a bank asks them to guarantee.

The other seven risks, in brief

#	Risk	The fix	Stop rule
8	Richmond Hill may tighten sign rules later. A full rewrite is expected, with no set date. The City's own plan calls this Phase 3. A new Council starts Nov 15 2026.	Build and go live fast once the gates pass. A sign already lawfully built and operating stands on stronger ground than a paper permit.	If a new by-law removes the digital-sign permission before you are built, stop spending. Switch to another town, per Part 4.
9	No Canadian insurer publishes a billboard program. Premiums are still a guess.	Call Federated Insurance, the sign industry's recommended insurer, at 1.844.628.6800. Also call three to five other brokers for written quotes before Gate 2.	If nobody will insure it for \$2 million to \$5 million of liability, stop. Do not build without that coverage. The landlord and the lender both require it.

#	Risk	The fix	Stop rule
10	Cash can run out. HST, Ontario's sales tax, is paid up front on the build and refunded only weeks later. Loan and lease payments start before the board is full.	Keep a start-up reserve of \$45,000 to \$60,000, not \$30,000. The lower number only works if the screen-lease payoff is capped by contract.	If the company account falls under \$15,000, treat it as a red signal. See the stop-loss table below.
11	A competitor could grab the same or a nearby parcel first. One permit can block a circle 300 metres wide around it.	Move quickly and quietly once the zoning answer is favourable. Ask the City monthly which permits have been filed.	If a competing permit is filed first on your shortlisted lot, move on to the next lot on the list.
12	An ad could break a law: an unregistered money-exchange (must register with FINTRAC, Canada's financial watchdog, Part 9), a cannabis ad, a misleading claim, or an unregistered election ad.	Check every regulated advertiser's licence or registration before signing. Part 15 has the money-service registry check. Write a right to refuse or remove any ad into every contract.	If an ad already ran and broke a rule, remove it right away. Keep a written record of the fix.
13	Ice, wind, or lightning can damage the screen or structure.	Confirm in writing that the insurance policy covers wind, ice, and lightning surge, not fire and theft alone.	If damage happens, photograph it right away. Call the insurer and the engineer the same day.
14	Stress and disagreement can build between you and your co-founder.	Write the shareholder agreement's rule for disagreement before any spending, not during a crisis. It should say who decides, such as a vote or an outside advisor.	If a decision cannot be agreed, use the written process.

The stop-loss numbers, once the board is live

Signal	Green, all is well	Yellow, act this month	Red, sell or stop
Collected per four-week period	\$5,000 or more	\$3,400 to \$4,999	Under \$3,400 for three periods in a row
Slots sold, out of six	Four or more	Three	Two or fewer
Month-six renewals	Half or more say yes	Fewer than half	None, and under sixty percent billed
Month-twelve occupancy	Forty-five percent or more	Thirty-five to forty-five percent	Under thirty-five percent, list for sale within ninety days
Cash in the company account	At the reserve target	Down to half the reserve	Under \$15,000

45% occupancy is about 2.7 of the six slots sold, averaged over a year of four-week periods.

If it fails anyway, the recovery playbook

The worst realistic case, a total dead-board loss before any tax relief, is about \$155,000 to \$205,000. Your spending cap and cash reserve must cover this number, not only the amount sunk into steel (Part 2).

If a red signal fires, take these steps in order.

1. **Freeze spending.** The same day, freeze all new spending. Write down every debt owed: the screen-lease balance, the loan, the rent left owing, and any prepaid advertisers. Cost is zero.
2. **Call the professionals.** Within a week, book one hour each with the lawyer and the accountant. Do not move money to family, or sell equipment cheaply to friends, first. A court can undo a payment like that later as a preference (paying one creditor unfairly ahead of others) and can treat it as fraud. Cost is zero to \$800.
3. **Talk to the lender.** Call the screen-lease company and the bank before missing a payment. Ask for a payment holiday or an early buy-out number. This can save roughly \$5,000 to \$20,000 in what the lender would otherwise charge to collect.
4. **Tell advertisers.** Tell them in writing and refund unused days. The most this ever costs is one prepaid period per advertiser, about \$8,400 to \$11,400 across all six slots.
5. **Try to sell it first.** Sell the board as a going business before taking it apart. Potential buyers include Sanford Outdoor at 905-339-1339 and DigiPoint Media at 289-223-1001. Also try Eye Candy Ads at 647-896-4662 and Action Media at 705-687-2000. A working board can sell for about four to five times its yearly cash left. In a typical failure, that is roughly \$78,000 to \$97,000.
6. **Offer it to the landlord.** Offer the landlord the structure in exchange for being released from removal costs. Removal otherwise runs \$8,000 to \$20,000.
7. **Dismantle if nobody buys it.** Get two written quotes first. The likely cost is about \$12,000.
8. **Close the company down.** Settle small creditors, then file the final HST and corporate tax returns.
9. **Claim the tax relief owed.** An ABIL (allowable business investment loss) lets you deduct part of the loss against your regular employment income. It is worth roughly 20 to 25 cents back per dollar lost, roughly \$23,000 to \$39,000 on a typical failed board.

Detail: Under the Canada Small Business Financing Program (CSBFP), the lender may take a personal guarantee up to the full original loan amount. This is set out in Justice Laws regulation SOR/99-141, section 19. VERIFIED. Under Ontario case law, a director has no automatic right to advice first. Get that advice anyway, on your own, before signing.

What you do

1. **Before Gate 1**, by January 31 2027, send the six written zoning questions. Also get your co-founder's immigration opinion in writing, if it applies.
2. **Before Gate 2**, by about April 2027, collect five written build quotes. Also collect at least three written insurance quotes.
3. **Before signing any lease**, have your lawyer run a parcel-register search on the chosen lot and negotiate a relocation clause. The search costs about \$36.50 to \$49, plus legal time.
4. **Before anyone signs a personal guarantee**, they get their own legal advice, paid for by the company. It costs a few hundred dollars.
5. **Every month once the board is live**, compare the real numbers to the stop-loss table above and review them with your co-founder.
6. **If a red signal ever fires**, you and your co-founder follow the recovery playbook in order, starting the same week.

Where these facts come from

research2/c7-cap-the-downside.md, research2/audit-operator.md, research2/audit-advisors.md, research2/g-rule-change-politics.md, research2/g-insurance-market.md, research2/g-parcel-due-diligence.md, research2/g-alectra-power-connection.md, research2/DECISIONS.md, and research2/FACT_BASE.md, all checked September 21 2026 against town and government websites and internal research notes.

Part 15. Questions We Need Answered

Facts checked September 21 2026. **UNKNOWN** marks an open question.

The ten core questions

#	Question	Why it matters	How to find out
1	UNKNOWN. How much cash can you and your co-founder actually put in? How much could you afford to lose completely?	Decides the build to target: Smart \$130,000, Likely \$175,000, Stress \$225,000. Part 12 lays out the funding choices.	A meeting with real bank statements on the table, this October
2	UNKNOWN. Is that cash already sitting in a Canadian bank account with a clear paper trail?	Ordinary bank wires to or from Iran are usually blocked outright, and intermediary banks refuse to pass them through. Canada's travel advice for Iran says normal banking channels are not possible. Money already in Canada still gets extra federal checks, whatever the amount.	Ask your bank directly. Part 11 has the source-of-funds steps.
3	How old are you, and how old is your co-founder?	The Futurpreneur loan is worth up to \$75,000 and accepts owners aged 18 to 39 only. If you are in that range, you qualify. If not, your co-founder may, or another program may fit better.	Already known to you. Write down whichever age qualifies, for the lender package.
4	UNKNOWN. What is your co-founder's exact immigration status, in writing?	Decides whether they can legally direct, work in, or be paid by the company. If they are not a Canadian citizen or permanent resident, get their status confirmed in writing by a licensed immigration consultant (RCIC) or lawyer before any work in the company, paid or unpaid.	A paid consultation with an RCIC or an immigration lawyer
5	UNKNOWN. How well does your co-founder read, write, and speak English?	Decides who deals with the town directly.	An honest assessment, this October
6	UNKNOWN. Does your co-founder have relevant trade experience from elsewhere, such as sign-making, electrical work, construction, selling ad space, or running a municipal concession (a city licence to operate on public land)?	Decides whether they lead construction, lead sales, or neither.	A conversation between you and your co-founder, matched against the real Ontario tasks in Part 8 and Part 9
7	UNKNOWN. Has your manager given written consent to this side business?	Without written consent, a conflict-of-interest complaint could cost you your day job.	Send your manager a written consent letter this October. Part 11 has a template.
8	UNKNOWN. How many real hours a week can you give, especially during permitting and construction?	The calendar in Part 5 assumes ten to fifteen hours a week. The real number sets how fast every phase moves.	Track your actual week for two to three weeks this fall

#	Question	Why it matters	How to find out
9	UNKNOWN. Is Richmond Hill's Yonge Street truly the right first location? Do you or your co-founder know any willing landlord there?	A confirmed, friendly landlord shortens the timeline by months. The research found no confirmed landlord yet for any of the twelve shortlisted lots.	Ask around your network, including friends, family, and community contacts. Part 6 explains the landlord approach.
10	UNKNOWN. Are you and your co-founder willing to actually stop at a gate? Will you walk away if the numbers say stop?	The staged plan (gates in Part 5) only works if you honour a no from the numbers.	A direct conversation between you now, before any money is spent

Seven extra questions the reviewers found

#	Question	Why it matters	How to find out
11	UNKNOWN. Which ten Persian business owners will you actually call in October?	The sales plan in Part 9 needs a real list, not a general idea of the Persian community.	Build the list together with your co-founder this month
12	UNKNOWN. Is anyone among you, your co-founder, or your close relatives a politically exposed person (a foreign government official, or a relative of one by blood or marriage)?	This status never expires once it applies. It permanently changes how carefully banks review every transaction.	Ask an immigration lawyer or the bank directly. Do not guess.
13	UNKNOWN. Has your co-founder been filing the T1135 tax form? The CRA (Canada's tax agency) requires it for foreign property or savings over \$100,000.	Missing this form carries real penalties. Fix it before new money moves.	Ask your accountant this October
14	UNKNOWN. Can your co-founder drive, and do they hold a valid licence?	Site visits, supplier meetings, and landlord walks all require driving.	A quick conversation between you
15	UNKNOWN. Does any bank you or your co-founder have used in Iran appear on Canada's sanctions list?	Dealing with a listed person or bank is a serious federal offence, even through a third country.	An immigration or sanctions lawyer checks the public list against the actual bank names
16	UNKNOWN. If you and your co-founder disagree at a gate, who decides?	Without a written process, a real disagreement under money pressure can freeze the whole project.	Write it into the shareholder agreement before any spending. Part 11 has the details.
17	UNKNOWN. Should you and your spouse sign a marriage contract?	Business shares count as shared property under Ontario law. If you are recently married or about to marry, a marriage contract protects both the business and the marriage if things go wrong later.	A short conversation with your lawyer this fall

The decision guide, if the answer is X, the plan becomes Y

Branch 1, how much cash you have

Combined cash of \$130,000 or more: hold back \$30,000 to \$60,000 as a reserve, then build the fuller \$175,000 board as planned.

\$65,000 to \$130,000: build the smaller, smart \$130,000 version. It uses a smaller LED face and reuses the landlord's existing pole sign (pylon). Pre-sell harder before committing.

Under \$65,000: take the low-cash route. It needs five of the six slots pre-sold before any steel is ordered, plus a \$25,000 government program loan.

Under \$20,000: stay a commission-only reseller. Part 13 describes this route.

Branch 2, your co-founder's immigration status

Permanent resident or citizen: they qualify fully. They can own shares, direct the company, and work in it and be paid.

Open work permit (valid for any employer, not tied to one named employer): may be enough. Proceed as planned if the RCIC confirms it covers their own business. Keep the written opinion on file.

Study permit: any work in the business, paid or not, counts toward their weekly cap of twenty-four hours. Keep their role small and track their hours carefully.

Visitor, or the RCIC says their status does not allow this work: you become the sole operator on paper. Your co-founder can advise informally but should take no paid or working role until their status changes.

Branch 3, age and hours

Age 18 to 39: you qualify for Futurpreneur (up to \$75,000). It goes first in the funding order.

Not in range: your co-founder may qualify instead. If neither of you does, lean on the government-backed small-business loan program and bank financing.

Under five hours a week for more than eight weeks running: hand day-to-day sales to a reseller such as Sanford Outdoor or DigiPoint, at fifteen to twenty percent commission. Fifteen percent of a \$1,600 slot is \$240. Slow the whole calendar down to match.

Branch 4, employer consent

Written consent given: proceed as planned. Keep billboard work strictly on personal time.

Consent refused, or given with limits: either your co-founder becomes the named, operating owner instead of you, or you pause the project until your employment situation changes.

Branch 5, site and landlord

Richmond Hill zoning comes back favourable and a landlord says yes: proceed with Path A, Richmond Hill.

Richmond Hill says no, or no landlord is found: Path B is East Gwillimbury. It is legal today: town staff already approved it, with no council vote. Part 4 explains the trade-offs.

Neither works out: Path C is Bradford. Its rules are older and due for a rewrite.

Branch 6, willingness to stop

You will honour a gate that says stop: Part 5 has the gates, and Part 14 has the stop-loss numbers.

You would push through a red signal anyway: the downside in Part 14 is roughly \$155,000 to \$205,000 for a total failure, and far more likely without a rule you both follow.

What you do

1. **This October**, hold one meeting with your co-founder and your spouse. Answer questions 1, 2, 9, 10, 16, and 17 together. Cost is zero.
2. **This October**, book a consultation with an RCIC or an immigration lawyer for your co-founder's status (questions 4 and 12). Ask your accountant about T1135 filing status (question 13). Cost is UNKNOWN. Ask for a quote when you book.
3. **This October**, send your manager the written consent letter (question 7). Start tracking your real weekly hours (question 8). Cost is zero.
4. **This October**, build the ten-name Persian call list with your co-founder (question 11). Use the contact leads in Part 9. Cost is zero.
5. **This October**, ask around your network, including friends, family, and community contacts, for a landlord contact (question 9). At the same time, screen the shortlisted lots in Part 6. Cost is zero.
6. **Once the immigration opinion and the cash number are known**, re-read the guide together. Write down, in one sentence each, which branch you are on. Do this before Gate 1, January 31 2027.

Where these facts come from

research2/DECISIONS.md decision 23, research2/audit-operator.md, research2/audit-advisors.md, research2/MERGED_GAPS.json, research2/f10-legal-status-tax.md, research2/r1-money-from-iran.md, and research2/w1c-legal.md, all checked September 21 2026.

Part 16. Who to Call

Call the town first, before spending money on plans. Get every rule answer in writing; an email counts.

Every contact was read on an official website or document on or before September 21, 2026.

1. Your town: permits and zoning

Richmond Hill, the main path. Part 7 has the full steps.

Who	Phone / email	What to ask
Sign Permit desk	905-771-8800, signpermits@richmondhill.ca	How to apply for a sign permit, and whether your parcel counts as Zoned Commercial
Zoning Info, the City's online zoning tool, Zone Richmond Hill	zoninginfo@richmondhill.ca	The free Request for Zoning By-law Information letter, up to 5 business days
Building Division	905-771-8810, building@richmondhill.ca	Building permit questions, and the Permitted Use Letter, a paid written zoning answer
Permit Portal	access@richmondhill.ca, permits.richmondhill.ca	A written zoning confirmation (compliance letter). About 10 business days
Alectra Utilities, New Connections	1-833-494-3674, NewConnections@AlectraUtilities.com	A free pre-check on power for your parcel, before you sign a lease
Toronto and Region Conservation Authority, TRCA	416-661-6600, info@trca.ca	Whether your parcel sits in a flood-risk area the conservation authority controls
Richmond Hill Small Business Enterprise Centre	905-747-6317, ecdev@richmondhill.ca	Whether your co-founder can use Starter Company Plus, a small government grant

Careful: the Business Licensing line, 905-771-8840, is for a business licence only, not signs.

East Gwillimbury, second choice.

Who	Phone / email	What to ask
By-law Enforcement Services, sign permits	905-478-4282 ext 1478, bylaws@eastgwillimbury.ca	How to file a sign permit, and the current fee, about \$1,988 in year one
Building, Development Services	905-478-4282 ext 1261, cityview.eastgwillimbury.ca	Building permit needs on your sign
Planning, Development Services	905-478-4282 ext 1285	Whether your site needs an Urban Design Impact Assessment, an extra design review
Clerks' Department, Legislative Services	905-478-3821	How to appeal a refusal

Bradford West Gwillimbury and Simcoe County, third choice.

Who	Phone / email	What to ask
BWG Building	905-778-2055 ext 1520	The 10-year sign licence, fee about \$20 per square metre
Simcoe County	705-735-6901	The extra County permit needed within 400 metres of Holland St

Newmarket, parked for now.

Who	Phone / email	What to ask
Licensing Division	905-953-5300 ext 2221, licensing@newmarket.ca	The sign-permit record list, and whether Council has set a 2027 meeting date
Economic Development	905-953-5300 ext 2612, ecdev@newmarket.ca	Available properties and start-up guidance

Tip: signs@newmarket.ca appears on one outside consultant's page. It has never been confirmed on an official Town page. Use licensing@newmarket.ca instead.

Other towns, closed or low priority, for reference only.

Town	Phone	Status
Barrie, By-law Enforcement	705-739-4241	Open, but 60 km away, served by three big operators already
Vaughan, Building Standards	BuildingStandards@vaughan.ca	Open only in Employment Areas, land zoned for factories and offices
Aurora, Building Division	905-726-4778	Council approval only, hard to enter
Markham	markhambusiness.ca	The town allows at most 10 boards total
King and Whitchurch-Stouffville	Ask each town's building department directly	Both towns ban billboards outright, based on our September 2026 research

2. The province and the highways

MTO is the Ministry of Transportation of Ontario.

Who	Phone / web	What to ask
MTO Central Region, Corridor Management	416-235-5385, toll-free 1-866-636-0663	Any sign within 400 metres of a 400-series highway needs a Minister's permit. The permit costs \$770 for 5 years
MTO permit portal	hcms.mto.gov.on.ca	Where to file the highway permit application

3. Power and electrical safety

Who	Phone / email	What to ask
Alectra Utilities, serves Richmond Hill, Vaughan, Aurora, Barrie and Bradford	1-833-494-3674, NewConnections@AlectraUtilities.com	New power timing. 1 to 3 months if reusing the landlord's supply. 3 to 5 months for new metered service. 6 to 9 months or more if the local grid needs expanding
Newmarket-Tay Power, serves part of Newmarket	905-895-2309, engineering@ntpower.ca	Power connection for a Newmarket-area site
Electrical Safety Authority, ESA	1-877-372-7233	Every screen must carry a cULus or cETLus mark. The connection fee is \$143

4. People who can build it

Who	Phone / email	What to ask
Media Resources, Oakville, LED display maker and installer	800-667-4554, info@mediaresources.com	A written quote for a board, delivered, installed, and energized
Daktronics Canada, Burlington	888-325-7446	A "One Dollar Buyout" lease quote
I-View LED	888-953-1111, sales@i-viewmedia.com	A lease-to-own quote, 24 to 60 months
Meridian OneCap, I-View's lender	1-866-986-6738	Financing terms for the screen
Formetco	800-367-6382, digitalsales@formetco.com	A quote and their financial-review process for a new build
Rouge Hill Consulting, engineer and permit packages	437-833-7817, permits@rougehillconsulting.com	Stamped engineer drawings and by-law review for your parcel
Signature Engineering	519-572-2409, chris.sharpe@signatureengineering.ca	A stamped engineering drawing for your pylon

5. Money and free help

Part 12 has the full funding picture.

Who	Phone / email	What to ask
Futurpreneur Canada, Ontario office	416-408-2923	A loan up to \$75,000, for ages 18 to 39. If you are older, your co-founder may qualify, or another program may fit better
BDC Business Solutions Centre	1-877-232-2269	The CSBFP (Canada Small Business Financing Program) bank loan process. BDC's newcomer loan needs under 3 years in Canada. Check whether your co-founder qualifies before applying
Alterna Savings, Community Microfinance	1-877-560-0100, microfinance@alterna.ca	A microloan for your co-founder, matched by BDC with a second, equal loan

Who	Phone / email	What to ask
ACCESS Community Capital Fund	416-462-0496, admin@accessccf.com	A loan up to \$20,000, after their free Business Lab
ACCES Employment, Entrepreneurship Connections	416-921-1800, startupconnect@accesemployment.ca	Free newcomer business training and mentoring
York Small Business Enterprise Centre, YSBEC	ysbec@york.ca, ext 71572	Free advice for East Gwillimbury, Newmarket and Bradford-area plans
South Lake Futures, South Lake CFDC, a federal community loan fund, Keswick	905-476-1244	A loan up to \$300,000, East Gwillimbury or Georgina sites only
CRA Liaison Officer service, the CRA is the Canada Revenue Agency	Request form on canada.ca	A free visit about taxes, sales tax rules and bookkeeping
Ontario Business Registry	416-314-8880, toll-free 1-800-361-3223	Incorporating, for \$300

6. Other operators, for a rep deal or a resale relationship

Part 13 has the plan.

Who	Phone / email	What to ask
Sanford Outdoor, Oakville, resells others' boards	905-339-1339, info@sanfordoutdoor.com	A commission-only rep agreement, and the status of their unbuilt Aurora and Bradford boards
DigiPoint Media, Mississauga	289-223-1001, Info@digipoint.ca	A rep agreement, and current rate quotes
Eye Candy Ads, Mark Snaper, site developer	647-470-1237	A rep agreement, and landlord introductions in Bradford, Keswick and East Gwillimbury
Action Media, Kevin Boyes, site developer	705-687-2000, sales@action-media.com	A rep agreement, and Barrie and Georgina board status
RCC Media	416-650-6000, toll-free 1-866-938-2111	A rep agreement, and who owns their Highway 400 and Steeles board
BOLD Boards	Contact form at boldboards.ca	Their landowner referral reward and any rep option
Pattison Outdoor, Barrie office	705-726-4747	Whether they hire local sales reps

7. Advertisers and the Persian community

Part 9 has the sales playbook.

Who	Phone / email	What to ask
Iran Star, Persian newspaper	647-674-4048, info@iranstar.com	Their advertising rates, and whether print still runs

Who	Phone / email	What to ask
Radio Sedaye Iran	905-886-2540, sedayeiran@live.ca	Radio ad rates, and a co-promotion with your board
Ethnic Channels Group	416-736-7577, webinfo@ethnicchannels.com	Whether they reach Persian-speaking viewers
Tirgan Centre for Art and Culture	416-227-1711	Sponsorship packages for their festival
Eventorian, Times Canada, runs Persian events	315 Steelcase Rd E, Markham, phone unconfirmed	Sponsorship at Mehregan, Yalda and Nowruz events
Iranian Canadian Association of Entrepreneurs, ICAE	info@icae.ca, 647-648-4950	Introductions to Persian business owners
Taheri Exchange, advertiser prospect, 5775 Yonge, Toronto	416-488-8822	Whether they would advertise on your board

RULE: before you sign a currency exchange, check Canada's list of registered money businesses. Several Yonge Street exchanges lost their licence in 2026. Advertising for an unregistered one is against federal law.

Detail: the registration list is at fintrac-canafe.canada.ca/msb-esm/reg-eng.csv. Search it for the exchange's exact legal name.

Tip: we do not yet have a named landlord for any shortlisted Yonge Street parcel. Ask a real estate lawyer to run a title search through **OnLand**, Ontario's online land-ownership system. Cost about \$36 to \$590 per parcel.

8. Insurance, legal and immigration

Who	Phone / email	What to ask
Federated Insurance, recommended by the Ontario Sign Association	1-844-628-6800	A quote for liability, property, and equipment coverage
Law Society Referral Service	416-947-3300, toll-free 1-800-668-7380, findlegalhelp.ca	A free 30-minute lawyer consult on company structure
Iranian Legal Services, Farsi-speaking	416-849-7081, 7368 Yonge St	Company set-up and contracts in Farsi
Ghasemi Law, Farsi-speaking	416-887-9200, 9030 Leslie St unit 309	A second opinion, in Farsi
Immigration, Refugees and Citizenship Canada, IRCC	1-888-242-2100	General immigration questions only. IRCC agents cannot advise on your co-founder's status

RULE: if your co-founder is not a Canadian citizen or permanent resident, get their immigration status confirmed in writing before they do any paid or unpaid work in the company. Use a licensed immigration consultant (an **RCIC**) or an immigration lawyer. IRCC's line gives general information only.

9. Trade bodies and industry data

Who	Phone / email	What to ask
Ontario Sign Association	905-482-4942, info@ontariosignassociation.com	Which membership tier fits an outdoor advertiser, about \$439 a year
COMMB, the body that collects official audience numbers for outdoor ads in Canada	support@commb.ca	Membership dues for a one-board operator, and access to their traffic data
Billboard Insider, US trade newsletter	billboardinsider.com	Free daily sign-up

10. A partner idea, not yet proven

Who	Phone / email	What to ask
JOLT, EV chargers paid for by ads, not the driver, already on Yonge St	Justin Dempsey, VP Real Estate Eastern Canada, 647-409-8016	Whether they pay a landlord a finder's fee for a new site

What you do:

1. **Before any call:** write your questions down first, so the call stays short. For Richmond Hill, have the written mixed-use zoning question from Part 7 ready to email to signpermits@richmondhill.ca.
2. **Week 1:** call the Richmond Hill Sign Permit desk and Zoning Info. Ask for the free written zoning letter.
3. **Week 1 to 2:** call the first six operators in section 6 (everyone but Pattison) for a rep agreement, as in Part 13.
4. **As needed:** call Alectra for a free power pre-check, before signing any lease.
5. **Ongoing:** split the calls by strength. For example, one of you takes English paperwork and sales calls. The other takes site work and asks the Farsi-speaking lawyers in section 8 to explain anything unclear.
6. **Every quarter:** ask whoever keeps this guide updated to re-check every phone number and fee here and note any change.

Part 17. What Is Proven and What Is Not

Most facts were checked on September 21, 2026. A few were re-checked the next day. Facts with their own date show it.

- **VERIFIED:** read in an official document, government page, or signed by-law.
- **ESTIMATE:** our own arithmetic, built from verified numbers.
- **UNKNOWN:** nobody has confirmed it. The entry says how to find out.

What is solidly VERIFIED

Fact	Where we read it
Richmond Hill's By-law 25-26, passed April 8 2026, allows signs up to 19 square metres. That is about the size of the 10-by-20-foot board this guide plans for	The City's own by-law document
East Gwillimbury cut its sign-spacing rule from 600 to 300 metres on July 23, 2026	By-law 2026-077, the Town's own document
The Canada Small Business Financing Program charges at most prime plus 3%, 7.45% today	The federal program's own rules
Ontario's minimum wage rises to \$17.95 an hour on October 1, 2026	Ontario.ca
A currency exchange must register with FINTRAC (the federal money-service-business regulator) before it can legally advertise	FINTRAC's own public list
One 10-by-20-foot board rents ads by the slot, \$1,750 to \$1,995 per 4-week period. This is a real Vaughan board	A live listing, BillboardHub #5107 and #5108
Toronto's Sign Variance Committee refused 18 of 28 digital sign requests (64%) from January 2024 to September 18, 2026	Toronto's own committee records

Money numbers (all ESTIMATE)

No Canadian source publishes a firm price for a finished 10-by-20-foot digital board. Every capital cost here is summed from real Canadian supplier quotes for the structure, screen, wiring and permits. The three cases in Part 2 (Bad, Likely, Good) come from that sum, not from one written price.

Money fact	Mark	Note
Build cost: \$130,000 smart, \$175,000 likely, \$225,000 stress	ESTIMATE	No written all-in quote exists yet. Get one before Gate 2 (Part 5)
Electricity, about \$6,100 a year	ESTIMATE	A real screen's watt rating, times Alectra's real rebate
Insurance, about \$4,500 a year	ESTIMATE	No Canadian insurer publishes a billboard-specific price. Get 3 written quotes
A single board sells for 4 to 7 times its yearly cash flow	ESTIMATE	From US trade sources. No recent Canadian small-board sale price was found
Screen lease rate, about 10% a year	ESTIMATE	No lessor publishes a rate. Planning number, not a quote

What we could not check

- **Your co-founder's immigration status.** If your co-founder is not a Canadian citizen or permanent resident, get their status confirmed in writing before they do any paid or unpaid work in the company. Ask a Regulated Canadian Immigration Consultant (**RCIC**) or an immigration lawyer.
- **Whether Richmond Hill will treat your parcel as Zoned Commercial.** The City has never said in writing whether mixed-use zones count as Commercial or Residential. This drives the 100-metre housing-distance rule. If they count as Residential, zero ordinary Yonge Street lots pass. Send the one written zoning question in Part 7 to signpermits@richmondhill.ca before you count on any specific lot.
- **The EV Charging Station Sign route.** Richmond Hill's by-law lets a sign next to an electric-car charger skip two distance rules. It does not say whether the charger must work, how close it must be, or whether the screen can carry pure ads. We wrote 12 questions for the City. Ask whoever keeps this guide updated for the list, or have a lawyer help write them. **Do not plan around this route until the City answers in writing.**
- **One competing company's board.** RCC Media announced a digital board at Highway 400 and Steeles in October 2025. We could not find its exact address or who permitted it. Call RCC Media, 416-650-6000.
- **A real, all-in, Canadian-dollar quote for a finished board.** Every builder price here is summed from separate pieces. Get 3 to 5 written quotes on one identical spec before Gate 2.
- **Whether your company is WSIB Class L or Class G5.** WSIB is Ontario's workplace injury insurer. Class L is \$0.18 per \$100 of pay, Class G5 (construction) is \$2.15. On \$50,000 of yearly pay, that is about \$90 versus about \$1,075. Call WSIB, 1-800-387-0750, and confirm in writing before hiring anyone.
- **Whether your co-founder has been filing form T1135.** Canada requires it once a person holds more than \$100,000 in property outside Canada. Ask your accountant.
- **Georgina and Innisfil billboard counts.** Each town caps total boards, 25 for Georgina and 45 for Innisfil. Neither publishes its current count against the cap. Call each town.
- **When Bradford West Gwillimbury will finish rewriting its sign by-law.** A rewrite was approved in principle on December 2, 2025. No draft exists. The earliest a new Council could pass it is December 2026.
- **Real traffic counts for Yonge Street, Davis Drive and Green Lane.** York Region sells them for \$160 each. Nobody on this project has bought them yet.

Corrections already made

1. **Highway boards.** We first wrote that every billboard visible from a highway sits on government-controlled land. That holds for every board we could trace except RCC Media's Highway 400 and Steeles board.
2. **Competitor count.** We first said four or five independent companies with about a dozen boards. The real count is two board builders and owners, Eye Candy Ads and Action Media. Sanford Outdoor and DigiPoint Media resell slots on Eye Candy Ads and Action Media boards, which they do not own. About 7 to 9 digital boards exist today, in York Region and Bradford together.
3. **Money table.** An earlier version paired the most expensive build cost with the best-case income, which made payback look faster than it is. Part 2 now pairs every cost with every case.
4. **Flowchart and two guesses.** An early flowchart was unclear. Two sentences read as proven facts but were our own guesses. Both are removed or rewritten as labelled estimates.

What changes, and when

Date	What happens
October 1, 2026	Ontario's minimum wage rises to \$17.95 an hour
October 17 to 26, 2026	Ontario's municipal election voting period
October 26, 2026	Election day, every town council in this plan
November 15, 2026	Richmond Hill's new Council begins, and could revisit the sign by-law
November 17, 2026	East Gwillimbury's new Council is sworn in
December 2026	Bradford's new Council is seated. Its sign by-law rewrite could restart
December 7 and 14, 2026	Newmarket's first Council meetings after the election
December 15, 2026	East Gwillimbury's first meeting after the election
January 31, 2027	Gate 1 (Part 5)
Spring 2027	Starter Company Plus's next intake, exact date not yet announced
About April 2027	Gate 2: permit plus financing plus 4 of 6 slots signed
August 1, 2027	Go-live, first board
January 31, 2028	Six-month review against the go-live numbers

RULE: do not rush any permit to beat the November 15, 2026 Council change. A board cannot be built that fast, and an unbuilt Richmond Hill permit lapses after 6 months anyway.

How to update this guide

1. **Re-run the money model.** The Part 2 numbers come from a calculation file. Ask whoever built this guide to re-run it whenever a cost or fee changes.
2. **Re-check any by-law after a Council election.** After November 15, 2026, check Richmond Hill's website before relying on Part 3 or Part 7.
3. **Re-check the currency-exchange registry before every new advertiser.** Registrations are revoked without notice. Check on the day you sign. Ask whoever keeps this guide updated for the check link.
4. **Re-buy traffic counts once a year.** York Region's \$160 counts are a snapshot.
5. **Get a fresh written quote from each supplier before ordering steel.** Prices, tariffs and exchange rates move. Re-confirm any quote older than 90 days.

Maintainer details: the money model is `research2/model.py`, run with `python3 research2/model.py` in the project folder. The currency-exchange registry is `fintrac-canafe.canada.ca/msb-esm/reg-eng.csv`. The EV-charger questions are in `research2/w1c-ev-charger-route.md`. For whoever maintains this guide, not for you to run.

What you do:

1. **You, before trusting any number here:** check its mark. Read VERIFIED items yourself if they matter. Treat ESTIMATE as a planning number. Treat UNKNOWN as call and ask.
2. **You, this month:** send the one written zoning question in Part 7 to Richmond Hill. Also ask whoever keeps this guide updated for the 12 EV-charger questions.

3. **You and your co-founder, this month:** if your co-founder is not a Canadian citizen or permanent resident, book an immigration lawyer or RCIC and get their status in writing. Nothing in Part 11 or Part 12 can be finalized without it.
4. **You, before Gate 2, about April 2027:** get 3 to 5 written quotes for the board. That turns the Part 2 ESTIMATE into a VERIFIED number.
5. **Whoever updates this guide, every few months:** re-run the checklist above, also before any big decision. Note the date of each fact you re-check and what changed at the top of this part.

Dictionary

Ontario, Canada and billboard-industry terms used in this guide, A to Z. Dollar figures are Canadian dollars unless marked otherwise. Facts checked as of September 21, 2026.

A

- **AADT:** Annual Average Daily Traffic, the vehicles past one point per day. York Region sells a count for \$160 a road, and a 2016 to 2017 count on Yonge Street south of Elgin Mills found roughly 25,000 to 35,000 vehicles a day, both directions. A vendor's impression claim, such as 30,000 a day for 30,000 passing cars, is an estimate from counts like this, not proof.
- **AGCO:** The Alcohol and Gaming Commission of Ontario. Its guideline says liquor ads should not sit within 200 metres of a school. This guide's advertiser rules follow it. No sign by-law writes it in.
- **Amendment:** East Gwillimbury's spacing rule changed from 600 metres to 300 metres by amendment 2026-077, passed July 23, 2026.
- **Annual return:** A yearly online filing to the Ontario Business Registry naming who runs the company and where its office is. It carries a small fee. Skipping it flags the company.
- **As-of-right:** Allowed by the by-law as written, with only the ordinary permit. A sign that meets every distance and size rule can be as-of-right, and in East Gwillimbury staff can then approve it without a Council vote.
- **Attribution rules:** Tax rules that shift tax back onto the person who gave or lent money when a family gift or loan moves income between people. A documented shareholder loan, backed by a promissory note, at CRA's 3% prescribed rate avoids them. An interest-free family loan could trigger them.

B

- **Bank of Canada policy rate:** Also called the overnight rate. It is 2.25% now. Every bank loan in this guide is priced off it.
- **BDC:** Business Development Bank of Canada, a federal lender that takes on more risk than a normal bank. Direct loans usually start only after 12 to 24 months of revenue, so it fits once the board is earning. It likes a credit score of 600 or higher, which a newcomer with no Canadian credit history may lack.
- **Break-even:** At \$1,600 a slot, about 26% full, or 1.6 of the board's 6 slots (Part 2).
- **Business Number:** A 9 digit CRA number used for HST, payroll and corporate tax. You get one automatically when you incorporate in Ontario.
- **By-law:** Richmond Hill's Sign By-law 25-26 made digital billboards legal there from April 8, 2026.

C

- **Caisson:** The concrete-filled column that anchors a tall pole, dug below the frost line. A digital-sized foundation typically costs \$5,000 to \$20,000. A smaller, ordinary pylon's foundation costs about \$3,000 to \$8,000.
- **CASL:** Canada's Anti-Spam Law, covering consent and unsubscribe rules for commercial email and text messages. An advertiser follow-up text must follow it. A first outreach text needs existing consent, or must clearly say who is messaging.
- **CBCA:** The Canada Business Corporations Act, the federal incorporation law. Unlike Ontario's OBCA, it has historically needed some Canadian-resident directors.
- **CBO:** See Chief Building Official.

- **CCA:** Capital Cost Allowance, the tax write-off on equipment. A billboard's LED screen and steel structure fall under CCA Class 8, normally 20% of the balance left each year. Equipment bought from 2025 through 2029 gets a bigger 30% write-off in year one.
- **CCPC:** Canadian Controlled Private Corporation, a private company mostly owned by Canadians. Only a CCPC gets Canada's low small business tax rate, on its first \$500,000 of active business income. Advertiser rent counts as active business income, interest on idle cash does not.
- **CGL:** Commercial General Liability insurance. Landlords and lenders typically ask for \$2 million of coverage, with the landlord named as an additional insured before the lease is signed, costing roughly \$800 to \$2,500 a year. An umbrella policy up to \$5 million might add around \$1,000 a year.
- **Chargee:** A lender with a registered claim, usually a mortgage, against land. Check the Parcel Register before any lease is signed. It shows the owner, any chargee (the bank that must sign off on a long lease) and any easement, such as a hydro easement across a plaza's back that can block a foundation spot. Ask that bank for a non-disturbance agreement, registered alongside the lease, so the lease holds even if the landlord defaults on their own mortgage.
- **Chief Building Official (CBO):** The town's top building inspector. In Bradford West Gwillimbury, the CBO must give written approval first. Only then can a sign licence allow a digital screen.
- **CMS:** Content management software for uploading ads and setting the schedule. Many screen makers, including Watchfire, bundle it free with the hardware.
- **Commercial zone:** East Gwillimbury's by-law allows billboards on Commercial, Industrial, Employment, Rural or Aggregate Resource land. Residential land is not allowed.
- **Committee of the Whole:** All of a town's councillors sitting together to discuss an item before the final Council vote. A sign by-law change is usually debated here first, then voted on at Council days or weeks later.
- **Competition Act:** The federal law banning false or misleading advertising, with penalties that can run into large fines. Presenting an unverified traffic count as fact could breach it. That is why this guide labels traffic numbers as estimates.
- **Conservation authority:** A regional agency whose permit is needed to build in a regulated area: land near rivers, valleys, wetlands and floodplains. In Richmond Hill, TRCA sign off must come before a building permit can be issued. See TRCA and LSRCA.
- **Constructor:** Ontario workplace safety law names one party as constructor, legally in charge of safety on the site. Hiring several trades directly, instead of one prime contractor, will likely make your own company the constructor. One turnkey supplier, from design to final hookup, avoids that trap.
- **Controlled area:** A strip of land near a provincial highway where the province, not the town, approves signs. A lot within Highway 404's controlled area needs an MTO permit before a billboard can go up. The strip includes a band around an interchange or intersection: 395 metres for a controlled-access highway and 180 metres for a King's Highway.
- **CPM:** Cost per thousand impressions. Watchfire quotes \$2 to \$3 as the benchmark for a digital roadside board.
- **CRA:** The Canada Revenue Agency, the federal tax office. It sets the prescribed rate for family loans and reviews large HST refunds before paying them out.
- **CSBFP:** The Canada Small Business Financing Program, where the federal government backs 85% of a bank loan of up to \$500,000 for equipment like a billboard's screen and structure, though you still owe it all. It charges a one time 2% registration fee and caps the interest rate at prime plus 3% (7.45% today), which already includes a 1.25% yearly administration fee. It usually needs a personal guarantee, capped at the loan amount.

D

- **Director:** Ontario directors can carry personal responsibility for things like unpaid wages. You and your co-founder would both likely be named directors of the new corporation.
- **Double-faced sign:** Allowed in Richmond Hill and East Gwillimbury. Its total sign area counts as twice the one-face limit, and the pole counts as one structure carrying two faces.
- **DSCR:** Debt Service Coverage Ratio. Most lenders here want at least 1.25, meaning yearly money left is 1.25 times the loan payment.
- **Duty of loyalty:** An employee's legal duty not to work against the employer's interests. Ontario's rules against non-compete agreements do not remove it. That is why the plan tells the employer about the side business in writing and gets the manager's written consent up front.
- **Dwell time:** Richmond Hill requires at least 3 seconds. East Gwillimbury requires at least 10 seconds. Part 1 lists all four towns.

E

- **Election sign:** A temporary sign supporting a candidate, under separate rules from billboard advertising. A candidate or registered third-party advertiser (a group running its own election ads) must give the billboard owner, called the "publisher" here, their information first. The publisher must keep the ad, its price and the sender's information for four years.
- **Employment zone:** Vaughan only allows billboards inside its mapped Employment Areas: land set aside for factories, warehouses and offices, with no shops or homes.
- **Encroachment permit:** Permission from York Region to place anything on or near its road land, even temporarily. An encroachment agreement costs about \$2,300 and takes about 8 weeks. The plan avoids needing one wherever possible.
- **Equity injection:** The cash a lender expects you to put in first. On a \$175,000 build, roughly \$60,000 to \$80,000.
- **ESA:** The Electrical Safety Authority, Ontario's electrical safety regulator. It charges a \$143 fee to inspect a billboard's wiring, then issues the paper the utility needs before hookup. Only an ESA-licensed electrical contractor may legally do wiring for hire, and one must connect the billboard's power before ESA will approve the site.
- **ESTIMATE:** One of this guide's three certainty tags. The number is this guide's own math from other verified numbers, arithmetic you can check yourself, not a quote or promise. The \$175,000 build cost is ESTIMATE because no vendor has given a firm price yet.
- **Exclusivity:** A lease clause promising the landlord will not let a competing sign company build nearby. Negotiate it to protect a Yonge Street pylon from a rival right next to it.

F

- **FFBA exemption:** The Family, Friends and Business Associates exemption. An Ontario company can sell shares to close family and friends without registering with a securities regulator. A relative could put in about \$43,300 for one third of a \$130,000 board and receive about one third of its yearly money left.
- **FINTRAC:** The federal agency that watches for money laundering. Money changing and money sending businesses must register with it. Rule: check every currency exchange advertiser against FINTRAC's public registry before signing them, since 18 Yonge Street registrations were revoked in 2026 alone.
- **Fixed running costs:** \$19,300 a year in this guide's model, whether the board is full or empty. They cover power (about 40,000 kWh, an average draw of roughly 4 kW), insurance, repairs, software, town fees, a property tax share and bookkeeping (Part 2).

- **Four-week period:** Exactly 28 days, 13 a year. This guide's rate card and revenue model are both built on it (Part 1).
- **Frontage:** Richmond Hill allows 0.30 square metres of sign area per metre of frontage. A full sized 19 square metre face then needs about 63 metres of frontage.
- **FSRA:** The Financial Services Regulatory Authority of Ontario. It licenses mortgage brokerages and agents, including the independent mortgage brokers on the advertiser call list. The list favours them over bank mortgage specialists, whose employer usually controls their advertising budget.
- **Futurpreneur:** A Canadian non-profit that lends money and provides mentors to business owners aged 18 to 39. Its Side Hustle loan can lend up to \$25,000, and only to an owner who holds more than half the voting shares. It takes a 1% fee when the loan is paid out, typically allows interest-only payments for the first year, and pairs approved borrowers with a mentor for up to two years.

G

- **Gate:** Gate 1 (January 31, 2027) and Gate 2 (about April 2027) are the go or stop checkpoints (Part 5). No steel or screen is ordered until 4 slots are signed at \$1,400 or more per period, the permit is in hand and financing is approved.
- **Geotechnical report:** A soil study, often a test hole, showing whether the ground can hold a foundation. It typically costs \$3,500 to \$8,000 and is needed before an engineer can design the caisson.
- **Grandfathered:** Allowed to keep operating because the sign was legally there before the rule changed, also called legal non-conforming. Richmond Hill's grandfather clause only protects a sign already standing on November 9, 2009, so a board built new in 2027 has no automatic protection if the by-law changes again. A Newmarket sign put up before the current by-law may hold this status, but the Town would need to confirm it case by case.
- **Grant:** No government grant found in this research pays for a billboard. Starter Company Plus can give your co-founder up to \$5,000 toward startup costs, if they qualify. Its intake is currently closed, and the next one is expected in spring 2027, date unpublished.
- **GTA:** The Greater Toronto Area, Toronto and the regions around it.

H

- **Heritage property:** No digital screens are allowed on a property with Heritage protection, whatever the underlying zoning says.
- **HST:** Harmonized Sales Tax, Ontario's 13% sales tax. The plan registers for HST on day one and chooses monthly filing, so refunds on business purchases come back roughly every month. Otherwise it can take up to a year.
- **Hydro:** The everyday Ontario word for electricity. Connecting a new billboard means applying to the local distribution company, the utility that owns the poles and wires: Alectra in Richmond Hill and Vaughan, Newmarket-Tay Power in Newmarket.

I

- **Incorporation:** Incorporating in Ontario costs \$300, with Articles of Incorporation filed online. A national incorporation costs \$200 plus a separate federal fee.
- **Independent legal advice:** A bank may require a co-signing relative to meet a separate lawyer, who has no other role in the deal, before signing.
- **IRCC:** Immigration, Refugees and Citizenship Canada. An immigration lawyer or RCIC can get a written IRCC opinion on exactly what your co-founder's status allows them to do.

- **ITC:** Input Tax Credit, the HST a business gets back on its own purchases. It needs HST registration first. The plan budgets an HST float of about \$9,750 on the build's non-screen spending, refundable in roughly 2 to 3 months, though CRA can take longer on a large first refund.

L

- **Land Registry:** OnLand, Ontario's Land Registry website, is a free way to find a parcel's owner by address. Start there with any shortlisted Yonge Street parcel.
- **Land rent:** The greater of 20% of gross revenue or \$10,000 a year. At \$74,880 of revenue, 20% is \$14,976, so that is the rent paid.
- **Land transfer tax:** A one time Ontario tax on a land sale or a very long lease. A lease of 50 years or less, counting renewals, is exempt. This guide's leases run much shorter anyway, to satisfy a tighter Planning Act rule (see Notice of lease).
- **Late fee:** A late fee clause is only enforceable if the contract states the yearly rate, for example 24% a year. Without a stated rate, the law caps it at 5% a year.
- **Letter of intent (LOI):** A short, unsigned, non-binding statement that an advertiser wants a slot once built. It costs the advertiser nothing, still proves real interest to a lender, and helps clear Gate 1. Once the permit and lease are both in hand, it becomes a signed insertion order (a signed purchase of ad space, with time and price), backed by a deposit of 10% of the year's price, held in trust and refundable until the board goes live.
- **Licence:** Bradford West Gwillimbury issues a 10 year sign licence. Other towns use shorter permits, and East Gwillimbury's renewal is entirely at the Town's discretion, not an automatic right.
- **Likely case:** The guide uses three cases: Bad, Likely and Good. Likely assumes 60% of slots are sold on average across the year, 3.6 of 6. On the \$175,000 build, it pays back in about 5.3 years.
- **Listed person:** A person or company named on Canada's sanctions list. No one may legally deal with them, so no advertiser on the sanctions Schedule 1 list may be sold a slot. This matters given Canada's sanctions on Iran.
- **Loop:** With 6 slots of about 8 seconds each, one loop takes roughly 48 seconds (Part 1).
- **LSRCA:** The Lake Simcoe Region Conservation Authority. It covers the part of East Gwillimbury outside TRCA's area, so a build there needs LSRCA sign off, not TRCA's.

M

- **Metrolinx:** The provincial agency that runs GO train and bus service and owns the land around its stations. Some freeway-facing billboards already stand on Metrolinx land under a Minister's Order.
- **Minister's Order:** A written decision by a provincial minister creating a special exception to the normal rules. Freeway billboards on land like Metrolinx GO station property usually exist under one, in place of the normal municipal permit process.
- **Ministerial Directive on Iran:** A federal order making Canadian banks treat any Iran money transfer as high risk and report it, regardless of amount. Even a fully legal transfer can trigger bank questions.
- **Minor variance:** A small exception to a by-law that does not weaken its overall purpose, sometimes approvable by staff instead of a full committee. Barrie lets its town Clerk approve a minor variance without a full public meeting.
- **Mixed use zone:** Much of Richmond Hill's Yonge Street is zoned mixed use. The town has never confirmed in writing whether that counts as Commercial land. This is the single biggest open question in this plan.
- **Money left:** This guide's plain word for what remains after land rent, sales cost and fixed running costs, before any loan payment, tax or salary (industry term: NOI). In the Likely case, \$74,880 of revenue leaves

\$33,116 a year (arithmetic in Part 2). A single owned board sells for 4 to 7 times that, roughly \$132,000 to \$232,000.

- **MPAC:** The Municipal Property Assessment Corporation, which sets each property's value for property tax. MPAC adds the billboard to the landlord's assessment at replacement cost less 50%, so this guide's lease reimburses the landlord for that extra tax.
- **MSB:** Money Services Business, a company that exchanges or sends money for a fee, such as a currency exchange (a sarafi in Farsi; Taheri Exchange at 5775 Yonge Street is one). Any MSB must be registered with FINTRAC. This guide's rule caps currency exchange advertisers at 2 of 6 slots.
- **MTO:** The Ministry of Transportation of Ontario, in charge of provincial highways like the 400 series. It must approve any sign near one. MTO's rule bans billboards within 400 metres of a 400 series highway, with no exception for urban areas.

N

- **Nits:** East Gwillimbury's by-law caps a digital sign at 5,000 nits in daytime. At night the cap is only 300 nits.
- **Notice of lease:** A short public record at the Land Registry showing that a lease exists, which a new buyer or lender must then respect. This guide writes site leases as 21 years less a day, which satisfies a Planning Act rule needing town consent for any longer term.
- **Notice of Project:** A form filed with Ontario's Ministry of Labour before construction starts, required when labour and materials cost more than \$50,000. A 10 by 20 foot billboard costs far more than that, so the constructor must file this notice before work begins.
- **NUANS report:** A search confirming no other Canadian company uses the exact name you want. A numbered company, such as 1234567 Ontario Inc., skips it entirely.

O

- **OBCA:** The Ontario Business Corporations Act, the provincial incorporation law. Unlike the federal CBCA, it needs no Canadian-resident directors. That is one reason this guide recommends Ontario incorporation.
- **Off-premises sign / third-party sign:** Ontario by-laws use both terms for a sign advertising a business not located on the land where it stands. This is the legal category a billboard falls under, so search by-laws for either term.
- **Offer to Connect:** A power company's written price and plan for hooking up a new electrical service. Alectra's typically arrives within 60 days of a formal request. The plan calls for asking for a free pre-check even earlier.
- **Official Plan:** Newmarket is currently rewriting its Official Plan, the town's long-term land-use plan, which could eventually affect which areas allow billboards.
- **OLS:** An Ontario Land Surveyor. An OLS survey, a signed drawing of property lines and proposed sign placement, is needed before staff review a sign permit application. It costs roughly \$2,000 to \$4,500 and proves a billboard's exact distance from a lot line or another sign.
- **Ontario Business Registry:** The government website where Ontario businesses register and file yearly reports. An \$8 Corporation Profile Report shows a company's directors. It can show who owns a shortlisted parcel.
- **Ontario Land Tribunal:** The provincial body that hears disputes over municipal planning decisions. Some large Yonge Street lots have active development applications that could end up before it. That is one reason this guide treats a long lease there as risky.
- **Ontario One Call:** A free service that marks buried pipes and wires before anyone digs. The call takes 5 business days to process. The result then stays valid for 60 days.

- **Open work permit:** A work permit letting its holder work for almost any employer in Canada. Public guidance does not clearly say whether it also covers running one's own business. Get a written RCIC opinion first, and do not assume it covers managing a new company.
- **Option to lease:** Signed before the permit, so the option holds the land while the town decides. No rent is paid until the City confirms the sign is allowed, and the full lease follows only after the permit. Include a permit-loss exit, so walk-away cost is nil if the permit is refused.
- **Out-of-home (OOH):** Total Canadian out of home spending was about \$842 million in 2025, and 58% of it was digital.

P

- **P.Eng:** Professional Engineer, licensed in Ontario to sign and stamp structural drawings. A P.Eng must stamp the drawings for a billboard's monopole and caisson.
- **PEP:** Politically Exposed Person, someone who holds or once held a senior government or military role. Close family counts too, including parents-in-law, and the status never expires. Banks give them extra scrutiny, which matters for any banking involving your co-founder's family.
- **Permanent resident:** Someone allowed to live in Canada permanently who is not yet a citizen, often shortened to PR. Most of the loan and grant programs here require citizenship or PR status.
- **PIN:** Property Identification Number, the 9 digit number Ontario's land registry uses to identify one parcel. Searching an address on OnLand returns the PIN, the first step before buying a Parcel Register.
- **Pixel pitch:** A 10 millimetre pitch is common and sharp for a roadside board. A 13 millimetre pitch is a little less crisp, but can save \$20,000 to \$40,000. At the chosen pitch this guide's screen is about 300 by 600 pixels, a number to confirm with your own supplier first.
- **Prescribed rate:** The minimum interest rate CRA expects on a loan between family members, reset every three months. It is 3% for October to December 2026. A family loan charging less risks being treated as a taxable benefit.
- **Prime rate:** Prime is 4.45% today. A CSBFP loan is capped at prime plus 3%, which works out to 7.45%. Reference case: a \$150,000 bank loan over 10 years at 7.45% costs about \$21,319 a year.
- **Programmatic:** Platforms such as Broadsign Reach and Vistar sell ad space automatically. They only make sense with several boards, so this plan skips them for the first board. Once several boards are owned, unsold space (remnant) can be listed on Broadsign Reach for small extra revenue.
- **Proof of play:** Watchfire's Ignite software prints a time stamped report for every play, showing an advertiser exactly when and how many times their ad played.
- **Protected person:** Someone Canada has formally decided cannot safely return home and is allowed to stay. This is similar to a refugee, who can usually get an open work permit. An RCIC should confirm a protected person's right to run a business.
- **Pylon:** A tall pole mounted sign at the edge of a parking lot, also called a pole sign. A rebuilt plaza pylon counts as a ground sign, meaning a sign on its own posts, not attached to a building. The plan's cheapest path is rebuilding an existing lit plaza pylon into a monopole (a single steel pole, no cross bracing) carrying a digital LED screen.

R

- **Rate card:** This guide's rate card runs from \$1,900 for a 4 week slot down to \$1,500 for a 52 week slot. Founding advertisers are locked at \$1,400 for their first year. Agencies get 15% off, so a \$1,600 slot costs an agency \$1,360.
- **RCIC:** A Regulated Canadian Immigration Consultant, licensed to give immigration advice. An RCIC can give you a written opinion stating exactly what your co-founder's status allows them to do.

- **Regional road:** A main road owned and controlled by York Region rather than the local town. Yonge Street is a Regional road, so York Region, not only Richmond Hill, has a say over signs and permits near it.
- **Rep agreement:** A fair one asks for around 15% of what is collected, paid within 30 days, with no long non-compete clause and a right to leave with 30 days' notice. Working as a rep before owning a board costs almost nothing and is a fast way to learn real prices.
- **Request for quotation (RFQ):** This guide's plan sends the same one page request to at least five builders, then chooses one. It asks each supplier to show freight, customs brokerage and duty separately from the screen's own price.
- **Reseller:** Sanford Outdoor and DigiPoint Media both resell space owned by other companies. Both operate in this guide's research area.
- **Residency obligation:** A permanent resident must spend 730 days in Canada every five years. Missing that risks losing PR status. It is one more reason to confirm your co-founder's immigration history in writing.

S

- **Sales cost:** 10% of what advertisers bring in, paid to whoever sold the ads. On \$74,880 of revenue, that is \$7,488.
- **Sanctions:** Canada's Iran sanctions freeze the property of listed people and companies. They do not ban ordinary Iranian citizens from moving their own money. Banks still treat any Iran linked transfer as high risk.
- **Screen lease:** Lease-to-own means monthly payments for a set number of years, then you own the screen for \$1. Several screen makers, including Daktronics and some in Canada, offer it directly (a vendor lease). Reference case: leasing \$100,000 over 84 months at 10% costs about \$19,921 a year.
- **Setback:** Richmond Hill keeps a new billboard at least 100 metres from land zoned Residential and at least 400 metres from a highway.
- **Shareholder agreement:** Often called a unanimous shareholder agreement. You and your co-founder should include a buy-sell clause covering what happens if one of you wants out.
- **Sign permit:** Richmond Hill's costs \$279 and includes the Building Code review needed for a structure this size, so there is no separate building permit fee. It lapses 6 months after issue if nothing has been built yet.
- **Sign Variance Committee:** Toronto's five-member body that decides sign variances. Between 2024 and September 2026, it refused 18 of 28 digital sign requests, about 2 of every 3.
- **Site plan:** Under site plan control, the town reviews a drawing of a property's buildings, driveways, parking and signs before something can be built or changed. Adding a sign to a plaza under site plan control may need a minor amendment, roughly \$1,088 to \$1,256 in Richmond Hill.
- **Small supplier:** A business earning \$30,000 or less in sales over the last four calendar quarters, not legally required to register for HST. This guide's plan registers for HST voluntarily from day one, to recover input tax credits.
- **Smart build:** The cheapest of the three build-cost cases, \$130,000. It uses a smaller screen and reuses the landlord's existing pole.
- **Soft costs:** Survey, engineering, legal and government fees added together, separate from the steel and screen. On a clean Richmond Hill site, they run about \$9,400. On a harder site, they can reach about \$27,600.
- **Source of funds:** Proof of exactly how the money in one specific deposit was earned or obtained, such as a pay stub, a property sale or a signed gift letter. A bank asking about a large deposit wants this, and a general description is not enough. A gift letter should state it is not a loan and show where the money came from.

- **Source of wealth:** An explanation of how a person built up their money over their whole life, such as decades running a business or years of salary and savings. Enhanced due diligence on Iran money asks about both sources.
- **Special Signage Area:** A named area, like a historic downtown, with tougher sign rules to protect its look. Digital screens are usually banned there. Richmond Hill's Downtown and Uptown areas are Special Signage Areas this plan avoids.
- **Sponsorship:** Tirgan, a Toronto Persian arts festival, sells sponsor packages. So do Eventorian's Mehregan, Yalda and Nowruz events. Persian promoters run Mehregan parties across the GTA each fall, and Persian shops, grocers and restaurants advertise heavily around Nowruz and Yalda, a good time to renew or upsell advertisers.
- **Start-up reserve:** At least \$30,000 kept untouched as working capital. It covers the board's first uncertain months.
- **Static:** Some builders put up the pole, foundation and wiring first as a printed static sign, protecting their spot until the digital screen is added.
- **Stress build:** The worst-case build-cost case, \$225,000, if steel and screen prices run high. It still pays back in the Likely case, in about 6.8 years, but never pays back in the Bad case.
- **Structuring:** Deliberately breaking a large cash deposit into smaller pieces to stay under \$10,000. Banks treat structuring as suspicious on its own, no matter the reason, and will report it.
- **Study permit:** A government paper letting a foreign student study in Canada. It may allow limited work, often 24 hours a week off campus. A study permit alone would not be enough to actively run this business, so your co-founder's actual status needs confirming.

T

- **T1135:** A tax form listing foreign property, such as bank accounts or land outside Canada. It is required if foreign property topped \$100,000 Canadian in the year. Confirm this for your co-founder.
- **T2:** The corporate income tax return every Canadian corporation files each year. A company's first T2 is usually prepared by its accountant and covers its first fiscal year.
- **TOSI:** Tax on Split Income, a federal rule that can tax family members at the top rate on company income if they are not genuinely active in the business. It applies to you and your co-founder here. A family member drawing dividends without real hours worked risks the top rate.
- **Transition time:** How long one digital ad takes to change to the next. Several Ontario by-laws expect about 1 second.
- **TRCA:** The Toronto and Region Conservation Authority, covering Richmond Hill. TRCA, not LSRCA, is who to call about a regulated area in Richmond Hill.
- **Trim:** The metal edging around the screen, also called the bezel. Richmond Hill's 19 mm cap counts the trim, so a true 10x20 face needs a trim no wider than about 23 mm to fit under it.

U

- **Unmetered service:** An electrical connection for something drawing a steady, predictable amount of power, with no meter and an estimated bill. Some smaller signs qualify, which can simplify the utility hookup.
- **UNKNOWN:** One of this guide's three certainty tags: nobody has confirmed the fact yet, and the guide says how to find out. Whether your co-founder's work permit covers running their own business is marked UNKNOWN.
- **Uptime:** An uptime of 95 to 98 percent is a normal industry benchmark, so up to about 14 to 36 hours dark a month is still normal.

V

- **Variance:** A Richmond Hill sign variance costs \$2,312 plus a \$415 first notice fee. If it is refused, there is no built-in appeal, only a lawsuit called judicial review.
- **VERIFIED:** One of this guide's three certainty tags. Someone on this project read the fact themselves, in an official document or a signed by-law. Richmond Hill's \$279 sign permit fee is marked VERIFIED.
- **Visitor:** Someone in Canada for a short stay who is not permitted to work. A visitor cannot legally help run this business, even unpaid, if a Canadian could otherwise be hired for the work.

W

- **Ward councillor:** The elected politician for the neighbourhood where a sign is proposed. A ward councillor can ask for a granted sign variance to be reconsidered, within a set number of days after it is approved.
- **Work permit:** An employer specific work permit only allows work for one named employer. It likely would not cover someone helping run their own new company.
- **WSIB:** Ontario's Workplace Safety and Insurance Board. Subcontracting the install work can keep the company at the lower Class L rate, \$0.18 per \$100 of payroll, instead of Class G5's \$2.15. Ask every subcontractor for a clearance certificate, proof they paid their premiums, so their unpaid premiums cannot become your bill.

Y

- **York Region:** The upper tier government above local towns like Richmond Hill and Newmarket. It runs major roads such as Yonge Street and Davis Drive. The Region must be asked about signs and permits there too, not only the town.

Z

- **Zoning by-law:** A sign by-law usually allows a billboard only on Commercial or Industrial zoned land. If it does not clearly allow one, a billboard is not allowed.
- **Zoning confirmation letter:** Richmond Hill offers a free zoning information letter, taking up to 5 business days. Keep it as written proof. It is the first, cheapest step toward answering the Yonge Street zoning question.

Toolkit: Ready Letters and Scripts

Facts below were checked on or before September 21, 2026. Nothing here is legal advice. Have a lawyer check any letter before you send it, especially one that asks a town or lender for something in writing. Part 16, Who to Call, has most of the phone numbers and emails used below. Keep a copy of everything you send, and every answer you get, in one folder per parcel.

Money figures in these letters and scripts are the plan's numbers, marked ESTIMATE unless a fee or number came from a town document.

Careful: the town letters below are pre-consultation letters, meaning questions asked before you apply or pay a fee. Ask for every answer in writing. An email reply counts. A verbal answer from a town desk cannot be relied on later.

1. Five letters to the towns

1.1 Richmond Hill: the zoning and permit questions letter

When to use it: send this first, by email, before you spend on plans or an engineer, for any Yonge Street parcel you are seriously considering. Richmond Hill never said whether a mixed-use zone counts as "Commercial," which matters for the 100 m rule (Part 7 explains). **Site plan control** (question 6) is the city's extra design review for some properties.

To: signpermits@richmondhill.ca. Cc: bylaw@richmondhill.ca, zoninginfo@richmondhill.ca Subject: Written interpretation request, Sign By-law 52-09 s.7.6.7, off-premises ground sign on Yonge Street

Hello,

I am planning one digital off-premises ground sign at [ADDRESS], Richmond Hill. The face is about 18.6 m² and the height is 7.5 m. Under By-law 25-26, Sign By-law s.7.6.7 allows this on Commercial or Industrial land. The property is zoned [RMU-COR1 / KDA-YC / RHC] under Zoning By-law 93-25. Could you please confirm in writing:

1. Whether this zone counts as lands Zoned for Commercial use under s.7.6.7(a), and whether the same zone also counts as lands Zoned for Residential use under s.7.6.7(b)(i). Or does only the N, NS, NT and NA residential zones count for that second test?
2. Whether the 100 m and 300 m distances are measured from the sign structure. Or from the lot line.
3. Whether a pending permit application counts as "another Sign" for the 300 m rule. Are there permits already issued or pending near this address?
4. Whether the sign may carry both tenant panels and off-premises copy. Both must fit inside the 19 m² Table C limit.
5. Whether the Downtown, Uptown, Civic Centre or Village Core special signage areas include this address. Please attach Schedule B.
6. Whether a Comprehensive Signage Design Plan or a site plan amendment will be required, if the property is under site plan control. Please also say if the Building Division wants its own permit file too.

Thank you. I understand this is general information, not approval of any plans.

[YOUR NAME] [phone] [email]

Tip: also file the free Request for Zoning By-law Information form, at forms.richmondhill.ca. It answers the plain zoning question in up to 5 business days. Send both together. On that form, ask for five things:

1. The zone and permitted uses under Zoning By-law 93-25.
2. Whether an **OLT** appeal or a site-specific exception applies to the property. The **OLT**, the Ontario Land Tribunal, hears appeals of town planning decisions.
3. Whether a **TRCA** regulation overlay applies. **TRCA**, the Toronto and Region Conservation Authority, protects rivers, valleys and wetlands.
4. Whether the Zoning By-law separately regulates a freestanding sign.
5. The zones of parcels within 120 m of a point on an attached sketch.

1.2 East Gwillimbury: the permit list letter

When to use it: send this before you file a Sign Permit Application for an East Gwillimbury parcel. It gets the Town's reading of two gaps in the amended by-law and shows the permits already issued near your site.

LSRCA (question 7) is the Lake Simcoe Region Conservation Authority, which protects Lake Simcoe's rivers and wetlands.

To: bylaws@eastgwillimbury.ca Subject: Pre-consultation request: third-party electronic billboard, [civic address]

Hello,

I am planning one third-party electronic billboard at [civic address], zoned [zone]. The face is one 10 ft by 20 ft, about 18.6 m². The height is 8 m or less. Before I file, I would like your written reading of these points. They are under By-law 2025-052 as amended by By-law 2026-077.

1. Does s.18.1 apply to an Electronic Billboard Sign, defined in s.18.2? That section sets a 20 m² face limit and an 8 m height limit. It also sets a 250 m setback.
2. Does the 100 m setback from street intersections apply to a static Billboard Sign? Or only to an Electronic Billboard Sign?
3. The Schedule J charges are \$45 per m² electronic and \$31 per m² third-party advertising. Are these per face or for all faces? Which base sign fee applies to a billboard?
4. Which building permit fee applies to a sign 7.5 m or lower?
5. Does the electronic board at 22746 Leslie Street count for the 300 m spacing rules? Can you share the list of billboard and third-party permits issued since October 7, 2025?
6. Does this lot have a registered site plan agreement? Would a sign need a site plan amendment?
7. This letter already covers the Sign Permit Application, the Building Permit and the LSRCA review. Which other review steps should I expect?

Thank you for your help.

[YOUR NAME] [phone] | [email]

Detail: East Gwillimbury's own copy of the sign by-law is not fully merged. Pages 1 to 39 still show the old 600 metre spacing rule. Pages 44 to 47 staple on the July 23, 2026 change to 300 metres. Get the answer in writing before you rely on either number.

1.3 Newmarket: the acceptable-locations map letter

When to use it: Newmarket is parked, with almost no open land for a new billboard (Part 3 explains). Send this letter early anyway. The Town's Routine Disclosure Policy releases these records for free. Newmarket's next

Council meets no earlier than December 14, 2026.

To: licensing@newmarket.ca, cc_clerks@newmarket.ca Subject: Request for billboard location map and permit list

Hello,

I am planning a Billboard Sign application under Sign By-law 2017-73. I understand some records are released under the Town's Routine Disclosure Policy, CORP.1-09. I would like your help with these records:

1. The current Billboard Acceptable Locations Map. This is the version attached to Report 2025-41, for the September 8, 2025 Committee. Please send it as a PDF. If you can, please share the GIS layers too, as a shapefile or KMZ. These are the permitted billboard areas, existing billboard points, and 300 m buffers.
2. A list of every Billboard Sign permit and application on file. Address, permit number, issue date and expiry date.
3. Whether any Billboard Sign permit or variance was issued, or applied for, since August 2025.
4. Written confirmation on a variance, for [address 1], [address 2] and [address 3].
5. The current Sign Variance Application form. Also the Sign Permit checklist you use for billboards.

Could I also book an in-person appointment with a Licensing Officer? Thank you for your time.

[YOUR NAME] [phone] [email]

Tip: the correct sign-permit contact is licensing@newmarket.ca. One other address, signs@newmarket.ca, shows up on other websites. It has never been confirmed on an official Newmarket page. Do not use it.

1.4 Bradford West Gwillimbury: the grandfathering and licence letter

When to use it: send this before you file for a Bradford sign licence. It confirms in writing that a licence issued today stays valid (**grandfathered**) after the Town's rewrite. BWG's Building Division has no published email; see below for how to send it.

How to send it: call 905-778-2055 ext 1520. Ask where the Building Division wants this in writing: by email, fax or in person. Or hand-deliver it to 100 Dissette St, Units 7 and 8, Bradford ON L3Z 2A7.

Subject: Pre-consultation: third-party digital ground sign licence, [civic address]

Hello,

I am planning a third-party digital ground sign at [civic address], with the owner's consent. The face is one 10 ft by 20 ft, 18.58 m². The height is [x] m. Please confirm the following in writing.

1. What does the Chief Building Official need for the written approval under s.9.2 to 9.4? What is the typical time?
2. The lot is within 400 m of County Road 88. Does Simcoe County By-law 6756 apply? Does the Town need the County permit before it issues the licence?
3. What licence fee applies today: Schedule A's \$20 per m², or the current fees by-law? Is it charged per face?
4. The licence is valid 10 years under Schedule B. What does renewal require and cost? The licence form refers to Section 4.16.
5. The security deposit is 10% of construction value. When is it released?
6. Council endorsed a comprehensive sign by-law update on December 2, 2025. If a licence is issued before a new by-law passes, will it stay valid?

7. Does site plan control or a Heritage Committee review apply to this lot?

Thank you.

[YOUR NAME] [phone] | [email]

RULE: send the Simcoe County letter too, for any lot within 400 m of Holland Street. Do this before you count on a Bradford licence alone. A County rule can apply on top of the Town's rule.

Companion letter, Simcoe County, service@simcoe.ca, 705-735-6901:

Subject: Sign permit under By-law 6756: billboard near County Road 88 in Bradford West Gwillimbury

Hello,

I am planning one billboard at [civic address]. The face is one 10 ft by 20 ft, 18.58 m². The height is 8 m or less. Please tell me:

1. Is this address within 400 m of a County Road limit under By-law 6756?
2. Please send the current Sign Permit application form, and the list of required documents.
3. For a face of 18.58 m², is the highway property line setback 30 m?
4. Suppose the lot cannot meet the 305 m spacing or the 91 m intersection distance. How does the section 10 variance work, and how long does it take?
5. How long does a complete application take? When must I notify the County for inspection?

Thank you.

[YOUR NAME] [phone] | [email]

1.5 MTO: the highway sign letter

When to use it: any parcel within 400 m of a 400-series highway (Highway 404, near East Gwillimbury or Newmarket, is one example) or of Highway 407. **MTO** is the Ministry of Transportation of Ontario. It has no published email for this desk, so this is a phone script. Follow up by fax for a paper record.

Phone: 416-235-5385, toll-free 1-866-636-0663, MTO Central Region, Corridor Management, Downsview Office. **Fax, for a written follow-up:** 416-235-4267, addressed to MTO Central Region, Corridor Management. Mailing address: 159 Sir William Hearst Avenue, 7th Floor, Downsview ON M3M 1J8.

Call script and fax cover text:

"Hello, my name is [YOUR NAME]. I am planning one digital billboard, about 18.6 square metres, at [civic address]. I believe this site is near [Highway 404 / 407 / 400]. I have four questions, and I would like a written answer if possible.

1. Is this address in the controlled area of a Class 1 or 2 highway? This is under section 38(2)(e) of the Public Transportation and Highway Improvement Act. Does that mean I need a Ministry sign permit?
2. Is the Highway Corridor Management System, at hcms.mto.gov.on.ca, the correct place to apply? Is \$770 for 5 years still the current fee for a billboard sign permit?
3. Once issued, can this kind of permit be cancelled by the Minister without compensation? If so, under what section?
4. What is the current processing time? Is it still about 30 business days, from a complete application to a decision?

My mailing address is [address] and my phone number is [phone]. Thank you for your help."

Detail: the Minister can cancel a permit under this Act at any time (section 38(11)). Since November 27, 2025, the law says cancellation is never treated as taking your property and is never owed compensation (section 96). That means an MTO-permitted sign is less secure than a town-permitted one. Highway 407 falls under a separate law, the Highway 407 Act, section 35(3). MTO handles both the same way in practice.

2. The landlord offer letter

When to use it: once you have a shortlisted parcel with a pylon or room for one, before you spend on drawings. It is not a lease.

Subject: A proposal for the sign pole at [ADDRESS]

Dear [Landlord name],

My name is [YOUR NAME]. I am building a small, local digital sign company based right here in Richmond Hill. I am writing about the [pole / plaza sign] at [ADDRESS].

The idea. We would rebuild your sign pole into a modern digital sign, at our cost. We would keep every one of your tenants' panels exactly as they are today.

What you would receive. Rent equals 20% of **gross advertising revenue**, or \$10,000 a year, whichever is more. **Gross advertising revenue** means all the money the sign takes in, before our costs. You get this rent no matter how full the sign is in a slow month. You would pay nothing toward building it. You would pay nothing toward its power, insurance, permits or upkeep either. Suppose the City raises your property's **assessed value** because of the sign. **Assessed value** is the dollar figure the City uses to set your property tax. We reimburse that extra tax too. About \$1,000 a year in our plan, an **ESTIMATE**.

What stays protected. Your tenants' panels, sightlines and existing lease rights are unaffected. Brightness and content follow the City's rules and our own written policy. No flashing, no scrolling, static messages only.

Your exits. The lease term, including every renewal, would be written as under 21 years. This follows the Ontario Planning Act. Suppose you ever sell or redevelop the property. You can end the lease on notice, with fair payment for the structure's **unamortized cost**. This is the part of the build cost we have not yet earned back. Or we relocate the sign elsewhere on your property. If the sign business ever stops, we remove the structure at our cost. We post security up front to guarantee this.

Your protection. We would carry commercial general liability insurance, called **CGL**, of at least \$2,000,000. It would name you as an additional insured. We would register the lease against the property. A future buyer would be bound by it. We would pay your own lawyer's and lender's fees to review and consent to it.

Next step. I would like 30 minutes to walk the site with you. I can show you photos of similar signs nearby, and answer any questions. Nothing needs to be decided at that meeting. Could you also tell me your lawyer's name? And whether your lender would need to know?

Thank you for considering this,

[YOUR NAME] [phone] [email]

Careful: never promise the town will approve the permit. Never state a guaranteed revenue number in this letter or out loud. Say "we expect" or "our plan assumes," never "you will earn."

If the landlord raises a concern:

What they worry about	What you say
"This will raise my property taxes."	Only the sign itself is assessed, at its replacement cost less 50%, by MPAC , the Municipal Property Assessment Corporation, Ontario's assessment body. Your land and building keep their own value. We reimburse the sign's share, about \$1,000 a year in our plan.
"My tenants will lose their panels."	Every panel stays. We get written tenant consent where a lease requires it.
"What if I sell or redevelop?"	You can end the lease with 12 months' notice, plus payment for the unamortized cost. Or we relocate on your property. The lease is registered, so a buyer is bound by the same terms.
"What if your company disappears?"	We post a removal deposit or bond. We carry \$2 million liability insurance naming you. The lease can be assigned to a bigger, established operator if we ever need to step back.
"My lender will object."	We prepare the consent package and pay your lender's and lawyer's fee. We ask only for a non-disturbance clause, a promise that your lender will not evict us if you default on your mortgage.
"Why should I believe a new company?"	We are local, based on Yonge Street. We can show you signed letters of intent from advertisers and our insurance certificate before you sign anything.

3. Selling toolkit

Use any of these in Farsi if the owner prefers.

3.1 Cold-call or walk-in script, 60 to 90 seconds

When to use it: your first approach to a local business owner, by phone or walking into their shop.

Open: "Hello, is this [Name]? I am [YOUR NAME]. I am not selling anything today. Do you have 60 seconds? If it is a bad time, tell me and I will call back." Why I am calling: "I am planning one digital billboard on Yonge Street, Richmond Hill, near [cross street]. It is not built. The town has not approved it yet. Before I spend money, I am asking ten local owners one thing. Would this be useful to you, at what price?" Why you: "I picked [Business] because [you are close by / customers pass here / we share a language]." Offer: "There are six slots. Each advertiser gets one slot of 8 seconds, all day. The founding price is \$1,400 for 4 weeks, on a one-year order. That price is fixed for the year. You pay nothing until the board is live. A refundable deposit comes only after the town approves it." Ask: "Could I show you a picture of what your ad would look like on it? Ten minutes, [Tuesday or Thursday]. Morning or afternoon?" If yes: confirm day, time, place. Ask if they prefer WhatsApp or email for the picture. Write down the answer and the date. That is their permission to message them. If not now: "Understood. May I send a short message with the location and price?" Note the date. If no: "Thank you for your time. One question: what would make a sign like this worth it?" Then stop there. Voicemail: "Hello [Name], this is [YOUR NAME]. I am planning a digital billboard on Yonge Street in Richmond Hill. I would value your advice as a local owner. I will try again on [day]. You can reach me at [phone]. Thank you."

RULE: never say "guaranteed," "sold out soon" or "everyone will see it." Never claim false approval. A false claim breaks Canada's false-advertising law.

3.2 Text or WhatsApp opener

When to use it: a business whose number the business itself published or gave you (see the RULE below). Only text them about their own business.

First message: "Hello [Name], this is [YOUR NAME]. I am planning one digital billboard on Yonge Street in Richmond Hill. I am asking local owners for advice before it is built. May I show you a two-minute mock-up of an ad for [Business]? No cost, no pressure. To stop messages, reply STOP. [Company Name], [mailing address], [phone]."

If yes: "Thank you. This is the location, and this is what your ad could look like: [picture]. The board is not built yet, and needs town approval. The founding price is \$1,400 per 4 weeks, on a one-year order, fixed price. Nothing is due until it is live. May I bring a one-page summary to your shop on [day]?"

If "How much?": "List price will be \$1,900 per 4 weeks. Founding advertisers pay \$1,400 on a one-year order, fixed for the year, plus HST. I can show you what that works out to per day and per thousand views."

RULE: only text a number the business itself published. Or a number they gave you by voice or in writing. Texting a number you found any other way breaks Canada's anti-spam law.

3.3 Email pitch

When to use it: after a first call or visit, or as a first outreach if you have not reached the owner yet.

Subject: A local digital billboard on Yonge Street: would it help [Business]?

Hello [Name],

I am [YOUR NAME]. I am planning one digital billboard on Yonge Street, near [cross street]. It is not built yet, and it needs the town's approval. I am asking local owners for advice first.

What it is: one 10 by 20 foot LED screen with six slots. Each advertiser gets one 8-second slot in a repeating loop, day and night.

Who passes: York Region counted about [number] vehicles a day on this stretch, count dated [date]. I will send you the report. Each view is a chance to see, not a promise to be remembered.

What it costs: founding advertisers pay \$1,400 per 4 weeks, on a one-year order, plus HST. That is about \$50 a day, an ESTIMATE. You pay nothing until the board is live.

What I would like: ten minutes to show you a mock-up of your ad. I would also like to hear what would make this useful for [Business]. Would [day] or [day] suit you?

Thank you, [YOUR NAME], [Company Name], [mailing address], [phone], [email]

If you would rather not hear from me, reply STOP. I will not write again.

3.4 Follow-up sequence

When to use it: after any first contact that did not end in a signed LOI. Stop after day 45, unless they ask you to keep going.

- Day 0: call or visit. Log who decides, best day to reach them, and what they said.

- Day 2, message: "Thank you for your time, [Name]. Here is the picture we talked about: [image]. If anything is unclear I am happy to explain."
- Day 5, email: a one-page summary. Location, size, slots, price, and the traffic count. Say the deposit is refunded in full if the permit fails.
- Day 10, call with one new fact: "The Region's count is in. About [number] vehicles a day. Would ten minutes this week help?"
- Day 21, message: "The founding price stays open until [date], or until advertiser four signs. Would you like a slot held for you?" Say this only if it is true.
- Day 45, note: "I understand the timing may not be right. May I check in again in [month]? If plans change, my number is [phone]." Then contact every 3 months after that.

3.5 Objection-answer sheet

When to use it: keep this open during any sales call.

1. "How many people see it?" "Fair question. The Region counted about [number] vehicles a day here, on [date]. At about 1.4 people a car, that is [number] chances to see in 4 weeks. Those are chances to see, not people who will remember you. Your slot plays about 1,800 times a day. That is 6 slots at 8 seconds each: 48 seconds a loop, run 24 hours. I will give you the count report to check it."
2. "Is it worth it?" "I cannot promise sales, and I will not. I can set it up so we can see. Use a phone number or promo word only for the board. Ask your staff how each new customer heard about you. If one customer is worth \$[profit] to you, divide \$1,400 by that number. That tells you how many new customers you need in 4 weeks to break even. Example: a customer worth \$200 to you needs 7 new customers in 4 weeks. That is \$1,400 divided by \$200. Does that sound possible?"
3. "Too expensive." "Tell me what would feel comfortable. [Listen.] Options: 12 weeks at \$1,750, a year at \$1,500, \$1,400 founding. That is about \$50 a day, day and night. What am I not seeing that makes it feel high?"
4. "I will think about it." "Of course. What would you like to think about: price, location, or whether it suits your business? If there was anything in this proposal you would change, what would it be? May I call you on [day] to hear your decision, whatever it is?"
5. "I already advertise in [paper, radio, Instagram]." "Good, keep it. This is different, because people see it every day on the road, without choosing to. Many owners use it alongside what they already do. What do you spend now, and which month brings the most customers?"
6. "It is not built. Why trust you?" "You should be careful. That is why nothing is due until it is live. The deposit is refundable and held in trust. If it is not live by [outside date], the order ends. Your deposit comes back. I will show you the permit status every month."
7. "People drive too fast to read it." "True, for long messages. So we keep it to about seven words: your name, and one thing. It works best for being remembered, on a road people use every day."
8. "I must ask my partner or head office." "Of course. Shall I prepare a one-page summary for them? Could we all meet on [day]?"
9. "Can I try one month?" "Yes, once it is live. One period is \$1,900, and the founding year is \$1,400. Many owners find one month too short to judge fairly. Would 12 weeks at \$1,750 be a fair middle?"
10. "Give me a better price." "\$1,900 minus \$1,400 is \$500. \$500 is 26% of \$1,900. I can talk about paying a year in advance." Only if you allow prepay discounts.
11. "What if the town says no?" "Then the order ends. You get your deposit back in full, within 10 business days. It is written in the order."
12. "The big companies are cheaper." "For a big reach, they may be. This board is one road in your neighbourhood. Ask what they charge for the road your customers use. Compare the cost per thousand views."

13. "Do you have other advertisers?" "Not yet. You would be one of the first four. That is why the price is lower and fixed."
14. "Have you done this before?" Say only what is true. Example: "I sell for a living. I have not run a billboard before. Nothing is due until it is live."

3.6 The one-page LOI outline

When to use it: once a business says yes in principle. Have a lawyer check the final wording before you use it for real.

Title: Letter of Intent to Advertise on a Proposed Digital Billboard.

1. Parties and date.
2. What is planned: one single-faced 10 by 20 ft billboard, six slots, 8 seconds each. Planned for Yonge Street in Richmond Hill, near [cross street]. It does not exist yet.
3. What the Advertiser intends: one slot, [12] months, at \$[1,400] per 4 weeks. Price fixed for the term.
4. Start: on the day the board goes live, about [month year]. Dates may move by written agreement.
5. What must happen first. The town issues the sign and building permits. The Operator signs the land lease. The board is built and running. If not all done by [outside date, six months after target], this letter ends.
6. Next step: within 10 days of permits and lease, the Operator sends a full Order. If signed, a 10% deposit of the yearly price is paid. It is held in trust, and refundable until go-live.
7. Money now: none [or a refundable \$X].
8. Not binding. This letter states plans and prices. Neither side must sign the Order. The only promise: no money is due under this letter.
9. Content: must follow the law and the town's rules. In Richmond Hill, at least 50% must be English or French text. It must also follow the Advertiser's own regulator. The Operator may refuse or remove non-compliant ads.
10. Signatures, names, titles, dates.

When to use it: a shorter, spoken version of the same LOI, for a quick yes on the spot. Say: "I intend to buy one slot, for 12 months." "The price is \$[price, at least 1,400] per 4 weeks, plus HST." "This starts once the board is live, by [date]." "Ads would be about 6 to 10 seconds, in a shared loop." "This letter does not bind either side. No money is paid now." "If the board goes ahead, we sign an order. A deposit is held in trust until live."

4. RFQs, for builders and screen suppliers

When to use it: once you have a shortlisted site and the City's zoning answer. Send the same email to every finalist supplier (Media Resources, Daktronics Canada, Nummax, Formetco, and one I-View dealer) so quotes compare like for like.

Subject: Request for quotation, single-face 10 ft x 20 ft digital billboard, Richmond Hill, Ontario

Hello,

We are a new Ontario company. We are planning one digital billboard, on a plaza pylon site, Yonge Street, Richmond Hill. We would like a written quote in Canadian dollars. We are new to the Ontario market, so please flag anything Ontario-specific or unusual.

1. **SCOPE.** Please price these six items separately, and then as one turnkey total. - LED screen, controller, software and cellular modem. - Steel column and screen frame, 7.5 m overall height. - Drilled concrete foundation, we will supply the soil report. - Crane, installation and commissioning. - Electrical on site to a disconnect at the pole. - Project management and permit drawings support.

Option B: new screen on the existing pylon, if our engineer approves it. 2. **SCREEN.** One face, 10 ft x 20 ft, 10 mm pixel pitch, also price 13 mm. The screen must be outdoor rated, for weather from minus 30 to plus 35 C. Please list resolution, maximum and night brightness in nits, average and maximum power in watts, weight, cabinet size, cooling method and IP rating. 3. **CONTROLS.** Automatic day and night dimming with a photocell. The screen must go dark on any fault. We need remote monitoring with email alerts, and static images only. Each ad shows for 8 seconds, though the City minimum is 3 seconds. We need six ads in a loop, a cellular connection, and cloud software. Please state any yearly fee for the software. 4. **CERTIFICATION.** The exact model must carry a CSA, cULus or cETLus mark (a recognized Canadian safety certification). Please attach the certificate. 5. **ENGINEERING.** Structural drawings must be stamped by an Ontario P.Eng. We need a Commitment to General Review, plus a Field Review Report after installation. Please name the engineer and their **PEO** (Professional Engineers Ontario) number. 6. **WARRANTY AND SERVICE.** Please tell us these seven things: - Years of warranty for parts, labour and brightness. - What voids the warranty. - Response time in hours for a service call. - Where your technicians are based. - Whether spare modules and power supplies are included. - Training for two people. - A commissioning test sheet. 7. **COMMERCIAL.** Prices in CAD, with HST shown separately. Freight and duty included, or shown. Price valid 30 days. Lead time from order to delivery, and delivery to live. Payment stages. A copy of your standard contract. 8. **COMPLIANCE.** Please attach a certificate of CGL insurance and your **WSIB** (Workplace Safety and Insurance Board, Ontario's workers' compensation body) clearance number, which proves you are paid up. Please also send two Ontario references for similar boards.

Site: [ADDRESS]. Decision date: [DATE]. Please reply with questions by [DATE], and the quote by [DATE].

Thank you, [YOUR NAME], [company], [phone], [email]

Tip: pricing the steel structure separately from the screen is sometimes cheaper. If you do, send this shorter version to a steel fabricator instead:

Subject: Quote request: steel column and frame, 10 ft x 20 ft LED billboard, Richmond Hill

Hello,

We need a fixed-price quote, in Canadian dollars, for one billboard's steel structure. The board is 10 ft x 20 ft. This covers a single steel column, 7.5 m overall height under Richmond Hill By-law 25-26. It also covers the screen frame, base plate, and anchor bolts. Plus an access door, paint or galvanizing, and delivery. Please also price installation by crane, if you offer it.

Loads: screen weight [FROM SUPPLIER, about 1,800 to 4,000 lb]. Plus wind and snow loads, under the Ontario Building Code. Stamped drawings will be supplied by [ENGINEER]. Please tell us these six things:

- Your welding certification. We need to know if you hold **CWB** (Canadian Welding Bureau) and **CSA W47.1** (the national standard for certified steel welders).
- Whether shop drawings are stamped by an Ontario P.Eng.
- Lead time in weeks.
- Your insurance certificate.
- Your **WSIB** clearance number.
- Photos and two references of similar digital or billboard structures you built.

Please also state what you assume for the foundation. And who supplies the anchor bolts.

Site: [ADDRESS]. Reply by [DATE].

Thank you, [YOUR NAME], [phone]

5. Rep-agreement request email

When to use it: to ask an operator to let you sell their open slots on commission, before you own a board yourself.

Subject: Sales partner for your York Region and Bradford digital boards

Hi [name],

My name is [YOUR NAME]. I am building a small advertising sales business. I serve Persian-speaking businesses along Yonge Street in Richmond Hill and Thornhill. I would like to sell open slots on your boards, on a commission-only basis. Could you tell me:

1. Do you work with independent reps or agencies? What commission do you pay, as a percent? Is it paid on collected money or on invoice?
2. Your current rate card, loop size, slot count, and spot length for [board names].
3. How ads are approved, creative specs, and how long from booking to going live.

I would want a simple, non-exclusive agreement, with a 30-day exit. I can send a company name and HST number once we agree terms. Could we speak for 10 minutes this week?

Thank you, [YOUR NAME] [phone]

Send to: Sanford Outdoor, 905-339-1339. DigiPoint Media, 289-223-1001. Eye Candy Ads, 647-470-1237, Mark Snaper. Part 16 has the full contact list and what else to ask each one.

Checklist for the lawyer to review before you sign a rep agreement:

- **Non-exclusive:** so you can also sell for other operators.
 - **Commission percent:** and whether it is paid on money collected or on the invoiced amount.
 - **Renewal commission:** whether you also earn commission on renewals, not only the first sale.
 - **First-period commission:** paid within 30 days.
 - **Billing:** who invoices and collects the money from the advertiser.
 - **Territory:** your territory, and which boards it covers.
 - **Payment date:** a set date each month, with a statement.
 - **Exit:** either side can end it on 30 days' notice.
 - **No lock-in:** no non-compete and no exclusivity clause against you. It must not stop you owning your own board later.
 - **No personal liability:** if an advertiser does not pay, you are not on the hook.
 - **Ad approval:** the operator approves every ad before it runs.
 - **Confidentiality:** applies only to their own price lists, not to your own business.
-

6. The employer consent note

When to use it: send this to your manager, or the owner or top manager of your employer, before you do any billboard work. Ontario law already voids almost every employee's non-compete clause (see Detail below).

Hi [name],

I am starting a small side project, on my own time. I sell ad space to local businesses. I will not use my employer's time, systems, customer lists or contacts. I will not sell to any business that competes with my employer. Please reply to this email to confirm you are comfortable with that.

Thank you, [YOUR NAME]

Detail: Ontario's Employment Standards Act section 67.2 voids a written non-compete clause for almost every employee. Check whether your exact job title sits on the law's narrow "executive" titles list; most titles do not. The note is not legally required. A duty of honesty and loyalty to your employer still applies while you work there, and a written reply is better evidence than a verbal one.

7. Co-founder agreement checklist

When to use it: before you incorporate or spend real money. Go through it with your co-founder and any family member with a financial stake.

People and status

- ☐ **Immigration status:** if your co-founder is not a Canadian citizen or permanent resident, get their status confirmed in writing, by a paid RCIC (a Regulated Immigration Consultant) or an immigration lawyer, not IRCC's phone line, before they do any paid or unpaid work in the company. Status decides whether they can be paid, work unpaid, or only lend money and hold shares.
- ☐ **Personal details:** your co-founder's age, when they landed in Canada, their town, and their English level.
- ☐ **PEP check:** if your co-founder or a family member ever held, or is related to someone who held, a top government or military post abroad, that makes them a foreign **PEP**. That status is permanent once it applies, and it must be disclosed to any bank early.
- ☐ **Sanctions check:** whether any bank you or your co-founder used in another country is on Canada's sanctions list. Check with a lawyer before any transfer.
- ☐ **T1135 check:** whether your co-founder, or any family member with foreign assets, has ever needed to file a T1135 form with the CRA, and whether they actually have.

Money and risk

- ☐ **Total cash:** is the cash you and your co-founder could put in already in a Canadian bank account with a paper trail?
- ☐ **Maximum loss:** how much you could afford to lose completely if the business fails. A dead board costs an estimated \$155,000 to \$205,000 before any tax relief.
- ☐ **Money from a high-scrutiny country:** whether money from a country with sanctions exposure or heavy bank scrutiny will be part of this. If so, it must move in one documented step, after a lawyer's advice.
- ☐ **Cash reserve:** the minimum cash reserve you agree to keep untouched. At least \$30,000. Or \$45,000 to \$60,000, if ending the screen lease early costs a lot.

Roles and hours

- [] **Who leads:** who leads day-to-day decisions, and who has the final say if the two of you disagree.
- [] **Your co-founder's hours:** their real weekly hours available. At steady state, with slots sold, expect 2 to 3 hours a week. **TOSI**, tax on split income, can tax dividends at the top rate, unless excepted. They only qualify for the "excluded business" exception at 20 hours a week or more. Keep timesheets as proof.
- [] **Your hours:** your real weekly hours alongside your regular job. At steady state, expect 3 to 5 paperwork hours, plus 2 to 6 selling hours. Combined with your co-founder, that is 9 to 14 hours a week, once slots sell. It rises to 20 to 30 hours combined, in the first 90 days live. It is 12 to 18 hours combined, while the loop is under 60% full.
- [] **Spouse or family member's role:** whether your spouse, or another family member with a financial stake, will hold shares or do regular work in the company. If they do, it changes your TOSI answer too. Ask the accountant.

Company structure

- [] **Share split:** agree on the share split between you and your co-founder. Do this before incorporating, in writing, with a lawyer.
- [] **One main applicant:** only ONE of you can be main applicant, Futurpreneur or Starter Plus. Both need over 50% ownership.
- [] **Who signs:** agree in advance who signs contracts with the town, suppliers and advertisers. The research plan assumes this is you, since the paperwork is in English.

Decisions to make before you spend money

- [] **Ten open questions:** answer the ten open questions in Part 15, Questions We Need Answered, and write the answers down where you both can see them.
 - [] **Stop rule:** agree now what you do, if under 45% full at 12 months live. Cut the price, sell the business, or wind it down.
 - [] **RULE:** order no steel or screen until four of six slots sell, permit in hand.
-

8. Bank meeting checklist

When to use it: before any meeting with Futurpreneur, Alterna, BDC, or a CSBFP-loan bank. **CSBFP** is the federal Canada Small Business Financing Program; the government guarantees most of the loan. Lenders want slightly different documents, so bring everything and let them say what they do not need.

Bring to every lender meeting

- [] **Business plan:** include the numbers from Part 2, How the Money Works.
- [] **Cash flow forecast:** month by month. Futurpreneur wants 24 months. A CSBFP bank, following CIBC's checklist, wants at least 1 year, month by month. It also wants a pro forma balance sheet.
- [] **Tax returns:** T1 returns, and CRA Notice of Assessment, for the last two years. For both of you, and your spouse too, if the lender wants them as guarantor.
- [] **Net worth statement:** a personal net worth statement for each guarantor. Bring investment account statements (**RRSP** retirement, **TFSA** tax-free and **RESP** education accounts) and a mortgage statement if you own property. Also fill in the lender's own Net Worth Worksheet.
- [] **Photo ID:** required for Futurpreneur's MyFP portal and other online application portals.
- [] **Articles of Incorporation:** once the company exists.

- [] **Land lease:** a conditional or signed land lease with the landlord. Or a strong letter of intent, if the lease is not final yet.
- [] **Builder quotes:** written quotes from your builder RFQ, Part 4 above. The lender treats these as your equipment purchase order.
- [] **Insurance:** proof of insurance, or a quote for it. A CSBFP loan requires insurance on the financed equipment.
- [] **Alternatives:** 6 months of your own bank statements, plus a short interview.

Detail: lenders judge a loan partly by **DSCR**, the debt service coverage ratio. Most want 1.20 to 1.25 or higher. A CSBFP loan can also require a personal guarantee, which can be set as high as the full loan amount.

RULE: most lenders count your own cash, not borrowed money, as equity. Start with money already in a Canadian bank account with a clear history. It is the cleanest, cheapest and fastest cash a lender will accept.

9. Permit documents checklist

When to use it: keep every parcel's paperwork here, whichever town you file in. Check the "Who needs it" column, since not every item applies to every town. Part 7, Getting the Permits, has the full steps for each town.

Document	What it is	Who needs it
Written landlord authorization	A signed letter from the property owner allowing you to apply for a sign permit on their land	All towns
Written Request for Zoning By-law Information	The town's free, written confirmation of the zone and permitted uses	Richmond Hill, free form. Ask for the same in writing elsewhere
Sign Permit Application form	The town's own form	All towns
Application to Construct or Demolish, with Schedule 1	The Ontario Building Code's standard building permit application form	Any town that treats the sign structure as a building permit item
Commitment to General Review and Owner's Undertaking	A form where your engineer commits to inspecting the work as it is built	Wherever a building permit is required
Compliance with Applicable Law form	Confirms the sign also meets other laws, like conservation authority or highway rules	Wherever a building permit is required
Statement of Design	The engineer's written basis for the structural design	Wherever a building permit is required
P.Eng stamped structural drawings and calculations	Engineering drawings signed by a licensed Ontario Professional Engineer	All towns
Geotechnical, soil, report	A report on the soil under the foundation, needed before the engineer finalizes the footing	All towns, before final engineering
Ontario Land Surveyor, OLS, survey or site plan	Property lines and sign position	Most towns, and required for financing

Document	What it is	Who needs it
Field Review Report	The engineer's written sign-off after the structure is built	All towns
TRCA or LSRCA clearance letter	Written confirmation from the conservation authority that the site is not regulated, or their own permit if it is	TRCA for Richmond Hill sites. LSRCA for East Gwillimbury and Bradford sites in a regulated area
MTO highway permit	The Ministry of Transportation's sign permit, \$770 for 5 years	Any site within 400 m of a 400-series highway or Highway 407
Simcoe County sign permit	A separate County-level permit	Bradford sites within 400 m of a County Road, Holland St, CR 88
Insurance certificate	CGL, naming the landlord	All towns, and every lender
WSIB clearance certificate	Proof your contractor and every subcontractor are covered	Required before hiring any contractor
Notice of Project	A safety filing required if you act as general contractor yourself and the job is over \$50,000	Only if you do not hire one prime contractor to be the "constructor"
Utility Offer to Connect	The power company's written offer and cost to connect the sign	All towns, from Alectra, Hydro One, or NT Power depending on the site
ESA connection authorization	The Electrical Safety Authority's sign-off before the screen can be turned on, fee \$143	All towns
Manufacturer's safety mark	A cULus or cETLus mark on the exact screen model, proving it passed a recognized safety test	All towns
Comprehensive Signage Design Plan or site plan amendment	An extra design review some plazas need before a sign permit is issued	Only if the City tells you the parcel is under site plan control
Sign permit fee payment	The town's own fee. See below	Whichever town you file in

Sign permit fees, town by town: Richmond Hill is the cheapest, at \$279. East Gwillimbury costs about \$1,988 in year one, roughly seven times more. Newmarket costs \$1,993.31, also about seven times more. Bradford charges about \$20 per m2, plus a refundable deposit, so its total depends on your sign's size. MTO charges \$770 for a 5-year highway permit. Richmond Hill's path is cheaper only if section 1.1's zoning question comes back favourable.

What you do:

1. **You, this week:** send the five town letters in section 1 to shortlisted sites. Keep a copy of each letter and every written answer in that parcel's folder.
2. **You, once a parcel looks promising:** send the landlord offer letter in section 2. Log every landlord's answer, even a no, so you know who to revisit.
3. **You and your co-founder, this month:** use section 3's toolkit on your first ten prospects. Track every call in one shared sheet.
4. **You, once site and zoning confirm:** send section 4's RFQ to all builders on one day, so quotes compare like for like.
5. **You, alongside the search:** send section 5's rep email to Sanford, DigiPoint and Eye Candy. Start earning commission while the main plan is built.

6. **You, before any billboard work at all:** send the employer consent note in section 6. Keep the written reply.
7. **You, your co-founder, and any family member with a financial stake, before incorporating:** work through section 7's checklist, out loud, together. Write down every answer.
8. **You, about April 2027, Gate 2:** bring the section 8 checklist to every lender meeting.
9. **You, for every parcel you pursue:** keep the section 9 permit checklist up to date.

Ontario Billboard Business: Expert Reference

Technical reference for legal counsel, lenders and town staff reviewing a proposed billboard company owned by you and your co-founder. Each fact carries its statute or by-law section, date and status. VERIFIED: read directly in an official document. ESTIMATE: our own calculation or judgment. UNKNOWN: not established in research, confirm before relying. Figures are Canadian dollars unless marked US\$.

Authority. Two files govern every number and decision here and outrank every other file in the project: `research2/MODEL.md` , the financial model (rerun `python3 research2/model.py` to verify), and `research2/DECISIONS.md` , 23 decisions made after all research on September 21 2026. Where a fact could not be independently re-read today, that is stated. The prior document, `research/brief_snapshot.md` (September 20 2026), contains defects corrected here. Do not rely on its numbers. Change-by-change detail is in `research2/CHANGES_W1A.md` (128 lines) and `research2/FACT_BASE.md` .

Verdict. Go, with conditions, staged. Stage 0, October 2026 to January 2027, is paperwork and pre-selling at low cost and fully reversible. The decision to build is made at Gate 2, targeted for April 2027, only if the permit is issued, financing is arranged and four of six slots are signed. No steel or screen order happens before that gate. Decisions.md item 1.

1. Municipal sign by-laws, town by town

Thirteen municipalities were checked. No town scored a clean green light. Richmond Hill, East Gwillimbury, Bradford West Gwillimbury, Vaughan, Barrie, Georgina and Innisfil are conditionally open. Newmarket is parked. Markham, King, Whitchurch-Stouffville, Aurora and Toronto are effectively closed to a new off-premises sign.

1.1 By-law identification and headline permission

Town	Governing by-law	Third-party sign permitted	Digital permitted	Status
Richmond Hill	Chapter 740, amended by By-law 25-26, in force April 8 2026, section 7.6.7	Yes, an ordinary ground sign on land zoned Commercial or Industrial may carry off-premises advertising	Yes, the whole face, minimum 3 second dwell	Yellow, the critical path
East Gwillimbury	By-law 2025-052 as amended by 2026-077, enacted July 23 2026	Yes, one Billboard Sign per lot on Industrial, Commercial, Employment, Rural or Aggregate Resource zoned land	Yes, as a separate Electronic Billboard Sign class, Part 18.2 and Part 19	Yellow
Bradford West Gwillimbury	By-law 2011-023, office consolidation dated April 21 2026	Yes outside land zoned Residential, section 5.15	Yes, only with prior written Chief Building Official approval, section 9.2 to 9.3	Yellow

Town	Governing by-law	Third-party sign permitted	Digital permitted	Status
Newmarket	By-law 2017-73, last amended by 2020-22	Yes in Commercial, Employment or Urban Centre zones, excluding the Downtown Urban Centre and Historic Downtown Urban Centre	Yes, Electronic Changeable Copy up to 100 percent of the sign face, section 25.1, but section 16.6 elsewhere bars automated message changes, an unresolved internal conflict, see the drafting trap in section 1.10	Red, parked
Vaughan	By-law 140-2018, fee by-law 051-2026	Yes, one billboard per lot, inside Official Plan Employment Areas only, section 15.1	Yes, static messages only, minimum 10 second dwell	Yellow
Barrie	By-law 2018-029, amended by 2026-011, January 28 2026	Yes as a poster panel (Barrie's term for a billboard) on vacant Commercial or Industrial land and all Agricultural land, section 12.1.1.1. Third-party advertising on ground signs and building walls was banned by 2026-011, pushing new third-party copy into the poster panel route	Yes, static images only, minimum 8 second dwell, auto-dimming required	Yellow
Georgina	By-law 2006-0062, amended by 2022-0036	Yes, subject to a town-wide cap of 25 boards, section 7.2(J)	Existing boards may convert to digital, 5 second dwell	Yellow
Innisfil	By-law 050-06, consolidation March 27 2024	Yes on Commercial, Agricultural or Industrial land within 300 metres of a provincial highway or county road, subject to a hard cap of 45 boards town-wide with a waiting list. The section number for this permission is not captured in research2/FACT_BASE.md	No, static only, no electrically animated or moving parts allowed	Yellow
Markham	By-law 2002-94, consolidated to April 2024	Prohibited unless Council approves, section 4.7.1(d), subject to a town-wide cap of 10, section 5.7.1. RCC Media is reported to hold most of the ten, though the exact count against the cap is unverified. RCC separately runs 12 digital bridge screens under its own 20-year agreement with the City and OUTFRONT, and it is not established whether those 12 count against the cap of 10 or sit outside it	Not addressed for a newly approved board	Red
King Township	By-law 2018-03, enactment date UNKNOWN, not found in research read	Prohibited, section 42(a)	Prohibited	Red

Town	Governing by-law	Third-party sign permitted	Digital permitted	Status
Whitchurch-Stouffville	By-law 2016-012-RE, passed February 2 2016	Advertising unrelated to the business on the lot is prohibited, section 3(l)	Not applicable	Red
Aurora	By-law 5840-16, enactment date UNKNOWN, not found in research read	Council approval only, no published size or spacing standard	Not documented in any public source found	Red, closed for planning purposes
Toronto	Municipal Code Chapter 694, consolidation dated June 3 2024	Yes only in Commercial, wall only, Commercial Residential, small wall only, Employment and Utility districts outside every ban zone	Yes, electronic static copy only, no motion	Red, closed by geometry and by a sign tax, not by a competitor

1.2 Spacing and setbacks

Town	From another off-premises sign	From a dwelling or Residential zone	From an intersection	From a 400-series highway
Richmond Hill	300 m, no exemption unless the sign is an Electric Vehicle Charging Station Sign	100 m from land zoned Residential, no exemption on this test even for an EV sign	15 m from a traffic control device	400 m, no EV exemption
East Gwillimbury	300 m static from static, 300 m Electronic from Electronic, 150 m Electronic from static	250 m from a dwelling or Residential-zoned land, applies to both classes	100 m for an Electronic Billboard Sign, the equivalent static-sign test is textually unclear, see traps below	400 m unless the MTO Corridor Signing Policy permits it
Bradford West Gwillimbury	40 m radius from another lawful third-party sign	Section 5.15 bars any Residential-zoned lot outright	15 m from an intersection or traffic control device	Not addressed in the town by-law. The Simcoe County layer applies within 400 m of a County Road
Newmarket	300 m from another Billboard, 15 m from any Ground Sign	200 m from Residential zoning, a school, a park or an Ontario Heritage Act property. The electronic overlay adds 30.48 m from Residential	22.86 m from an intersection or traffic light for the electronic overlay, not separately stated for static copy	The Highway 404 pocket sits mostly inside MTO's 400 m band

Town	From another off-premises sign	From a dwelling or Residential zone	From an intersection	From a 400-series highway
Vaughan	600 m on the same side from another billboard	100 m from a building with dwelling units or Residential-zoned land	Not addressed	400 m unless the MTO Corridor Signing Policy permits it. Vaughan staff recommended an exemption from the by-law's own 20 m ² /8.0 m limits for two ONroute sites on Highway 400 in King City, but whether Council formally adopted it is unconfirmed, see section 1.9
Barrie	500 m on the same side from another poster panel	100 m from Residential-zoned land	Not addressed, 15 m from every property line applies generally	Not a distinct test in Barrie's by-law
Georgina	Not addressed beyond the 25-board town-wide cap	400 m from Residential-zoned land, applies to faces of 10 m ² or more	Not addressed	Not addressed
Innisfil	300 m from another billboard	60 m from a Residential-zoned lot, or a distance equal to the sign's height, whichever is greater	Not addressed, 10 m to the street line	Must sit within 300 m of a highway or county road to qualify at all
Markham	400 m from any other billboard	100 m from Residential-zoned land	Not addressed	Not addressed beyond the Council-approval requirement
Toronto	100 m from another third-party sign, 150 m if electronic, 500 m from another electronic sign on the same street or an intersecting one	60 m for an electronic sign, 30 m for a static one, from Residential, Residential Apartment, Commercial Residential, Institutional or Open Space districts	30 m from the intersection of a major street with any street	400 m from every listed highway, plus 450 m either side of Yonge Street from Highway 401 to Drewry and Cummer Avenues

Markham, King and Whitchurch-Stouffville are omitted from the fee and permit-life table below because a new third-party sign is prohibited or Council-approval-only with no published standard. Aurora's standards could not be independently verified today.

1.3 Size, height, permit life and fee

Town	Maximum face size	Maximum height	Permit life	2026 fee
Richmond Hill	0.30 m ² per linear metre of Street Line frontage to a maximum 19.00 m ² on Commercial land, 5.00 m ² on Industrial, Institutional or Agricultural land. Sign area includes the frame	3.50 to 7.50 m, tiered by area	Lapses if not erected within 6 months of issue, one further 6-month extension available on written application	\$279 for a permanent ground sign

Town	Maximum face size	Maximum height	Permit life	2026 fee
East Gwillimbury	20.0 m2 per face, 40.0 m2 total	8.0 m	1 year, renewable annually at the Town's sole discretion	\$325.90 review, plus \$45.00 per m2 for an electronic sign review, plus \$31.00 per m2 a year for the third-party advertising permit itself. An 18.58 m2 face costs about \$576 a year in the third-party line alone
Bradford West Gwillimbury	0.3 m2 per metre of frontage to 22 m2, needing about 73 m of frontage	3.5 to 8.5 m, tiered by frontage	10-year licence, non-transferable	\$20 per m2, minimum \$50
Newmarket	18.58 m2 per sign face	7.5 m, minimum 3.05 m ground clearance	5 years from issue	\$1,993.31, renewal \$665.19 every 5 years
Vaughan	20 m2 per face, 40 m2 total	8.0 m	Not stated as a fixed term in the research read today	\$185.00 plus \$46.00 per m2, a 40 m2 example prices at \$2,025
Barrie	20.0 m2 per face, 40.0 m2 total	7.5 m	Not stated as a fixed term in the research read today	\$103.15 plus \$31.32 per m2, a 40 m2 example prices at \$1,355.95
Georgina	10 m2 on Commercial land, 20 m2 needs an Industrial, Institutional, Rural or Open Space lot with about 170 m of frontage	Not found	Not found	Building permit for a freestanding sign, \$456, under the 2026 fees by-law. The sign permit fee itself is unknown
Innisfil	25 m2 per face, 50 m2 total, no single dimension over 7.0 m, maximum 2 faces	10 m	6 months, renewable once for a further 6 months	\$452.00, renewal \$200.50, sign variance \$1,004.70
Toronto	20.0 m2 in Commercial, Employment and Utility districts	10 m for a ground sign, 15 m for a wall sign in Commercial or Utility districts	5 years, renewable for a further 5 years if still compliant	The permit fee itself was not separately captured. The Third Party Sign Tax adds \$15,084.23 a year, Class IV, on a face between 5 and 45 m2

1.4 Deciding body and contact

Town	Who decides	Contact
Richmond Hill	Community Standards Division for the permit itself, the Commissioner of Community Services for a variance under section 14, moved from Planning and Building by By-law 25-26	signpermits@richmondhill.ca, 905-771-8800. Zoning confirmation letters, zoninginfo@richmondhill.ca, building@richmondhill.ca, 905-771-8810
East Gwillimbury	Chief Building Official or delegate for the permit, an Appeals Committee for a variance appeal filed within 14 days	bylaws@eastgwillimbury.ca, 905-478-4282 extension 1478

Town	Who decides	Contact
Bradford West Gwillimbury	Chief Building Official for the licence, Council for a variance at \$800, or the Chief Building Official for a minor variance at \$400	Building Division, 905-778-2055 extension 1520
Newmarket	Staff for a standard sign permit. A billboard variance goes to the Committee of the Whole, then Council, and Council's decision is final and binding	licensing@newmarket.ca, 905-953-5300 extension 2221. The address signs@newmarket.ca appears only on a third-party consultant page and is unverified
Vaughan	Staff for the permit, the Sign Variance Committee, which meets monthly, for a variance	BuildingStandards@vaughan.ca
Barrie	Staff through the APLI online portal, the City Clerk for a minor variance	enforcement.services@barrie.ca, 705-739-4241
Georgina	Staff for the permit, Council for a variance	bylaws@georgina.ca, 905-476-4301 extension 3006
Innisfil	Staff for the permit, Council for a sign variance	inquiry@innisfil.ca, 705-436-3710
Toronto	The Chief Building Official for the permit, a 5-member Sign Variance Committee for a variance, meeting about 6 times a year	Toronto Planning and Housing Committee, 416-397-4579. Toronto is a reference point only, treated as closed
Simcoe County, Bradford's second layer	County staff, within 400 m of a County Road such as Holland Street, which is County Road 88	Simcoe County, 705-735-6901
MTO, the provincial layer	Ministry approval, no municipal role	Central Region, Downsview, 416-235-5385

1.5 Richmond Hill, the critical path, detail

Section 7.6.7 reads, quoted directly from the April 2026 consolidation: "A Ground Sign may be used for Off-Premises Advertising, provided such Sign: is only erected on lands Zoned for Commercial or Industrial use; is not located within 100 metres of any lands Zoned for Residential use unless functioning as an Electric Vehicle Charging Station Sign; is not located within 300 metres of another Sign containing Off-Premises Advertising unless functioning as an Electric Vehicle Charging Station Sign; and is not located within 400 metres of any Provincial Highway." The critical open question. The Sign By-law never defines "Commercial Zone," "Industrial Zone" or "Residential Zone." Richmond Hill's new comprehensive zoning by-law, CZBL 93-25, passed September 24 2025 with an Ontario Land Tribunal decision on July 2 2026, replaced the old zone names with mixed-use categories: RMU-COR1 and RMU-COR2, Regional Mixed Use Corridor, KDA-YB and KDA-YC, Yonge corridor Key Development Areas, and RHC, all of which permit both Commercial uses and Apartment Dwellings in the same zone. No City mapping, FAQ, staff report or memo answers whether a mixed-use zone counts as Zoned for Commercial use, which would allow a sign, or as containing land Zoned for Residential use, which could block every neighbouring lot within 100 m under the second test. A City staff memo dated September 22 2025 confirms Industrial lands remain governed by the older by-laws, since Employment Area lands were deliberately left out of CZBL 93-25. Judgment, not fact: our estimate is an 85 to 90 percent chance the City accepts the reading favourable to a sign. On the unfavourable reading, zero of the ordinary shortlisted lots pass. The only route to certainty is a written answer per parcel. Three free or low-cost channels exist: a Request for Zoning By-law Information, up to 5 business days, building@richmondhill.ca, 905-771-8810, a

Permitted Use Letter through the permit portal, and a written sign by-law interpretation from signpermits@richmondhill.ca.

Face size. A true 10 ft by 20 ft LED face is 18.58 m². Richmond Hill's 19.00 m² cap on Commercial land counts the sign's frame, so a real 10x20 board with a normal bezel is over the limit. Two fixes exist: specify a bezel no wider than 22.8 mm, or build an 8 ft by 16 ft face instead, 11.9 m², which also needs only about 40 m of frontage rather than 63 m and saves an estimated \$44,000 on the screen. Decisions.md item 4.

No-digital zones. The Downtown Special Signage Area bars any Digital Display entirely, section 9.1.1(c). Within it, the Village Core, Yonge corridor from about Major Mackenzie Drive to Dunlop and Wright Streets, caps a ground sign at 2.40 m², and the Uptown and Civic Centre districts cap it at 1.00 m², both non-digital, per Table E and Table F. The Headford area and any designated Heritage Property also bar Digital Display. The precise Schedule B and D maps are not inside the 46-page consolidation, so a parcel-level check against the City's own map is required before relying on a lot being outside these areas.

Rule-change risk. Richmond Hill's own 2026 resident survey found 63 percent of 246 respondents concerned about more signs, alongside 41 percent support for commercial ground signs. A Phase 3 comprehensive rewrite of the whole Sign By-law is planned with no date set. A new Council is sworn in November 15 2026. Our estimate is a 30 to 45 percent chance of tightening rules by 2028, with a 5 to 15 percent chance of forced removal carrying an estimated \$157,000 stranded cost. Mitigation: permit-loss exit clause in every site lease (section 5).

1.6 East Gwillimbury detail

By-law 2026-077, enacted July 23 2026, cut the spacing test from 600 m to 300 m, section 18.1(a)(iv) as amended, added a 100 m intersection setback to the Part 18.2 electronic list, and split "Billboard Sign" into a static definition, excluding electronic, and a new "Electronic Billboard Sign" definition. Electronic specifications, Part 19: minimum 10 second message duration, maximum 1 second transition, 5,000 nits by day and 300 nits by night, no more than 3 lux above ambient within 10 m, no more than a 25 percent brightness change at a transition, dark from 23:00 to 07:00 if visible from a habitable room of a legal dwelling, automatic shutoff on malfunction, and third-party certification from an electronic sign expert such as the manufacturer. Four Village Cores, Queensville, Sharon, Mount Albert and Holland Landing, carry a 250 m halo for static billboards and are closed entirely to electronic signs within a 100 m halo.

Two traps. First, the Town's own PDF is not a true consolidation: pages 1 to 39 still carry the pre-amendment October 2025 text, including the old 600 m figure, and the amending By-law 2026-077 is stapled on as pages 44 to 47, last modified August 4 2026. A reader working front to back will see the wrong number. Second, the amendment's drafting creates an ambiguity, since section 5.4 adds a new clause "(m)" to Part 18, but Part 18.1, the static Billboard Sign list, ends at "(f)" and Part 18.2, the electronic list, ends at "(l)," so the new clause in fact continues the electronic list rather than clearly applying to a static sign. Plan for a 100 m intersection setback on a static sign as a precaution, and obtain the Chief Building Official's written interpretation before relying on this point.

Permit renewal is not a right. Section 4.4 allows the Town to refuse or revoke for non-conformity, breach of other laws including the Canadian Code of Advertising Standards, false statements, an application left inactive for 6 months, a sign not seriously started within 6 months of issue, or ongoing non-compliance. Section 20.3 states the annual third-party permit "may be renewed annually, subject to compliance," at the Town's sole discretion, not automatically.

The GIS top candidate corridor is Woodbine Avenue, with roughly 1,240 m of frontage, though zoning by-law 2018-043 places the Yonge Street and Green Lane node, and the 2nd Concession and Green Lane node, in Mixed Use zoning, which section 20.4 closes to a third-party sign by default unless the Town approves

otherwise. Hydro One serves most of East Gwillimbury, and its delivery charges run roughly double Alectra's. No Council meeting able to amend the sign by-law is scheduled before December 15 2026.

1.7 Bradford West Gwillimbury and the Simcoe County layer

By-law 2011-023, section 1(g), defines a billboard as a third-party ground sign displaying copy that is periodically replaced. Section 5.13 sets the 40 m radius spacing test, and section 5.15 bars any Residential-zoned lot. Electronic copy needs prior written Chief Building Official approval under section 9.2 to 9.3, with a minimum 5 second message, 1 second transition, and brightness of 5,000 nits by day and 500 nits by night, no more than 6.5 lux above ambient within 10 m. The licence is non-transferable, section 4.8, and runs 10 years, Schedule B. Revocation has eight grounds, section 12.1(a) through (h): not seriously commenced within 6 months, not substantially completed within 12 months, mistaken or false information, issued in error, the owner's own written request, unpaid fees, an abandoned sign, or a prior required approval that was itself revoked. The town's own fee stack for one clean-site face, separate from any County fee below, is the \$20 per m² sign licence, minimum \$50, the \$266.97 "Permanent Signs" building permit, and a refundable security deposit of 10 percent of construction value, minimum \$500, maximum \$10,000, paid up front and returned only after the Electrical Safety Authority inspection and the engineer's post-erection report both pass.

A second, independent layer applies within 400 m of a County Road. Holland Street in Bradford is County Road 88. Simcoe County By-law 6756 imposes stricter numbers than the town by-law on that band: 305 m spacing, 91 m from an intersection, and 100 m from a home, plus its own separate permit, \$150 the first year and \$100 a year after that, plus HST. This County permit does not itself carry a security deposit, that deposit belongs to the town's own building permit fee line above. A Bradford applicant within 400 m of Holland Street therefore needs both approvals.

The Town's rewrite of its sign by-law was endorsed in principle by the Chief Building Official on December 2 2025 to address digital signage and the Highway 400 employment area, but no draft, notice or consultation has surfaced, and the calendar shows no Council or Committee meeting scheduled through the rest of 2026. The earliest realistic date for a new draft is after the new Council is seated in December 2026. Filing a licence application before any rewrite is the way to lock in the current, looser rule, since section 2.2 grandfathers a lawfully erected sign as long as it is not substantially altered and its use is not discontinued.

1.8 Newmarket detail, parked

By-law 2017-73 remains current, last amended by 2020-22. Table 16.1 permits a billboard in Commercial, Employment or Urban Centre zones, excluding the Downtown Urban Centre and Historic Downtown Urban Centre, capped at 18.58 m² per face and 7.5 m high. Section 16.2 adds the 300 m and 15 m spacing tests and the 200 m Residential, school, park and heritage-property setback. Section 7.2(c) sets a 5-year permit term. The word "renew" does not appear in the by-law text, though the 2026 fee schedule lists a Billboard Sign Renewal fee of \$665.19 every 5 years, so renewal is a fee-schedule item, not a stated right in the by-law.

The Town's own Billboard Acceptable Locations Map, on the eScribe agenda system, shows exactly three pockets where a new billboard would be permitted, each identified from the map's shading rather than from any published legal description: Pocket 1, a large fan-shaped area west of Yonge Street and north of Davis Drive West, matching the footprint of the Upper Canada Mall lands and currently unoccupied. Pocket 2, three tiny slivers at Mulock Drive near the rail line and Prospect Street, sitting entirely inside an existing sign's 300 m circle, meaning no new board can go there while that sign stands. Pocket 3, a long chain of parcels along Harry Walker Parkway North and South near Highway 404, running through the MTO's 400 m controlled area for nearly its whole length, so an MTO permit would be required for most of it.

Council formally ratified the denial of Eye Candy Ads' variance application for 749 Davis Drive on September 15 2025, adopting the Committee of the Whole's recommendation of September 8 2025 by a carried motion with no recorded division. The application sought variances from the 200 m Residential setback, requesting distances as close as 115 m, and from the 200 m school setback, requesting 42 m from Huron Heights Secondary School. Mayor John Taylor and Councillors Jane Twinney and Bob Kwapis, all standing for re-election in October 2026, spoke against it, citing the precedent a grant would set. Under section 33.13, Council's decision on a billboard variance is final and binding, with no appeal route. No sign by-law item has appeared on any Council or Committee of the Whole agenda since that date through September 21 2026, and no Council or Committee of the Whole meeting able to revisit the by-law is scheduled before December 7 and December 14 2026. Realistic timing for any change is January to March 2027 at the earliest.

1.9 Other towns, condensed

Vaughan: Fee By-law 051-2026, effective February 24 2026, replaced 251-2024. Vaughan staff recommended, Committee of the Whole Report 23, Item 16, an exemption from the by-law's own 20 m²/8.0 m limits, not from the separate MTO 400 m highway test, for two ONroute sites on Highway 400 in King City to carry 15.24 m high digital boards, under a June 2023 Minister's Order covering 23 ONroute locations. Whether Council formally adopted that exemption is unconfirmed. The primary Council record was blocked to this research, and only a secondary search extract states a June 24 2025 adoption date. If confirmed, this suggests Vaughan staff will support a provincial project inside the highway band even where its own by-law would otherwise forbid it.

Georgina: the current count against the 25-board cap is not published anywhere found.

Innisfil: the 45-board cap carries a waiting list by date received. Automated message changes are barred along with animated copy and moving parts.

King Township: Council may grant a variance to the section 42(a) prohibition, valid for a maximum of 365 consecutive days.

Whitchurch-Stouffville: the operative by-law is 2016-012-RE, section 3(l). By-law 2004-212-RE was repealed in 2016.

Aurora: By-law 5840-16 is the operative sign by-law, but its detailed third-party rules sit behind a records system that could not be read. Treat Aurora as closed for planning purposes until independently confirmed.

Toronto: see section 2.6.

1.10 Known drafting traps in the primary sources

East Gwillimbury's public PDF is not a consolidated document and displays the pre-amendment 600 m figure on most of its pages, with the actual 300 m amendment stapled on at the end. East Gwillimbury's amendment also creates an ambiguity over whether the new 100 m intersection setback reaches a static Billboard Sign or only an Electronic Billboard Sign. Richmond Hill's Sign By-law never defines the zone names its own tests depend on, and the City's new comprehensive zoning by-law never mentions the Sign By-law at all. Newmarket's section 3.9 cross-references York Region's since-repealed By-law 2015-36, whose Schedule A survives only by an express saving clause in the replacement By-law 2025-62, and the list it points to is a list of where regional-road temporary signs may be placed, not a list of prohibited intersections, so Newmarket's own prohibition-style wording appears to invert the source list's meaning. Newmarket's by-law also contradicts itself on digital signs: section 25.1 permits Electronic Changeable Copy on the whole face of a billboard, but section 16.6 elsewhere says a billboard may be illuminated but not electrically animated and may not have automated message changes. Read together, section 25 likely governs a digital face in practice, and the Town's own staff report on the 749 Davis Drive application treated that sign as having a digital face, but the Town has not

confirmed this reading in writing. Toronto's Chapter 694 text contains a literal drafting error stating an electronic ground sign's height limit in square metres rather than metres.

2. Provincial and Toronto layers

2.1 The permit stack, in order

A billboard needs approvals from up to eleven separate authorities depending on the parcel. In order: landowner authorization by option or lease. Written zoning confirmation, essential in Richmond Hill given the ambiguity above. The town's sign permit or licence. A building permit under the Ontario Building Code, since a freestanding sign of this size is a designated structure requiring engineer-stamped drawings and a post-erection engineer's report. Site plan control approval, where the property is subject to it. York Region Corridor Control, if the frontage is a Regional Road, Yonge Street is Regional Road 1, Davis Drive is Regional Road 31, Green Lane is Regional Road 19, Leslie Street is Regional Road 12, Woodbine Avenue is Regional Road 8. The relevant conservation authority, the Toronto and Region Conservation Authority for Richmond Hill, if the parcel sits in a regulated area. An MTO permit, if any part of the sign is within 400 m of a provincial highway. Simcoe County's own permit, if the Bradford parcel is within 400 m of a County Road. The electricity utility's offer to connect. An Electrical Safety Authority inspection and Certificate of Acceptance before energization. A municipal business licence is generally not required for a sign or advertising company in any of the towns checked.

2.2 MTO and the Public Transportation and Highway Improvement Act

The Highway Corridor Management Manual, April 2025 edition, remains current, confirmed against the Ministry's own library record updated August 31 2026. Section 5.7 states: "Billboard signs are not permitted within the controlled area adjacent to Class 1 and 2 highways." Sections 5.7.2 and 5.7.3 apply this to both rural and built-up or urban segments alike, so there is no urban exception. Class 1 and 2 highways cover the entire 400-series network. The statute, the Public Transportation and Highway Improvement Act, section 38(2)(e), requires a Ministry permit for any sign within 400 m of a controlled-access highway's limit, and section 38(11) lets the Minister cancel any such permit at any time at the Minister's discretion. A November 27 2025 amendment, now section 96, bars any claim for compensation arising from a highway designation, a section 34 or 38 prohibition or direction, or a permit refusal or cancellation. A billboard permit fee is \$770, valid 5 years, with a 30 business day combined acknowledgment and decision window, applied for through the Highway Corridor Management System at hcms.mto.gov.on.ca. Contact, MTO Central Region, Downsview, 416-235-5385.

One frequently repeated sentence does not appear in the April 2025 manual and should not be quoted: that the 400 m band is measured from the projected mainline right-of-way at an interchange. No such sentence was found on a direct search of the current text.

2.3 Highway 407 Act

The controlling provision is section 35(3): "The Minister of Transportation shall control the use of the lands adjacent to the Highway 407 lands, and section 38 of the Public Transportation and Highway Improvement Act applies to the adjacent lands." Highway 407 crosses Yonge Street in the Vaughan and Markham area roughly 150 m south of the Yonge and Highway 7 intersection, so the excluded 400 m band on that stretch of Yonge runs from about Highway 7 to about 8790 Yonge Street, not roughly 3 km.

2.4 Freeway board tracing

Every freeway-adjacent billboard our research could trace to a public record sits on Metrolinx, ONroute or reserve land under an express Minister's Order, most visibly the June 15 2023 Order permitting new billboards at 23 ONroute locations on Highways 400 and 401. One board could not be traced: RCC Media announced a new digital billboard at Highway 400 and Steeles Avenue West on October 28 2025, but no address, side of the road, owner, size or permit record was found on either the Toronto or the Vaughan side of that intersection, and it does not appear on RCC's own locations page. Claim only that every freeway board we could trace sits on government or reserve land under a Minister's Order. The Highway 400 and Steeles board is unresolved as of September 21 2026.

2.5 Conservation authorities and Regional roads

The Toronto and Region Conservation Authority covers Richmond Hill's regulated areas. Its fee schedule, effective February 1 2026, lists two figures for an ancillary structure permit, \$1,035 and \$2,555 per component, but the schedule's own column layout makes it unclear which figure applies to a minor single structure outside all hazards and which applies to a fuller commercial structure. Ask TRCA directly, 416-661-6600 or info@trca.ca, before budgeting this line. The Lake Simcoe Region Conservation Authority governs East Gwillimbury and Bradford's regulated areas, with a Minor permit at \$2,625, an Intermediate permit at \$4,171 and a Major permit at \$6,300, effective April 1 2026. York Region's Signs on Regional Roads By-law 2025-62, in force January 1 2026, governs only structures placed in, on or over a Regional road allowance, so a sign kept entirely on private land does not need Regional approval under this by-law, though any work inside the road allowance, such as a new driveway or utility connection, needs a separate Regional encroachment permit with an estimated 8-week lead time.

2.6 City of Toronto, Chapter 694

Chapter 694, section 694-24A, bans a new third-party sign within 400 m of Highways 400, 401, 404, 409, and 427 for the segments listed, the Don Valley Parkway, the Gardiner Expressway and the Queen Elizabeth Way, plus a 450 m band either side of Yonge Street from Highway 401 north to Drewry Avenue on the west side and Cummer Avenue on the east side. Outside those ban zones, a third-party sign is permitted only in Commercial districts, wall signs only, Commercial Residential districts, a small wall sign only, Employment districts, ground and electronic ground, and Utility districts, ground, wall, electronic ground and electronic wall, capped at 20.0 m² per face.

Toronto's Third Party Sign Tax adds a second, independent cost on top of any permit. An electronic ground sign with an aggregate face area over 5 m² and up to 45 m², which covers a standard 10x20 board, falls in Class IV at \$15,084.23 a year, confirmed against the City's own 2026 rate page. Rates increase annually, invoices are assessed by March 31 and payment is due July 1.

The Sign Variance Committee's full record from February 2024 through September 18 2026 shows 28 decisions on third-party electronic sign applications, 10 granted and 18 refused, a 64 percent refusal rate. Every successful applicant brought a staff-supported, near-compliant proposal in an Employment or Commercial district and paid the \$2,039.44 variance fee. JOLT Charge, an EV-charging and digital advertising company backed by a \$194 million Canada Infrastructure Bank partnership, won 5 of its 13 Toronto applications, including two inside a highway ban zone. Pattison won 1 of its 5 attempts, at 4711 Steeles Avenue East, and was refused the other 4, most recently on September 18 2026 for a proposed sign at 3474 Kingston Road. Toronto is closed by its by-law geometry and its sign tax, not by a Pattison monopoly. A variance is the only route, and it is costly and uncertain, open only to a well-funded, patient applicant.

3. Competition structure, corrected

The market near your target corridor is smaller and more fragmented than a first read suggested. Two independent site developers build the physical structures: Eye Candy Ads, led by Mark Snaper and based in Bradford, holding 3 digital faces in Bradford, 2 in Keswick, 1 in East Gwillimbury with its permit status unverified, and 4 in Barrie, contact 647-470-1237. Action Media, led by Kevin Boyes, holding 10 locations across Barrie, Georgina and cottage country, contact 705-687-2000. Their structures are resold through two sales networks rather than sold direct in most cases: Sanford Outdoor of Oakville, which markets over 130 digital faces across more than 30 Ontario markets but in this corridor mostly resells Eye Candy's and Action Media's own structures, contact 905-339-1339, and DigiPoint Media of Mississauga, a similar fill and resale channel, contact 289-223-1001.

Counting individually confirmed structures on September 21 2026, York Region plus Bradford together hold about 7 to 9 live independent digital faces, and Barrie holds about 8 to 9. No Pattison, Bell or Allvision billboard was found operating in Newmarket, East Gwillimbury, Bradford or Innisfil.

Larger players operate mostly outside this corridor or in adjacent channels. RCC Media holds 45 York Region location cards on its own live page, 31 in Vaughan, 12 in Markham and 2 in Newmarket, counting both digital and static structures together, including two confirmed Newmarket faces on Davis Drive, one digital east of Leslie Street and one static poster east of Yonge Street. BOLD Boards operates 43 digital and 8 static faces, 51 total, across 14 Ontario markets including Barrie, Bradford, Keswick and Vaughan, and offers landowners 15 percent of gross revenue. Pattison Outdoor holds the TTC transit contract to December 31 2033 and a 23-structure ONroute program on Highways 400 and 401, and lists Barrie and York as its northern markets, but no confirmed static or digital billboard in the smaller towns of this study. Bell Media, through its Astral and former Outfront businesses, holds Toronto's street furniture contract to August 2027, with a Council direction toward a new request for proposals issued in March 2026 but not yet posted. G3 Media, formed from 665 or more panels Bell was required to divest, is now Ontario's third-largest operator by that measure. Allvision runs roughly 40 large-format freeway-adjacent faces on Highways 401, 403, 407 and 427 as a site-developer model similar in spirit to Eye Candy's and Action Media's local approach.

The Competition Bureau's own 2024 finding, made in connection with the Bell and Outfront transaction, is that permitting and by-law access, not capital, form the real barrier to entry in this industry. This matches the corridor evidence directly: the two active local operators are small, permit-holding site developers, not the national chains.

4. Economics, with arithmetic

The model covers one 10 ft by 20 ft LED face with six slots and thirteen four-week periods a year, computed September 21 2026.

4.1 Assumptions

Input	Value	Source
Slots in the loop	6, each an 8 to 10 second turn	BillboardHub listings, Vaughan boards, Eye Candy
Price per slot per 4 weeks	\$1,200 bad, \$1,600 likely, \$1,900 good	Vaughan list prices \$1,750 and \$1,995, with 15 to 25 percent term discounts observed
Occupancy, paid slots of 6	40 percent bad, 60 percent likely, 75 percent good	Industry norm for a mature board is about 80 percent. A new board ramps, this is an estimate

Input	Value	Source
Land rent	The greater of 20 percent of gross revenue or \$10,000 a year	BOLD Boards offers 15 percent, Lamar's own filings show about 17 percent, your own offer is capped at 20 percent
Sales cost	10 percent of gross revenue	Commission or reseller cost. Your own selling time is not separately costed
Fixed running costs	\$19,300 a year, table below	Drawn from the Alectra, insurance and operations research files
Build cost, all in	\$130,000 smart build, \$175,000 likely, \$225,000 stress, plus 8 percent contingency	Bottom-up estimate from vendor and cost-survey research, no single verified Canadian quote exists yet
Bank loan	10 years at 7.45 percent, prime plus 3 percent, the CSBFP ceiling, equals \$14,213 a year per \$100,000 borrowed	Canada Small Business Financing Program rules, Bank of Canada prime rate today
Screen lease	84 months at 10 percent equals \$19,921 a year per \$100,000, an unpublished planning band, not a quoted rate	Daktronics, I-View and Formetco vendor financing pages

4.2 Fixed running costs, \$19,300 a year

Electricity, 40,000 kWh, after Alectra's 23.5 percent rebate, before HST, \$6,100. Insurance, liability, property, equipment and cyber combined, \$4,500. Repairs and a spare-parts reserve, \$3,000. Software, cellular data and monitoring, \$1,200. Town permit renewals and fees, \$500. Property tax pass-through to the landlord under MPAC's assessment rules, \$1,000. Bookkeeping, accounting and legal upkeep, \$3,000.

4.3 The three cases, a steady year once the board has filled

Line	Bad	Likely	Good
Revenue, 6 times price times 13 periods times occupancy	\$37,440	\$74,880	\$111,150
Land rent	\$10,000	\$14,976	\$22,230
Sales cost	\$3,744	\$7,488	\$11,115
Fixed running costs	\$19,300	\$19,300	\$19,300
Money left before loans and tax	\$4,396	\$33,116	\$58,505

Likely case revenue would be \$124,800 if every slot sold all year.

4.4 Payback in years, build cost divided by money left

Build cost	Bad case	Likely case	Good case
\$130,000, smart build	29.6 years	3.9 years	2.2 years
\$175,000, likely build	39.8 years	5.3 years	3.0 years
\$225,000, stress build	51.2 years	6.8 years	3.8 years

4.5 The pre-sale revenue floor

RULE: no steel and no screen order before four of six slots are signed for a full year and the permit is in hand. Four slots signed at \$1,400 per 4-week period for a year equals \$72,800 of contracted revenue, close to the entire Likely case of \$74,880.

Signed slots at \$1,400	Revenue a year	Money left before loans
3	\$54,600	\$18,920
4	\$72,800	\$31,660
5	\$91,000	\$44,400
6	\$109,200	\$57,140

4.6 Break-even, at \$1,600 a slot

The board covers its own running and rent costs at about 26 percent occupancy, 1.6 of 6 slots. It covers both those costs and the annual payment on a \$150,000, 10-year loan, \$21,319 a year, at about 46 percent occupancy, 2.8 of 6 slots.

4.7 Loan and lease cost, per \$100,000 financed, per year

Financing	Annual cost
Bank loan, 10 years at 7.45 percent	\$14,213
Bank loan, 15 years at 7.45 percent	\$11,090
Bank loan, 5 years at 7.45 percent	\$24,017
Screen lease, 84 months at 10 percent	\$19,921
Screen lease, 60 months at 10 percent	\$25,496
Screen lease, 48 months at 10 percent	\$30,435

The model's recommendation is to lease only the screen and finance the steel and power connection with the longest bank term available, if the bank will lend against it.

4.8 Cash needed before the first ad, Likely route

Build cost, all in, Likely case, \$175,000, plus 8 percent contingency, \$14,000, plus the HST float on non-screen spend, an estimated \$9,750, normally refundable in 2 to 3 months, plus a start-up reserve for ramp-up, interest and insurance, \$30,000, totals \$228,750. Less the screen, financed separately by lease, \$100,000, leaves \$128,750 still needed from owner cash, a bank loan and any program loan combined.

4.9 Four funding stacks

Lenders generally look for a debt service coverage ratio of at least 1.25.

Stack	Build cost	Screen lease	Bank loan
A, cash-heavy, no bank loan	\$175,000	\$100,000	\$0

Stack	Build cost	Screen lease	Bank loan
B, balanced, sized to a 1.25 coverage ratio	\$175,000	\$100,000	\$46,000
C, smart build	\$130,000	\$80,000	\$30,000
D, low cash, needs 5 of 6 slots pre-sold	\$130,000	\$80,000	\$50,000

Stack	Owner cash needed	Loan payments a year	Coverage ratio	Left after loans
A	\$128,750	\$19,921	1.66	\$13,195
B	\$82,750	\$26,459	1.25	\$6,657
C	\$66,900	\$20,201	1.64	\$12,915
D	\$21,900, plus a \$25,000 program loan	\$29,048	1.53, or 1.14 at the ordinary Likely case rather than pre-sold revenue	\$15,352

Every stack already includes 8 percent contingency, the HST float on non-leased spend, and a \$30,000 start-up reserve. If a screen lease's end-of-term buyout cannot be capped by contract, the reserve should be \$45,000 to \$60,000 instead, since that buyout can run \$20,000 to \$42,000 at month 12 alone.

4.10 Portfolio value and exit multiples

Money left a year before loans, less shared operating costs across a portfolio: 1 board, \$33,116. 2 boards, \$66,232. 3 boards, \$74,348, after a \$25,000 a year shared-cost allowance begins. 5 boards, \$140,580. 10 boards, \$271,160, after a \$60,000 a year shared-cost allowance.

A dead board, one that never fills and is removed, costs an estimated \$155,000 to \$205,000 before any tax relief, with possible Allowable Business Investment Loss relief recovering roughly \$23,000 to \$39,000 of that, an estimated 20 to 25 cents on the dollar. A single board typically sells at 4 to 7 times its own annual cash flow after land, power and a sales allowance, applied to the model that is \$17,584 to \$30,772 in the Bad case, \$132,464 to \$231,812 in the Likely case, and \$234,020 to \$409,535 in the Good case, all estimates. A 3-face network sells at an estimated 5 to 9 times, and a 10-face network with long leases at an estimated 7 to 11 times. Bell's C\$410 million purchase of Outfront Canada in June 2024, roughly 15 times cash flow, is not a comparable benchmark for a single board or a small independent network. Because most municipal sign permits are not transferable, a sale of a billboard business is normally structured as a sale of the corporation's shares rather than an asset sale of the permit itself.

5. Company, tax, immigration and contract layer

Corporate structure. An Ontario corporation under the Business Corporations Act is the recommended vehicle for a two-owner business, at \$300 to incorporate online, with a written unanimous shareholder agreement. This avoids the federal Canada Business Corporations Act's rule that at least 25 percent of directors, or at least one director if there are fewer than four, must be a resident Canadian, a rule that can catch a permanent resident once more than one year has passed since that person became eligible to apply for citizenship. Ontario's own director-residency requirement was repealed in 2021 and does not apply. Directors remain personally liable for up to six months of unpaid wages and up to twelve months of unpaid vacation pay under the Business Corporations Act, and can be held liable for unremitted HST or payroll source deductions, so a shareholder agreement should not be treated as full personal-liability protection.

Your employment. The Employment Standards Act, section 67.2, voids a non-compete agreement for any employee who is not an executive as the Act narrowly defines that term. Check whether your own job title meets that narrow definition. If it does not, no statutory non-compete bars a side business here. The common-law duty of loyalty and good-faith dealing during employment still applies with no written agreement in place. The practical steps are to do all billboard work on personal time with personal equipment, never use your employer's customer data, disclose the side business to your manager in writing and obtain written acknowledgment, and avoid selling advertising space to your employer's direct competitors without separate disclosure and consent.

Lease and contract essentials. A lease over three years should have a notice of lease registered on title under the Land Titles Act, section 111, to bind a future buyer or mortgagee of the land. Land transfer tax on a lease is avoided only where the unexpired term, counting every renewal and option, cannot exceed 50 years in total. Every advertiser insertion order should include a right to reject or remove non-compliant content, a publisher-not-liable clause, an indemnity running from the advertiser, and payment terms tied to posting. Competition Act section 52 reaches a publisher who knowingly runs a misleading ad (see Other publisher duties). Every site lease should include a permit-loss exit clause given the rule-change risk described above.

HST and tax. Register for HST voluntarily on day one, since the roughly 13 percent paid on the structure, screen, installation and legal fees becomes a recoverable input tax credit once registered, and elect monthly filing at registration. A refund is normally issued within about 4 weeks, though a large first refund can trigger a review adding an estimated 8 to 10 weeks. Combined federal and Ontario small business corporate tax on the first \$500,000 of active income is 11.2 percent from July 1 2026 onward, blending to about 11.7 percent for a full 2026 calendar year corporation. The structure and screen fall in Capital Cost Allowance Class 8, a 20 percent declining balance, with an enhanced first-year deduction available for assets acquired before 2030.

Owner pay and family tax rules. Plan to pay nobody in year one except the documented repayment of money the owners themselves lent to the company. The Tax on Split Income rules apply to both owners whenever co-founders are related by marriage or blood, and a family member can only qualify for the excluded-business exception by working an average of 20 hours a week with contemporaneous timesheets. Take no dividends until an accountant has reviewed the structure.

Immigration status. If your co-founder is not a Canadian citizen or permanent resident, get their immigration status confirmed in writing, by a licensed immigration consultant (RCIC) or lawyer, before they do any paid or unpaid work in the company. Under the federal Immigration and Refugee Protection Regulations, section 2, "work" includes any paid activity and can also include unpaid activity that directly competes with citizens or permanent residents in the labour market, so unpaid day-to-day operating work can still count as work requiring status that permits it. A Canadian citizen or a permanent resident who maintains the 730-day residency obligation may own shares, direct, work in and be paid by the company without restriction. An open work permit holder may work for any employer, but Immigration, Refugees and Citizenship Canada's own public pages do not say whether that extends to being self-employed, and a written opinion from an RCIC or immigration lawyer is needed before relying on it. An employer-specific work permit holder may only work for the named employer, and a study permit holder is capped at 24 hours a week during term time, with self-employment income counting toward that cap. A visitor, including a business visitor, may not work in the Canadian labour market at all. Confirm which document they hold, a permanent resident card, a work permit with its stated conditions, or a study permit. The Start-up Visa program and the federal Self-Employed Persons Program are both currently paused and are not a live option.

FINTRAC and money services businesses. Any business that advertises foreign exchange or money transfer services, including by an interior or exterior sign, is itself treated as a money services business and must be registered with FINTRAC, whether or not it conducts transactions. RULE: verify every currency-exchange advertiser's FINTRAC registration number against the public MSB registry before signing a contract and again

before each renewal, since a spot check during this research found one previously assumed advertiser's public registry record showing an expired registration, and at least 18 MSB registrations on Yonge Street were revoked at some point during 2026. Cap currency exchanges at 2 of the 6 slots on any one board regardless of registration status, to avoid the loop reading as a remittance network.

Other publisher duties. The Municipal Elections Act and the Election Finances Act both impose a written-information duty on a billboard company running a third-party political advertisement, plus a 4-year record-keeping and public-inspection duty at the municipal level and a 2-year duty at the provincial level. The Competition Act's misleading-advertising provisions, section 52, expressly reach a publisher who knowingly permits a misleading representation to run, not only the advertiser who created it, and carry penalties up to \$10 million or three times the benefit obtained, whichever is greater, for a corporation. Cannabis and tobacco or vaping advertising is barred outright under their respective federal Acts. Liquor advertising should stay at least 200 m from a school under an AGCO guideline, which uses "should not" wording rather than a hard statutory ban.

6. Verification log, re-checked September 21 2026

Method. Ten research files, one per subject area, each read the town, provincial or federal primary source directly on September 21 2026, not an earlier summary. The line-by-line change record is in `research2/CHANGES_W1A.md` (128 entries), with itemized correction lists in `research2/FACTS_rules.md`, `research2/FACTS_money.md` and `research2/FACTS_market-ops.md`. This reference was written September 22 2026 from that dated research and adds no new primary-source reads.

What changed, headline items. East Gwillimbury's spacing test is 300 m, not the 600 m an earlier draft used, following By-law 2026-077. The freeway claim is narrowed from "every freeway board sits on government or reserve land" to "every freeway board we could trace does," since RCC Media's Hwy 400 and Steeles board remains untraced. The competition structure is corrected from "four or five independents holding a dozen faces" to two site developers reselling through two networks. The build-cost and payback figures are corrected from a single, misleadingly paired \$150,000 and 3.8-year figure to the full Bad, Likely and Good grid in section 4 above. Whitchurch-Stouffville's operative by-law is 2016-012-RE, not 2004-212-RE. Vaughan's fee by-law is 051-2026, not 251-2024. Barrie's By-law 2026-011 newly banned third-party advertising on ground signs and walls. Newmarket's correct sign contact is `licensing@newmarket.ca`, not `signs@newmarket.ca`. Toronto's Sign Variance Committee tally is corrected from 12 decided and 3 granted to 28 decided and 10 granted. The Highway 407 Act section is 35(3), not 26(3). Bradford West Gwillimbury's revocation grounds are eight, section 12.1(a) through (h), not nine. The conservation authority for Richmond Hill is the Toronto and Region Conservation Authority, not the Lake Simcoe Region Conservation Authority. Fixed running costs are corrected to \$19,300 a year from an earlier \$12,800, and electricity to \$6,100 a year on Alectra rather than roughly \$1,500 a year on the wrong utility, since Alectra, not Newmarket-Tay Power, serves Richmond Hill. Money left before loans is corrected to \$4,396, \$33,116 and \$58,505 across the three cases, from a single earlier figure of \$39,616 built on the older, incorrect inputs. One advertiser name is corrected from "Taher Exchange" to Taheri Exchange.

What could not be verified. Your co-founder's immigration status and exact document type need direct, written confirmation from an RCIC or immigration lawyer, since this affects who may legally direct the company. Whenever money moves through a bank in a country with sanctions exposure, confirm in writing whether that bank sits on Canada's sanctions list before relying on those funds. Whether Richmond Hill's Council enacted By-laws 81-26 or 82-26 following the September 16 2026 vote referenced in Council materials was not confirmed in the files read. No willing landlord is currently confirmed for any of the twelve shortlisted Yonge Street lots. No firm, written, Canadian-dollar vendor quote exists yet for a real 10 ft by 20 ft board, every capital cost figure in this file remains a bottom-up estimate rather than a quote. Georgina's and Innisfil's current

billboard counts against their 25 and 45 town-wide caps are not published anywhere found. Whether Eye Candy's East Gwillimbury sign at 22746 Leslie Street is actually permitted or built could not be confirmed against any Town record. Aurora's detailed third-party sign standards sit behind a records system that returned no readable content. WSIB's classification of this specific business, Class L professional services against Class G5 specialty trades construction, has not been confirmed directly with WSIB.

7. Sources

Every source below was read directly, in the September 20 2026 research or the September 21 2026 re-verification, except where a page is noted as blocked or read only through a search extract.

Municipal by-laws. Newmarket 2017-73, <https://www.newmarket.ca/media/file/2017-73-sign-by-law-consolidation>, and the current by-law directory page, <https://www.newmarket.ca/resident-services/by-law-enforcement/by-law-directory/sign-by-law>. East Gwillimbury 2025-052 and 2026-077, <https://www.eastgwillimbury.ca/en/By-law-and-Parking/By-law-2025-052-Sign-By-law.pdf>. Richmond Hill Chapter 740, <https://www.richmondhill.ca/en/shared-content/resources/documents/Community-Standards-By-laws/740---Signs---Updated-April-2026.pdf>. Bradford West Gwillimbury 2011-023, <https://www.townofbwg.com/living-in-bwg/by-laws/frequently-requested-by-laws/sign-by-law-2011-023/>. Innisfil 050-06, <https://innisfil.ca/en/building-and-development/resources/050-06-Sign-By-law.pdf>. Barrie 2018-029, <https://www.barrie.ca/Sign-Bylaw.pdf>, and its 2026 fee schedule, https://www.barrie.ca/Fees-Bylaw_Schedule-B.pdf. Georgina 2006-0062, <https://www.georgina.ca/sites/default/files/2024-03/Sign%20Bylaw%202006-0062%20%28PUT-1%29.pdf>. Vaughan 140-2018, <https://www.vaughan.ca/sites/default/files/2024-02/140-2018%20%28Consolidated%29.pdf>, its December 2025 and 2026 consolidations were only read through search extracts, the PDFs themselves are behind a Cloudflare challenge. Markham 2002-94, <https://www.markham.ca/sites/default/files/2024-06/2002-94-Consolidated---Updated-April-2024.pdf>. King 2018-03, [https://www.king.ca/sites/default/files/uploads/bylaws/2018-03%20-%20Sign%20By-law%20\(revised\).pdf](https://www.king.ca/sites/default/files/uploads/bylaws/2018-03%20-%20Sign%20By-law%20(revised).pdf). Whitchurch-Stouffville 2016-012-RE, <https://whitchurch.civicweb.net/document/109585/>. Aurora 5840-16, <https://records.aurora.ca/WebLink/ElectronicFile.aspx?docid=30869&dbid=0&repo=Public>, read only through a search extract, the live records system requires JavaScript.

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Provincial and federal. Public Transportation and Highway Improvement Act, <https://www.ontario.ca/laws/statute/90p50>. Highway 407 Act, <https://www.ontario.ca/laws/statute/98h28>. MTO Highway Corridor Management, <https://www.ontario.ca/page/highway-corridor-management>. Simcoe County AADT counts, <https://www.simcoe.ca/wp-content/uploads/2026/03/AADT-Summary-2025.pdf>.

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Original brief and prior research. The full source list for the September 20 2026 research, covering Lamar and Outfront SEC filings, MPAC, CCA Class 8, the Land Titles Act, Ad Standards, AGCO and the Statistics Canada language and immigration tables used for the community and advertiser sections, is preserved in `research/brief_snapshot.md`, its own Sources section, and is not repeated here in full. Any figure drawn from that file and not corrected in section 6 above should still be treated as current, since only the items listed in the verification log changed.